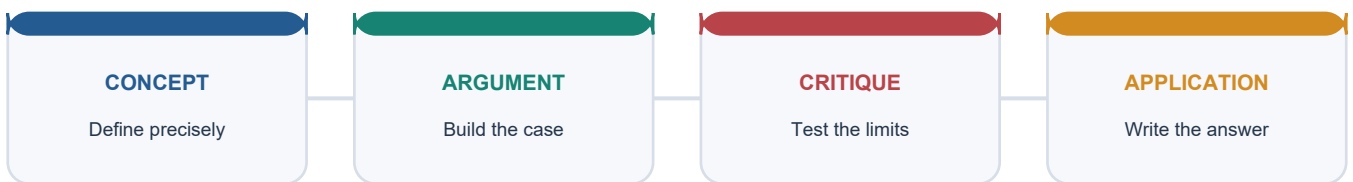


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Religious Experience: Nature and Object - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 18 teaching sessions, 32 diagnostics, 8 solved PYQs, 6 original Mains models and register notes

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Religious Experience: Nature and Object - Learner-v2

Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-06 **Syllabus clause, verbatim:** *Religious Experience : Nature and Object (Indian and Western)*. **Evidence discipline:** doctrine, attribution and previous-year wording are controlled by the repository owner files. Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is never an official UPSC key. **Terminology rule:** English-first throughout. The English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit, Pali, Latin or German term follows in parentheses.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Taught sessions in the Basic block	18
Verified topic-owned previous-year questions	8 (2018-2025, one per year)
Core diagnostic MCQs	24
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)
Consolidated register cards	18
ASCII master flow panels	25

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Exact printed ownership and cross-topic firewall

The printed clause owns the **nature, varieties, claimed object, interpretation and epistemic force of religious experience in Indian and Western thought**.

Owned here	Boundary that is not crossed
phenomenology and typology of mystical, numinous, conversion, devotional and revelatory experience	faith's <i>reception</i> of revelation belongs to the Reason, Revelation and Faith owner
experience as defeasible evidence, and testimony to it	full existence-proofs belong to the Proofs for God owner
conflicting experience-reports used as an epistemic defeater	complete pluralist theory and the absolute-truth debate belong to the Religious Pluralism owner
ineffability, treated only as a phenomenological feature and a communication problem	semantic theories of religious language belong to the Religious Language owner
Indian meditative (<i>yogic</i>), devotional (<i>bhakti</i>), Buddhist and Vedāntic comparisons	complete school doctrines belong to the Paper I canonical owners
prayer and worship, because a printed 2020 question demands them	wider questions about faith, ritual and non-theistic religion retain their own owners
the sacred and the holy as the object-pole of religion	evil and the profane as <i>religion-founding</i> categories belong to the Problem of Evil owner

ANALYSIS: **[FACT]** Three cautions govern the whole clause. "Subjective" means *first-personal*, not unreal. "Ineffable" means that an experience **resists adequate expression**, not that it has no phenomenology or reportable content. And a neural correlate may explain **mediation** without by itself proving either veridicality or illusion. Almost every low-scoring script on this clause fails at one of these three points.

0A. The four analytical layers, and the varieties they classify

PHENOMENOLOGY	->	CLAIMED OBJECT	->	INTERPRETATION	->	EPISTEMIC FORCE
what it is like		what seems given		how a tradition names it		what it justifies, and for whom

Variety	Characteristic structure	Typical attribution
Mystical / unitive	unity, non-duality or communion; often ineffable and noetic	James, Stace, Advaita, theistic mysticism
Numinous	awe before an overwhelming and attracting holiness	Otto's mystery that makes one tremble and yet fascinates (<i>mysterium tremendum et fascinans</i>)
Conversion	reorganisation of a divided self, its orientation and its conduct	James; assessed through enduring fruits
Revelatory	an event or presence received as disclosure	Hick's non-propositional, "experiencing-as" model
Devotional	prayerful address, surrender, love or worship	theistic traditions and the devotional (<i>bhakti</i>) paths
Meditative / disciplined	staged concentration or insight with stated preconditions	Yoga, Buddhist meditation, Vedāntic contemplation

ANALYSIS: **[FACT]** Psychological genuineness, doctrinal authenticity and metaphysical veridicality are **three different achievements**. An experience may be sincere and perfectly tradition-conformable without its claimed object being publicly established.

MEMORY: **The one rule that organises this whole clause.** Every printed question here has a **nature** half and an **object** half. Answer both explicitly, and say whether the object is *encountered* (a relation between two terms) or *realised* (an identity that abolishes one term). That single sentence separates a good script from an average one.

Local source and factual control

- The local *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion*, "Mysticism and Religious Experience," print pp. 138-167 (PDF pp. 150-179), controls the definition of mystical experience, its phenomenology, ineffability and the epistemic models.
- The local Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vol. II, especially PDF pp. 370-445, supports the bounded meditative (*yogic*), Vedāntic and intuitive comparisons. The named work in the 2025 stem remains *The Hindu View of Life* (1927), and its own theses must be used.
- The local John Hick is used only for bounded revelation, interpretation and pluralist links.
- **[FACT]** No neural correlation, psychological mechanism or reported transformation is treated here as automatic proof or disproof of a transcendent object.

Source-complete coverage ledger

[FACT] marks retained repository doctrine or verified question data. **[INFERENCE]** marks learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Owner material	Where it is taught here	Retention decision
Owner Section Section 0, 0A - one-screen map, four layers, varieties	Session 1	Taught in full, with the layer separation made the organising spine
Owner Section 1 - Western accounts (James, Otto, Schleiermacher)	Sessions 2, 3, 4	Split into James's marks, James's method and varieties, and Otto with Schleiermacher

Owner material	Where it is taught here	Retention decision
Owner Section 2, Section 2.1 - Indian accounts and the experience-types bridge	Sessions 7, 8, 9	Taught in full, with Advaita, Radhakrishnan and the four-tradition bridge separated
Owner Section 3 - object and veridicality, interpretation and mediation dispute	Sessions 10, 11, 13	Taught as core ; the mediation grid becomes the perennialism/constructivism session
Owner Section 4 - comparison grid	Session 17 and register card 17	Retained as a ten-row bench
Owner Section 5 - foundational statement bank	Sessions 2, 3, 8 and the quotation-discipline session	Retained in full
Owner Section 6 - applied-question drills; Section 6A parity bench	Sessions 17, 18 and the PYQ practice block	Retained as answer routing and as a six-axis parity bench
Owner Section 7 - model-answer skeletons	Session 18 and the PYQ practice block	Retained and expanded into full solutions
Owner Section Section 9.1-9.5 - doctrine dossiers	Sessions 2, 4, 7, 8, 11	Taught as core doctrine, not as optional enrichment
Owner Section 9.6 - Stace, Zaehner, Katz, Forman	Sessions 5, 6	Taught as core ; the Advanced dossier records its promotion to Core on 15 August 2026
Owner Section 9.7 - prayer and worship (2020 owner-module)	Session 15	Taught as core ; it carries a printed previous-year question
Owner Section 9.8 - public discourse (2019 owner-module)	Session 16	Taught as core ; it carries a printed previous-year question
Owner Section 9.9 - Alston's perceptual model	Session 12	Taught as core ; the Advanced dossier records its promotion to Core
Owner Section 9.10 - sacred and holy as object (2018 owner-module)	Session 10	Taught as core ; it carries a printed previous-year question
Owner Section Section 10-13 - debates, criticisms, traps, keyword bank	Sessions 11, 17, 18 and the register notes	Retained in full
Owner Section Section 14-18 - PYQ routing, answer architecture, directive decoder, verdict ladder, quotation discipline	Session 18 and the PYQ practice block	Retained in full
Advanced dossier Section 6 - four second-order contrasts	Optional Advanced block only	Second-order debate only; no core content depends on it

[INFERENCE] Correction recorded in this repair. The previous edition of this package pasted the whole of owner Section Section 9-19 into the Optional Advanced block as an unedited source dump. Three of those modules - Section 9.7 prayer and worship, Section 9.8 public discourse and Section 9.10 the sacred and the holy - carry **printed previous-year questions** (2020, 2019 and 2018), and the Advanced dossier's own promotion ledger of 15 August 2026 states that the Stace/Zaehner typology and the perceptual model of religious experience "now live in Core and must not be described as Advanced-only". They are therefore taught inside the Basic block, and the Optional Advanced block now carries only genuinely second-order material.

Origin, chronology and anachronism control

A calendar timeline is not the natural shape of this clause: it is a problem in the epistemology of experience, not an institution with a founding date. What *is* required is enough chronology to prevent anachronism, plus the dated print anchors an examiner can be quoted at.

CONCEPTUAL ORIGIN OF THE PROBLEM

- Stage 1 A subject reports an experience that seems to present a sacred or ultimate reality.
- Stage 2 The report is FIRST-PERSONAL: its felt certainty is not transferable as it stands.
- Stage 3 The subject's own tradition supplies the concepts that NAME what was met.
- Stage 4 Other traditions report incompatible objects with equal conviction.
- Stage 5 A test is demanded -> and every candidate test assesses AUTHENTICITY, not the existence of the object.
=> the clause exists because Stages 3, 4 and 5 cannot be waved away.

DATED PRINT ANCHORS (assert these years; invent no others)

- 1902 William James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (Gifford Lectures 1901-02)
- 1912 Emile Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (the sacred/profane pair)
- 1917 Rudolf Otto, *The Idea of the Holy* (Das Heilige)
- 1927 S. Radhakrishnan, *The Hindu View of Life* <== the NAMED work in the 2025 stem
- 1957 R. C. Zaehner, *Mysticism Sacred and Profane*
- 1957 Mircea Eliade, *The Sacred and the Profane* (hierophany; axis mundi)
- 1960 W. T. Stace, *Mysticism and Philosophy*
- 1971 James Rachels, "God and Human Autonomy"
- 1978 Steven Katz, "Language, Epistemology and Mysticism"
- 1979 Eleonore Stump, "Petitionary Prayer", *American Philosophical Quarterly*
- 1991 William Alston, *Perceiving God: The Epistemology of Religious Experience*

CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY AN INVENTED YEAR

- Schleiermacher -> *The Christian Faith* ("feeling of absolute dependence")
- Swinburne -> *The Existence of God* (principle of credulity; principle of testimony)
- Hick -> *Philosophy of Religion* (the Real; experiencing-as)
- Forman -> *The Problem of Pure Consciousness* (the Pure Consciousness Event)
- Aquinas -> *Summa Theologiae* (prayer as a divinely ordained secondary cause)
- Teresa of Avila -> her criteria of discernment Habermas -> the translation proviso
- Indian anchors -> *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* 1.4.10 ("aham brahmasmi");
Taittirīya Upaniṣad 2.4.1 ("yato vaco nivartante");
the navadha bhakti list; *Yoga-sūtra* 1.2, 1.3;
Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy* Vol. II

The rail explains why the clause exists; the dated strip is the only chronology you may assert. Anything in the third block must be cited by work, never by a manufactured year.

ANALYSIS: **[FACT] Anachronism control.** Otto (1917) writes *after* James (1902) and can be read as supplying the object-pole James left open; Stace (1960) writes *after* Zaehner (1957) and is answering him; Katz (1978) writes *after* both and is answering the common-core thesis; Forman answers Katz. Getting this order right is what turns a name-list into an argument.

Learning roadmap

Session	Learner objective
1	Separate phenomenology, claimed object, interpretation and epistemic force
2	Grade James's marks two-plus-two, and say why the grading matters
3	Use James's method - first-person documents, medical materialism, fruits, the "MORE" - and his varieties
4	Reconstruct Otto's numinous, and place Schleiermacher accurately
5	Set Stace's two-fold common core against Zaehner's three-fold denial of one
6	Argue perennialism against constructivism, and locate the Pure Consciousness Event
7	Explain direct realisation (<i>anubhava</i> , <i>aparokṣānubhūti</i>) in Advaita, with the correct terminology
8	Evaluate Radhakrishnan's integral intuition from <i>The Hindu View of Life</i>
9	Compare Advaita, Yoga, devotion and Buddhism on structure, object and control
10	Decide whether the sacred, the holy or God is the object of religion

Session	Learner objective
11	Apply the principle of credulity, testimony, defeaters and the naturalistic critique
12	State Alston's perceptual model at its real strength - and its real limit
13	Handle plural and conflicting experiences, and Hick's mediated Real
14	Relate mystical experience to revelation without identifying them
15	Distinguish prayer from worship and determine the place of each
16	Give a graded answer on religious experience in public discourse
17	Run the Indian-Western parity bench and the ten-row comparison
18	Convert all of it into 10-, 15- and 20-mark scripts

SESSION 1 - THE FOUR LAYERS: PHENOMENOLOGY, OBJECT, INTERPRETATION, WARRANT

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. A religious experience is an experience that its subject takes to be a contact with, an awareness of, or a response to a sacred or ultimate reality.

Technical definition. Philosophically it is analysed on four separable layers: its **phenomenology** (what it is like), its **claimed object** (what seems to be given), its **interpretation** (how a tradition names what was given), and its **epistemic force** (what, and for whom, it justifies).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

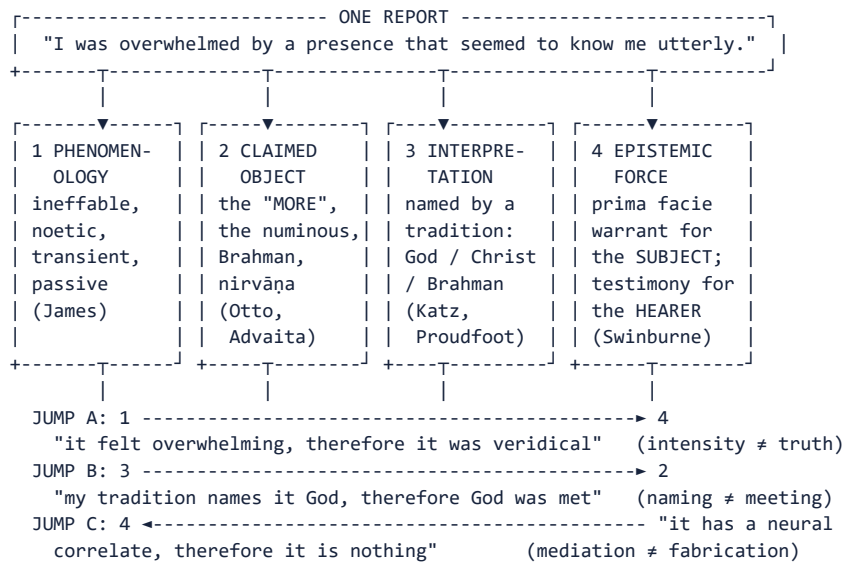
Religious experience may transform the subject completely, and still not convert that private force into public proof of the reality it appears to disclose; the philosophical work lies in separating what happened, what it seemed to be of, how it was named, and what it warrants.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

phenomenology · claimed object · interpretation · epistemic force · veridicality · defeater · first-personal · mediation

How to use them: decide in the first paragraph which layer the stem is buying. "Nature and variety" is layer one. "Sacred and holy as generic names for the object" is layer two. "In the light of the Vedāntic tradition" is layer three. "How far can it be made a topic of public discourse" is layer four. Naming the layer is worth more than any list of thinkers.

VISUAL - THE FOUR LAYERS AND THE THREE ILLEGITIMATE JUMPS



Read the four boxes left to right for the analysis; read the three crossed arrows for the three inferences that lose marks. Almost every weak script commits Jump A; almost every over-confident critic commits Jump C.

TEACHING

[FACT] The layers are separable in principle even where they are fused in practice. A report is delivered already interpreted - the subject uses the only vocabulary they have - but the *analysis* can still ask which features would survive redescription and which would not. That is why a comparative typology is possible at all.

[FACT] The three cautions stated in the clause's preamble do real work here.

1. **Subjective ≠ unreal.** First-personal access is a fact about *how* the state is known, not about whether it occurred. Pain is first-personal and entirely real.
2. **Ineffable ≠ contentless.** James's own use of the term is that the state "defies expression" and must be directly experienced; he then writes two lectures describing it. Ineffability limits **exhaustiveness** of report, not every statement about the state.
3. **Neural correlate ≠ disproof.** Every perception has neural correlates. To convert a mechanism into a defeat, the critic must show that the mechanism is **unreliable**, or that it fully explains the seeming without the proposed object.

[FACT] Three distinct achievements. Psychological genuineness (the subject is sincere and not deceived about having the state), doctrinal authenticity (the state conforms to what the tradition recognises), and metaphysical veridicality (the claimed object exists and was met) are independent. A state may earn the first two and fail the third.

[INFERENCE] The productive framing for the exam is a **ladder of increasing commitment**: description commits you to least, warrant to most. Answer only as far up the ladder as the directive requires, and say explicitly where you stop.

Objection. If interpretation is unavoidable, layer 1 is a fiction: there is no "raw" phenomenology to describe. **Reply.**

[INFERENCE] Conceded that no report is uninterpreted. But comparative typologies work with **reported marks** - objectivity, blessedness, paradoxicality, ineffability - that recur across traditions whose interpretations conflict. The recurrence is data even if the description is never theory-free; that is a weaker claim than a "raw core" and it is the one worth defending.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: The philosophical question about religious experience is not whether it occurs but what it licenses. **Named evidence:** James grants mystical states authority for the one who has them and denies them authority over outsiders; Swinburne's principle of credulity extends defeasible warrant; Alston concedes that no doxastic practice is non-circularly validated. **Analysis:** All three positions accept the occurrence and differ only about transferability, which shows that the live dispute sits on the fourth layer, not the first. **Qualification:** This holds only while phenomenology and interpretation are kept apart; once "what it was like" is reported in the vocabulary of "what it was of", the object has been assumed rather than argued.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not open a religious-experience answer by narrating a mystical episode. Open by naming the layer the stem is about.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not use "subjective" as a term of abuse. Say **first-personal**, and then state precisely what first-personal access does and does not transfer.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not treat neuroscience as either proof or refutation. Correlation identifies mediation; defeat requires an argument about reliability.

MINI RECAP

Four layers - phenomenology, object, interpretation, warrant. Three illegitimate jumps - intensity to truth, naming to meeting, mediation to fabrication. One habit - say which layer you are on.

SESSION 2 - WILLIAM JAMES I: THE MARKS OF MYSTICAL STATES, CORRECTLY GRADED

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. James's "marks" are the recurring features by which he decides whether a reported state counts as mystical at all.

Technical definition. In *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902; Gifford Lectures 1901-02, Lectures XVI-XVII) James gives **two marks that jointly entitle a state to be called mystical** - ineffability and noetic quality - and **two further marks, less sharply defined, that are usually found** - transiency and passivity.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

James's four marks are not four equals: ineffability and noetic quality **settle the classification**, while transiency and passivity merely **accompany** it - and that grading is exactly what allows a stable Indian realisation to count as mystical rather than as a failed mystical episode.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

ineffability (defining) · noetic quality (defining) · transiency (usual) · passivity (usual) · "states of insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect" · authority for the subject

How to use them: write the two-plus-two grading in the *first* body paragraph of any James question. It is the single most reliably rewarded discrimination in this clause.

VISUAL - TWO-PLUS-TWO, NOT FOUR

DEFINING - these two settle the question	
① INEFFABILITY "defies expression" must be DIRECTLY experienced; more like a feeling than a proposition James: the "handiest" mark	② NOETIC QUALITY "states of insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect" carries a curious sense of AUTHORITY = experienced insight, NOT proven
▲ jointly sufficient to call a state mystical	
----- USUAL - present in most cases, not definitional -----	
③ TRANSIENCY cannot be sustained long; may RECUR and DEVELOP	④ PASSIVITY onset may be facilitated by voluntary preliminaries, but once it sets in the mystic feels GRASPED AND HELD by a superior power

WHY THE GRADING PAYS ► a state may be genuinely mystical WITHOUT being brief or wholly passive ► which is exactly the position of Indian liberating knowledge (jñāna): STABLE and ESTABLISHED, not an episode.

A flat four-mark list makes Advaitic realisation look like a defective case.

The double rule marks the logical break. Everything above it is definitional; everything below it is statistical.

TEACHING

[FACT] Mark 1 - ineffability. The state defies adequate expression; its quality must be directly experienced and, being more like a feeling than a proposition, cannot be imparted to one who has not had it. James calls this the "handiest" of the marks - handiest because it is the quickest test to apply.

[FACT] Mark 2 - noetic quality. Mystical states present themselves as **states of knowledge**: "states of insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect," illuminations and revelations carrying a curious sense of authority. ANALYSIS: Noetic quality is *experienced* insight, not independently demonstrated knowledge - the distinction on which the whole veridicality question later turns.

[FACT] Mark 3 - transiency. The state cannot be sustained for long; James notes its characteristic brevity, adding that it may recur and develop on recurrence.

[FACT] Mark 4 - passivity. Although the onset can be facilitated by preliminary voluntary operations, once the state sets in the mystic feels grasped and held by a superior power.

[FACT] The scope restriction. These four marks describe **mystical states**, not every religious experience. Conversion, prayer, worship and ordinary devotional feeling are religious experiences to which the four marks need not apply at all. Writing "James's four marks of religious experience" misstates his own claim.

[FACT] The authority clause. James holds mystical states to be **authoritative for the one who has them**, but to impose **no authority on outsiders**. This is not a stray remark: it is the hinge of the veridicality question, and it is why James cannot be used as a proof of God.

[INFERENCE] Why the grading matters, stated for the examiner. Because transiency and passivity are merely usual, a state that is neither brief nor wholly received can still be mystical. Indian liberating knowledge (*jñāna*) is precisely such a state: it is the settled result of hearing, reflection and contemplation, not a passing seizure. A candidate who lists four equal marks has, without noticing, defined the Indian case out of the category - and then cannot run the comparison the paper actually rewards.

Objection. Ineffability and noetic quality look inconsistent: how can a state be both beyond expression and a state of knowledge? **Reply.** **[FACT/INFERENCE]** James's own usage separates them. Ineffability concerns the **adequacy of report**; noetic quality concerns the **mode of presentation**. A state can present itself as disclosing something while resisting exhaustive articulation, exactly as an unfamiliar taste presents a determinate quality one cannot fully convey. The inconsistency charge only lands if ineffability is read as "no content", which is Trap 3 of this clause.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: James's classification of mystical states is graded, not flat. **Named evidence:** In Lectures XVI-XVII of the *Varieties*, ineffability and noetic quality are the two marks that "entitle" a state to be called mystical, while transiency and passivity are the two "less sharply marked" but usual accompaniments. **Analysis:** The grading does real philosophical work: it decouples the classification from duration and receptivity, so a disciplined, stable realisation remains mystical. **Qualification:** It also fixes James's limit - because the noetic mark is *felt* authority rather than demonstrated knowledge, the same grading that widens the class narrows what the class proves.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Writing a flat list of four equal marks is **the single commonest error in this clause**. It costs the discrimination and it wrecks the Indian comparison.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not apply the four marks to *every* religious experience. They are marks of **mystical states**.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not upgrade "noetic quality" into "knowledge that has been established". James says it *presents itself* as insight and carries a sense of authority.

MINI RECAP

Two defining marks - ineffable, noetic. Two usual marks - transient, passive. One consequence - stable Indian realisation stays inside the category. One limit - felt authority binds only the experienter.

SESSION 3 - WILLIAM JAMES II: METHOD, MEDICAL MATERIALISM, FRUITS, AND THE VARIETIES

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. James's method is to study religion through first-person documents and to judge it by what it does to a life.

Technical definition. It is **empirical** (it takes personal testimony as data), **pragmatic** (it evaluates by consequences, "fruits"), and **anti-reductive** (it refuses "medical materialism", the fallacy of discrediting a state by its physiological or pathological origin).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

James studies religion where it is actually lived - in the documents of individual religious life - and therefore judges it by its fruits rather than by its roots; the price of that method is that it can authenticate a transformation without establishing the reality of the "MORE" the transformation is attributed to.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

medical materialism · fruits ("by their fruits ye shall know them") · personal before institutional · the "MORE" · the subconscious · healthy-mindedness · the sick soul · the divided self · conversion · saintliness

How to use them: the 2022 stem prints *both* "nature" and "variety". The marks answer *nature*; this session answers *variety*. A script that gives only the four marks has answered half a question.

VISUAL - THE VARIETIES, AND THE TWO TESTS JAMES REFUSES AND ACCEPTS

PERSONAL RELIGION (James's unit of study) - institutions come later

HEALTHY-MINDEDNESS	religion of the once-born; evil minimised, harmony affirmed
THE SICK SOUL	acute consciousness of evil, guilt, finitude
THE DIVIDED SELF +→ CONVERSION	inner conflict seeking unification the reorganisation of the divided self: orientation and conduct restructured
SAINTLINESS	the durable moral and affective FRUITS
MYSTICISM	the experiential pole - the four marks

REFUSED TEST: "medical materialism" - discredit a state by its physiological or pathological ORIGIN. Origin ≠ worth ≠ truth.

ACCEPTED TEST: FRUITS - "by their fruits ye shall know them" (Matthew 7:16/20; James ADOPTS the maxim, he does not coin it).

THE OBJECT JAMES ALLOWS HIMSELF: the "MORE" - a wider reality with which the self feels connected THROUGH THE SUBCONSCIOUS. Deliberately under-described, so that the psychology does not smuggle in a theology.

The upper block is the "variety" the 2022 stem demands; the lower block is the method that makes James's evidence admissible and his conclusion modest.

TEACHING

[FACT] Method. James studies **first-person documents** - conversion narratives, mystical reports, letters and confessions - rather than creeds and institutions. Religion for James is **personal before institutional**; theology and ecclesiastical organisation are secondary growths upon it.

[FACT] Medical materialism. This is James's own term (*Varieties*, Lecture I) for the fallacy of dismissing a religious state by pointing at its physiological or pathological origin - Saint Paul's vision as an epileptic discharge, Saint Teresa as a hysteric. His reply is a general epistemic point: **causal origin does not by itself settle truth or worth**, and the same argument would discredit every scientific insight that arrived to a tired or unusual brain.

[FACT] Fruits. The admissible test is consequential: enduring moral integration, courage, charity, the transformation of conduct. James invokes the biblical maxim "by their fruits ye shall know them" (Matthew 7:16/20) **as a criterion he adopts**, not as a phrase he invented. **ANALYSIS:** Attribute the maxim to scripture; attribute the *use* of it as a test to James.

[FACT] The varieties. Healthy-mindedness and the sick soul are two temperaments before evil; the divided self is the condition that conversion resolves; saintliness names the durable fruits; mysticism is the direct experiential pole.

[INFERENCE] These are not a hierarchy but a map of how different temperaments meet the same problem, and preserving that plurality *is* James's "variety".

[FACT] The "MORE". James's own object-term is deliberately thin: the self feels connected, through the **subconscious**, with a wider reality he calls the "MORE". It is a description of what the experience delivers, not an identification of what exists.

[INFERENCE] The exact strength and the exact limit. James's strength is methodological openness - he takes testimony seriously without letting private conviction coerce anyone. His limit follows immediately: good fruits can authenticate a transformation, but they cannot establish that the "MORE" exists, and culturally conflicting experiences sharpen that gap rather than closing it.

Objection. If fruits are the test, a false belief that happens to make people kind is vindicated, and a true belief that makes them miserable is condemned. **Reply. [FACT/INFERENCE]** James can accept this without embarrassment, because fruits are offered as a criterion of **authenticity and value**, not as a deductive proof of the object. The objection succeeds only against a stronger pragmatism than James's text requires here - but it does correctly locate why James cannot function as an argument for God's existence.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: James's pragmatism is a rule of evidence, not a theory of truth about God. **Named evidence:** He rejects medical materialism in Lecture I, adopts the scriptural "by their fruits" maxim as his criterion, and closes with a "MORE" reached through the subconscious. **Analysis:** Refusing origin-based dismissal and accepting consequence-based assessment together license a study of religion that is empirical without being reductive. **Qualification:** The same combination caps his conclusion: consequences can show that a religious life is genuine and valuable while leaving its metaphysical object entirely undetermined.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not credit James with coining "by their fruits ye shall know them". It is Matthew 7:16/20; James adopts it.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the 2022 stem with the marks alone. "Nature **and variety**" is two deliverables.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not turn the "MORE" into God. James keeps it deliberately indeterminate, and saying so earns marks.

MINI RECAP

Empirical, pragmatic, anti-reductive. Refuse medical materialism; accept fruits. Varieties - healthy-minded, sick soul, divided self and conversion, saintliness, mysticism. Object - the "MORE", through the subconscious, and no further.

SESSION 4 - RUDOLF OTTO: THE NUMINOUS, AND WHERE SCHLEIERMACHER BELONGS

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. The numinous is Otto's name for the distinctive religious feeling of standing before something overwhelming, uncanny and yet irresistibly attractive.

Technical definition. In *The Idea of the Holy (Das Heilige, 1917)* Otto isolates the non-rational core of the holy as the **mystery that makes one tremble and yet fascinates** (*mysterium tremendum et fascinans*): mysterious and "wholly other", overwhelming in majesty and power, and at the same time compelling and attractive.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

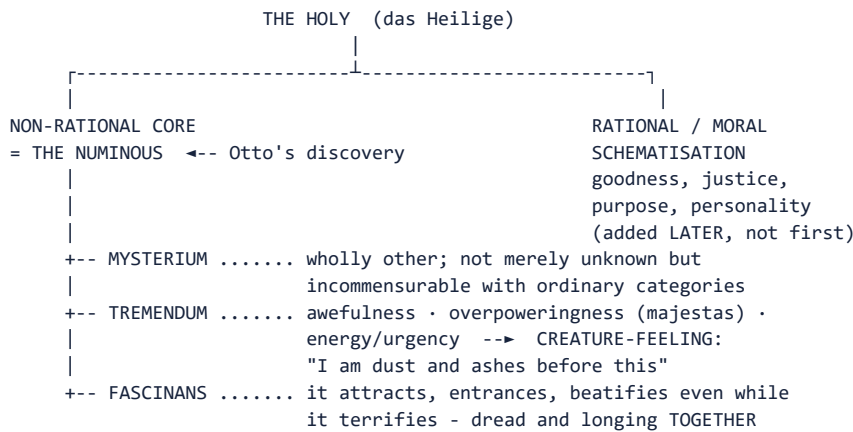
Otto's achievement is to show that the holy is not simply the morally good raised to a maximum: it is a distinct category with its own phenomenology, disclosed in an awe that no ethical predicate exhausts - which is why his account supplies the object-pole that James's psychology deliberately left open.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

numinous · mystery (mysterium) · tremendum · fascinans · wholly other · creature-feeling · non-rational (not irrational) · schematisation · a priori category · Schleiermacher's feeling of absolute dependence

How to use them: always write the Latin in full once - *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* - and then translate it. Then immediately state the "non-rational ≠ irrational" distinction, because that is where the examiner is looking.

VISUAL - THE ANATOMY OF THE NUMINOUS



ANALYSIS: NON-RATIONAL ≠ IRRATIONAL. Non-rational = not reducible to conceptual and moral judgement. Irrational = contradicting reason. Otto claims the first and denies the second.

- SCHLEIERMACHER, for contrast: religion's essence is the FEELING OF ABSOLUTE DEPENDENCE (The Christian Faith). Otto's objection in effect: dependence is a feeling ABOUT MYSELF; the numinous is a feeling of SOMETHING ELSE - it has an object-pole built into it.

Read down the left branch for Otto's analysis; read the right branch for what he says comes afterwards. The bottom band is the comparison the examiner rewards.

TEACHING

[FACT] The object-pole. For Otto the object of religious experience is the **holy / numinous**, experienced as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* - an *a priori*, non-rational awe: overwhelming (*tremendum*), yet fascinating and attracting (*fascinans*), and wholly other.

[FACT] The argument. Ordinary moral predicates do not exhaust holiness. Religious awe displays a distinctive quality disclosed in experience, which is only **later schematised** by rational and ethical concepts. Calling God "good" and "just" is therefore a second operation performed on a prior datum, not the datum itself.

[FACT] Non-rational, not irrational. "Non-rational" means *not reducible to conceptual-moral judgement*. It does not mean contrary to reason. ANALYSIS: This single distinction is the most frequently examined point in any Otto question.

[FACT] Creature-feeling. The canonical example: creature-feeling before the "wholly other" combines dread, humility and fascination in one state. It is not fear of a danger - a danger is a comparable thing - but the sense of one's own nothingness before what is incommensurable.

[FACT] Schleiermacher. Religion's essence, for Schleiermacher (*The Christian Faith*), is the **feeling of absolute dependence**. **[INFERENCE]** Otto's account is usually read as a correction: dependence describes the subject's condition, whereas the numinous is constituted by its object-directedness. Place Schleiermacher as the immediate background, not as an alternative to be listed.

[FACT] The presupposition, stated honestly. ANALYSIS: Otto assumes that the phenomenological distinctiveness of awe supports a distinctive **object**, rather than merely an unusual emotion. That assumption is exactly what the critic denies.

Objection. Psychology can explain awe - evolutionarily, socially, neurologically - without any numinous object at all; Otto has reified a culturally trained emotion. **Reply. [FACT/INFERENCE]** Otto's reply is phenomenological: he describes the **intentional structure** of the state, and intentionality is not an extra feeling but a form. Fear-of-a-tiger is not tiger-flavoured anxiety; it is directed. The reply is genuine but bounded: describing a state as object-directed does not show that the object exists. Say both halves.

[INFERENCE] A real cross-cultural limit. Indian traditions frequently organise the sacred through **purity and auspiciousness** (*pavitra, śuddha, maṅgala*) rather than through dread. Otto's dread-centred phenomenology is therefore not obviously universal, and noticing this converts a description into an evaluation.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Otto establishes the holy as a *sui generis* category rather than an intensification of the moral. **Named evidence:** *The Idea of the Holy* (1917) names the numinous *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* and locates moral and rational predicates as later schematisations of it. **Analysis:** If awe has an intentional structure that ethical vocabulary cannot exhaust, then religion has a datum of its own and is not a department of morality. **Qualification:** The account remains phenomenology: it fixes what the experience is *of* as presented, not that the presentation is satisfied - and the Indian organisation of the sacred through purity rather than dread limits its claim to universality.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Never gloss "non-rational" as "irrational". Otto explicitly claims the first and denies the second.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Otto's **holy** with Durkheim's **sacred** (Session 10). One is a phenomenological quality of an object; the other is a social classification.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not present Otto as a proof of God. He offers a description of the object-pole, and a description is not an existence claim.

MINI RECAP

The holy has a non-rational core - the numinous. *Mysterium + tremendum + fascinans*, felt as creature-feeling before the wholly other. Moral predicates are later schematisations. Non-rational ≠ irrational. Schleiermacher's absolute dependence is the background Otto corrects.

SESSION 5 - STACE AGAINST ZAEHNER: TWO RIVAL TYPOLOGIES OF MYSTICISM

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. A typology of mysticism is an answer to the question: is mystical experience **one thing described differently**, or **several genuinely different things**?

Technical definition. W. T. Stace's *Mysticism and Philosophy* (1960) gives a **two-fold** classification - extrovertive and introvertive - resting on a **common core**. R. C. Zaehner's *Mysticism Sacred and Profane* (1957) gives a **three-fold** classification - nature, monistic, theistic - that **denies** a common core and adds a ranking.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Stace buys cross-cultural unity by relegating difference to interpretation; Zaehner preserves difference at the price of a contested hierarchy - and the defensible position keeps both classifications while dropping Zaehner's ranking.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

extrovertive · introvertive · unitary contentless consciousness · common core · perennialism · experience-versus-interpretation · nature mysticism (pan-en-henic) · monistic · theistic · identity versus relation · confessional ranking

How to use them: typology is the hidden hinge of this clause. It is the question on which pluralism, veridicality and the common-core debate all turn, so a comparison question that never reaches Stace and Zaehner has stopped one level short.

VISUAL - THE TWO SCHEMES, SIDE BY SIDE

----- STACE (1960): 2 TYPES + A COMMON CORE -----	
EXTROVERTIVE	unifying vision achieved THROUGH the senses; the mystic still sees the many, but perceives the ONE SHINING THROUGH them, with an inner subjectivity or life in all things
INTROVERTIVE	ALL sensory and conceptual content EXCLUDED, leaving a unitary, CONTENTLESS pure consciousness - non-spatial, non-temporal. Stace: the higher and more complete type
SHARED MARKS	sense of objectivity/reality · blessedness and peace · feeling of the holy or sacred · paradoxicality · ineffability
METHOD MOVE	separate the EXPERIENCE from its INTERPRETATION; the experiences converge, the interpretations diverge ==> classic PERENNIALIST / COMMON-CORE thesis

DIRECT RIVALS - NOT COMPLEMENTARY

----- ZAEHNER (1957): 3 TYPES + NO COMMON CORE -----	
① NATURE (pan-en-henic, "all-in-one")	oneness with nature; Zaehner controversially places certain drug-induced states here, in explicit opposition to Aldous Huxley's claims for mescaline
② MONISTIC	isolation or identity of the soul with an IMPERSONAL absolute - Sāṃkhya-Yoga's aloneness (kaivalya), Advaita's non-duality
③ THEISTIC	loving union with a PERSONAL God in which the creature/creator distinction is PRESERVED - Rāmānuja, Sufism, Christian mysticism
ANALYSIS: ZAEHNER RANKS THEM,	theistic highest. Widely criticised as confessionally motivated (he was a Catholic convert). State the criticism - and state the real point behind it.

THE REAL POINT BEHIND THE RANKING: monistic and theistic reports differ in LOGICAL FORM - IDENTITY abolishes one term; RELATION requires two. A common-core theory must EXPLAIN that away, not assume it.

Read each panel downward for the scheme; read the bottom band for the argument that survives even after the ranking is discarded.

TEACHING

[FACT] Stace, extrovertive. The unifying vision is achieved *through* the physical senses. The mystic still sees the multiplicity of objects but perceives the **One shining through** them, together with an apprehension of an inner subjectivity or life in all things.

[FACT] Stace, introvertive. All sensory and conceptual content is **excluded**, leaving a **unitary, contentless pure consciousness**, non-spatial and non-temporal. Stace regards this as the higher and more complete type.

[FACT] Stace's shared marks. Both types report: a sense of **objectivity or reality**; **blessedness and peace**; a feeling of the **holy or sacred**; **paradoxicality**; and **ineffability**.

[FACT] Stace's decisive methodological move. He distinguishes the **experience itself** from its **interpretation** and argues that the experiences converge cross-culturally while the interpretations - theistic, monistic, Buddhist - diverge. This is the classic **perennialist / common-core** thesis, and every later dispute in this clause is a dispute about that move.

[FACT] Zaehner's three types. (1) **Nature mysticism** (*pan-en-henic*, "all-in-one"), a sense of oneness with nature, where Zaehner controversially groups certain drug-induced states, explicitly against Aldous Huxley's claims for mescaline. (2) **Monistic mysticism**, the isolation or identity of the soul with an impersonal absolute - Sāṃkhya-Yoga's aloneness (*kaivalya*), Advaita's non-dual realisation. (3) **Theistic mysticism**, loving union with a personal God in which the creature-creator distinction is **preserved** - Rāmānuja, Sufism, Christian mysticism.

[FACT] The ranking, and how to handle it. ANALYSIS: Zaehner ranks the three, treating theistic mysticism as highest and most complete. The ranking is widely criticised as **confessionally motivated**. **[INFERENCE]** The correct exam move is surgical: **keep the classification, drop the ranking** - and then state the genuine philosophical point that survives, namely that identity-reports and relation-reports differ in logical form.

Objection to Stace. "Interpretation" is doing all the work: subtract enough interpretation from any two experiences and they will look alike. **Reply.** **[FACT]** The shared phenomenological marks - objectivity, blessedness, paradoxicality, ineffability - are reported *within* the descriptions, not imposed on them afterwards. **[INFERENCE]** The reply narrows the claim from "identical core" to "recurrent reported marks", which is weaker and more defensible.

Objection to Zaehner. The typology smuggles in a theological ranking. **Reply. [FACT]** The classification can be retained while the ranking is dropped - and usually should be.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Whether mystical experience is one or many is decided by which typology you accept, and each typology carries a price. **Named evidence:** Stace (*Mysticism and Philosophy*, 1960) divides extrovertive from introvertive and grounds a common core in five shared marks; Zaehner (*Mysticism Sacred and Profane*, 1957) divides nature, monistic and theistic and denies any core. **Analysis:** Stace secures cross-cultural unity only by assigning divergence to interpretation, while Zaehner secures difference only by ranking types on a scale his critics trace to his own confession. **Qualification:** The defensible residue keeps Stace's extrovertive/introvertive pair and Zaehner's monistic/theistic pair and discards the hierarchy, because the logical difference between identity and relation is real even when the ranking is not.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Stace and Zaehner into one "typology of mysticism". They are **rivals**: two types with a core, against three types without one.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not report Zaehner's ranking as neutral scholarship, and do not throw out his classification along with it.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the drug-state grouping to Huxley. Zaehner places such states under nature mysticism **against** Huxley's mescaline claims.

MINI RECAP

Stace - extrovertive / introvertive + five shared marks + experience-versus-interpretation + common core. Zaehner - nature / monistic / theistic + no core + a contested ranking. Verdict formula - keep both classifications, drop the hierarchy.

SESSION 6 - PERENNIALISM AGAINST CONSTRUCTIVISM: KATZ, FORMAN AND THE PURE CONSCIOUSNESS EVENT

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Constructivism says your tradition shapes not merely how you *describe* a mystical experience but what the experience *is*. Perennialism says a shared experience underlies the divergent descriptions.

Technical definition. Steven Katz, "Language, Epistemology and Mysticism" (1978), argues that **there are no unmediated experiences**: the mystic's tradition, expectations, concepts and practices enter the experience itself. Robert Forman replies with the **Pure Consciousness Event (PCE)**: a contentless state has nothing for concepts to shape, so the mediation thesis fails exactly at the introvertive limit.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Constructivism is at its strongest precisely where mystical reports are richest and at its weakest precisely where they are emptiest - which is why the whole dispute has come to rest on whether a contentless state is possible at all.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

mediation · "no unmediated experiences" · constructivism · perennialism / common core · Pure Consciousness Event · attribution theory (Proudfoot) · Hick's plural mediation · occurrence versus interpretation versus veridicality

How to use them: this session supplies the *evaluative* move for almost every question in this clause. One sentence of Katz-versus-Forman raises a description into an assessment.

VISUAL - FOUR POSITIONS ON MEDIATION, AND THE PRESSURE ON EACH

POSITION	CLAIM	PRESSURE ON IT
PERENNIAL / COMMON CORE (Stace)	traditions interpret a substantially shared experiential core	subtracting "interpretation" may manufacture an abstract sameness
CONSTRUCTIVISM (Katz 1978)	concepts, expectations and practices shape the EXPERIENCE itself	contentless or minimally conceptual states press the universal claim
ATTRIBUTION (Proudfoot-style)	an experience is RELIGIOUS partly because the subject explains it through a religious scheme	explaining the CLASSIFICATION may not exhaust the phenomenology or object
PLURAL MEDIATION (Hick)	diverse traditions are culturally conditioned responses to ONE Real	an unknowable Real may be too indeterminate to support specific claims

KATZ -----> strong
on EXTROVERTIVE and THEISTIC reports (rich content = much to shape)
KATZ -----> weak
on the INTROVERTIVE limit <-- FORMAN plants the Pure Consciousness
Event exactly here: no content, therefore nothing for concepts to shape.

- THE STRONGEST CONCLUSION separates OCCURRENCE, INTERPRETATION and VERIDICALITY, and refuses to infer any one of them from another.

Read the table for the four positions; read the two arrows for where the central dispute is actually decided.

TEACHING

[FACT] Katz's thesis. There are **no unmediated experiences**. The Jewish mystic does not have a Buddhist experience differently described; they have **different experiences**, because tradition, expectation, conceptual training and practice are constitutive, not merely descriptive.

[FACT] Forman's reply. The **Pure Consciousness Event** is a wakeful state without sensory or conceptual content. By definition it offers nothing for concepts to shape, so Katz's thesis fails at precisely the introvertive limit that Stace called the higher type.

[FACT] The honest verdict. ANALYSIS: Constructivism is very strong for **extrovertive** and **theistic** reports, and weakest for the **contentless** case - which is exactly where its opponents concentrate their evidence. Say this; it is the assessment the examiner wants.

[FACT] Attribution. A Proudfoot-style position holds that an experience counts as religious partly because the subject explains it through a religious scheme. **[INFERENCE]** Its pressure point is that explaining how a state gets *classified* need not exhaust either its phenomenology or its object.

[FACT] Hick's plural mediation. Diverse traditions are culturally conditioned responses to one ultimate **Real** ("the Real *an sich*"), experienced through different lenses. Its pressure point is indeterminacy: a Real that no determinate predicate fits may be unable to ground the determinate claims traditions actually make. (Complete pluralist theory belongs to the Religious Pluralism owner; here it functions only as a reply to diversity.)

[INFERENCE] What follows for warrant. Mediation and fabrication are different. All ordinary perception is mediated by concepts, expectation and training, and we do not conclude that ordinary perception has no objects. Mediation therefore **erodes the inference from convergence** - you can no longer say "everyone reports the same thing, so they met the same thing" - without by itself establishing that the reports are empty.

Objection. If constructivism is right, comparative typologies are worthless, and Stace, Zaehner and Otto were all doing pseudo-science. **Reply.** **[INFERENCE]** Overstated. Comparative work can proceed as the study of **tradition-shaped experience-types**, mapping how different formations produce different structures. What constructivism removes is the perennialist *inference* from typological similarity to a single object - a specific conclusion, not the whole enterprise.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: The mediation dispute does not settle whether religious experience is veridical; it settles what convergence can be used to prove. **Named evidence:** Katz's 1978 thesis that there are no unmediated experiences; Forman's Pure Consciousness Event as the counter-case; Hick's culturally conditioned responses to the Real. **Analysis:** Once experience is conceded to be tradition-shaped, cross-cultural similarity becomes evidence of shared human formation rather than of a shared object, so the perennialist argument loses its inferential step while the reports themselves stand. **Qualification:** Constructivism is not itself a refutation, because mediated perception is still perception; the defensible position separates occurrence, interpretation and veridicality and argues each on its own evidence.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat constructivism as proving that mystical experience is fabricated. It attacks an **inference**, not the occurrence.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present Forman as refuting Katz across the board. He targets the contentless limit case.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not import the full pluralism debate here. Use Hick only as the mediation reply; the theory belongs to the Religious Pluralism owner.

MINI RECAP

Katz - no unmediated experiences. Forman - the Pure Consciousness Event at the contentless limit. Proudfoot - religious by attribution. Hick - plural mediation of one Real. Verdict - mediation defeats the convergence argument, not the experience.

SESSION 7 - INDIAN ACCOUNTS I: DIRECT REALISATION AND ADVAITA

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. In Indian thought the highest religious experience is not a belief about ultimate reality but a **direct realisation of it**.

Technical definition. Direct realisation (*anubhava*; immediate, non-mediated realisation, *aparokṣānubhūti*) is the goal of the whole spiritual path. In Advaita Vedānta it is the non-dual (*nirvikalpa*) recognition in which subject-object duality collapses and the realiser **is** Brahman - "I am Brahman" (*aḥam brahmāsmi*, Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 1.4.10).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Advaitic realisation is not a subject perceiving Brahman as an object but the removal of the ignorance that made subject and object look like two: it is therefore an **identity** where theistic mysticism reports a **relation**, and that difference of logical form is the discriminating point of every Indian-Western comparison in this clause.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

direct realisation (*anubhava*) · immediate realisation (*aparokṣānubhūti*) · non-dual (*nirvikalpa*) · "I am Brahman" (*aḥam brahmāsmi*) · self-established / self-certifying (*svataḥ-siddha*) · beyond objectifying speech (*avācya*) · bliss (*ānanda*) · hearing-reflection-contemplation (*śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*) · stable knowledge (*jñāna*)

How to use them: the 2024 stem asks for "main features". Give an **enumerated feature-list**, and make each feature contrast with a rival account - that contrast is what converts a list into an answer.

VISUAL - THE FEATURE LIST, EACH FEATURE AGAINST ITS RIVAL

FEATURE OF ADVAITIC REALISATION	WHAT IT IS BEING CONTRASTED WITH
① NON-DUAL (<i>nirvikalpa</i>): subject-object duality collapses	theistic mysticism: an encounter between two terms that both remain
② IDENTITY, not relation: "I am Brahman" (<i>aham brahmāsmi</i> , <i>Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 1.4.10</i>)	Otto's "wholly other"; Rāmānuja's loving union that PRESERVES the creature-creator distinction
③ SELF-ESTABLISHED (<i>svataḥ-siddha</i>): self-luminous consciousness is not established by a further cognition	James's noetic mark, which is FELT authority; and Alston's <i>prima facie</i> , defeasible warrant
④ BEYOND OBJECTIFYING SPEECH (<i>avācya</i>): "from which words turn back" (<i>yato vāco nivartante</i>)	ineffability as a mere reporting difficulty; here it is a claim about the STRUCTURE of the object
⑤ BLISS (<i>ānanda</i>), beyond the categories of ordinary cognition	emotional ecstasy; <i>ānanda</i> is ontological, not a mood
⑥ STABLE KNOWLEDGE (<i>jñāna</i>), not an episode	James's TRANSIENCY - which is why his two-plus-two grading matters

THE ROUTE: hearing (*śravaṇa*) → reflection (*manana*) → contemplation (*nididhyāsana*) → realisation. Instruction PREPARES and REMOVES; it does not manufacture.

THE IMAGE: the tenth man - the counter forgets to count himself and grieves for a man who was never lost; instruction removes the ignorance of an ALREADY PRESENT fact.

ANALYSIS: TERMINOLOGICAL FIREWALL: do NOT call this experience *anirvacanīya*.

In Advaita's technical vocabulary *anirvacanīya* ("indescribable as either real or unreal", *sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*) is the status of *MĀYĀ* and the world-appearance - never of Brahman or of Brahman-realisation.

Read the left column for the 2024 feature-list; read the right column for the discriminator that must accompany each feature. The firewall box is a scripted trap in this clause.

TEACHING

[FACT] Direct realisation. In Indian thought the highest religious experience is **immediate, intuitive realisation** (*anubhava* / *aparokṣānubhūti*), not mere belief. It is the terminus of the path, and it is soteriological: it is assessed by whether it removes ignorance and bondage, not by its intensity.

[FACT] The Advaita features. (i) Non-dual (*nirvikalpa*) experience - the collapse of subject-object duality; the realiser is Brahman. (ii) **Self-established / self-certifying** (*svataḥ-siddha*). (iii) Beyond objectifying speech (*avācya*; "from which words turn back", *yato vāco nivartante*). (iv) Bliss (*ānanda*), beyond the categories of ordinary cognition. (v) **Not a relation to an object but identity** - which is what distinguishes it from theistic, dualistic mysticism.

[FACT] The argument behind the claim. Subject-object cognition presupposes a **witnessing consciousness** that is never itself an object; scripture (*śruti*) removes false identification; and disciplined inquiry culminates in the recognition that the self (*ātman*) is Brahman. The presupposition is that consciousness is **self-revealing and non-objectifiable**, and that non-dual testimony can remove ignorance.

[FACT] The canonical example. The **tenth-man story**: instruction does not create the missing person but removes ignorance of an already present fact. This is the exact model of how *śruti* is supposed to work - removal, not production.

[FACT] Stability over ecstasy. It is not a temporary altered state alone; **stable knowledge (*jñāna*) matters more than episodic ecstasy**. **[INFERENCE]** This is the point at which James's grading of his marks becomes indispensable: because transiency is only a *usual* mark, established *jñāna* is not disqualified from the mystical category.

[FACT] The terminological firewall. ANALYSIS: Do **not** call Advaitic realisation *anirvacanīya*. That term denotes the status of *māyā* and the world-appearance as "indescribable as either real or unreal" (*sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*), not the status of Brahman or of its realisation. A 2025 Religious Language question prints *anirvacanīyatā* in its own proper sense; importing it here is a scripted error.

Objection. A contentless experience cannot identify Brahman: if nothing determinate is given, nothing determinate is known. **Reply. [FACT]** Advaita answers that Brahman is not an inferred object at all but the **self**, and that conceptual instruction *prepares* a non-objective recognition rather than delivering an object to inspect. **[INFERENCE]** The reply is internally coherent but pays a price the examiner rewards you for naming: it removes the experience from the space of ordinary evidence, so it cannot then be re-entered as public evidence for Brahman.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: The main feature of Advaitic religious experience is that it is a recognition of identity, not an encounter with an object. **Named evidence:** *Aham brahmāsmi* (Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 1.4.10) states the identity; the *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* sequence supplies the discipline; the tenth-man analogy models instruction as removal of ignorance. **Analysis:** Because the realisation is of the self as self-luminous, it cannot be described as a subject cognising Brahman, and its self-establishment (*svataḥ-siddha*) is therefore a structural claim, not a report of confidence. **Qualification:** The same structure limits its public force: an experience defined as non-objective cannot be checked by the procedures that check objects, which is precisely what the diversity objection exploits.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not describe Advaitic experience as "a subject perceiving Brahman as object". That is the error the whole doctrine is designed to exclude.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not use *anirvacanīya* for Brahman or for Brahman-realisation. It belongs to *māyā*.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not translate *ānanda* as "happiness" or "ecstasy". It is bliss as a structural feature, not a mood.

MINI RECAP

Direct realisation (*anubhava* / *aparokṣānubhūti*). Six features - non-dual, identity, self-established, beyond objectifying speech, bliss, stable. Route - hearing, reflection, contemplation. Image - the tenth man. Firewall - *anirvacanīya* belongs to *māyā*.

SESSION 8 - INDIAN ACCOUNTS II: RADHAKRISHNAN'S INTEGRAL INTUITION, AND VEDĀNTIC PLURALITY

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. For Radhakrishnan, religion begins in a direct spiritual experience of the Real; creeds, rituals and institutions are later interpretations of it.

Technical definition. Religious experience is **integral intuition** (*anubhava*): a knowing that unites cognition, feeling and will, higher than sense and reason because it does not divide subject from object, and **self-certifying** in the sense that it does not await confirmation from a further cognition.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Radhakrishnan inverts the usual order of religion: dogma does not generate experience, experience generates dogma - and the strength of that inversion is also its exposure, since an experience made prior to every creed can no longer be corrected by any of them.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

integral intuition · direct spiritual experience (*anubhava*) · self-certifying · experience prior to dogma · The Hindu View of Life (1927) · universality across traditions · spiritual humanism · Advaitic assimilation (the objection)

How to use them: the 2025 stem names the work. **Name its own theses before criticising them** - fidelity first, evaluation second. That order is what "Evaluate ... as explained by ... in *The Hindu View of Life*" is buying.

VISUAL - THE INVERSION, AND WHERE IT IS ATTACKED

ORDINARY PICTURE

creed --> practice -->
experience as confirmation

THE THREE CLAIMS TO NAME

- ① experience is PRIMARY
- ② it is SELF-CERTIFYING
- ③ it is UNIVERSAL across traditions

RADHAKRISHNAN'S INVERSION

EXPERIENCE (anubhava)

| integral intuition:
| cognition + feeling + will



INTERPRETATION by a tradition

| concepts, symbols, myth



CREED · RITUAL · INSTITUTION

| "secondary", revisable



TOLERANCE follows as a CONSEQUENCE:
rival creeds are rival readings of a
depth none of them owns

THE THREE PRESSURES TO STATE

- ① prior-to-all-creeds = correctable by none
- ② self-certification is exactly what an outsider cannot check
- ③ "one depth, many readings" is a substantive metaphysics that theists and Buddhists reject - the ADVAITIC ASSIMILATION charge

Left, the reversal; right, the two columns an evaluation question requires you to run against each other.

TEACHING

[FACT] The doctrine. Religion is grounded in **direct, intuitive spiritual experience of the Real (anubhava)**, which is **self-certifying** and universal across traditions; dogma and ritual are **secondary interpretations** of this core experience. Religious experience is **integral intuition** - a knowing that unites, higher than sense and reason.

[FACT] The argument. Discursive reason divides subject and object and therefore cannot deliver the Real as it is; religious intuition **integrates** cognition, feeling and will; and cross-traditional spiritual transformation is offered as evidence of a common experiential depth.

[FACT] The presupposition. ANALYSIS: That intuition can **disclose reality**, rather than merely report subjective intensity. State this explicitly; it is the load-bearing assumption.

[FACT] The distinction that protects him. Radhakrishnan's "intuition" is **not a hunch**. It is claimed as disciplined, integral and transformative awareness - the product of a practice, not a flash of feeling.

[FACT] The canonical use. Diverse doctrinal formulations can be treated as **interpretations of a common realised depth**, which is how the position generates a principled religious tolerance rather than a merely polite one.

[FACT] The standing objection. ANALYSIS: The account may **privilege Advaitic unity and assimilate theistic difference**. The reply is that universality concerns experiential *depth*, not identical doctrinal description - and **[FACT]** the adequacy of that reply remains contested. Report the contest; do not resolve it by fiat.

[INFERENCE] Vedāntic plurality, which the 2021 stem requires. "The Vedāntic tradition" is not one voice. Śaṅkara's Advaita makes the highest realisation a **non-objective recognition of identity**. Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita rejects the erasure of difference: Brahman is personal, selves and world are real modes dependent on God, and fulfilment is loving knowledge and communion in which the worshipper is **not** dissolved. Madhva's Dvaita hardens the distinction further: God and soul remain eternally different and saving experience is a grace-enabled relation. **Vedānta therefore contains both identity-recognition and intentional encounter**, and a script that reduces "Vedāntic experience" to Advaita has misread the printed word "tradition".

[INFERENCE] The epistemic status varies with the school. Advaita calls realisation self-certifying because self-luminous consciousness is not established by a second cognition. The devotional schools place more weight on scripture, grace and the transformed relation of dependence. In every case, however, the test is **soteriological** - does it remove ignorance, egoism and bondage - and that is what distinguishes Vedāntic *anubhava* from an unregulated private impression.

Objection. If each school's disciplined practice and conceptual grammar identifies the experience, then "Vedāntic experience" is doctrinal interpretation imposed on ambiguous states. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The right response is not

to manufacture a flat common core. It is to concede mediation and deny that mediation is fabrication: each school supplies a practice, a grammar and tests of transformation by which experience is identified. But those criteria are **internal**, and internal criteria do not by themselves prove the metaphysical object to an outsider.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Radhakrishnan makes spiritual experience the source of religion and creeds its derivatives. **Named evidence:** *The Hindu View of Life* (1927) treats direct intuitive experience of the Real as primary and self-certifying, with dogma and ritual as secondary interpretations, and grounds tolerance in that priority. **Analysis:** The inversion explains both religious diversity and the possibility of inter-religious respect without requiring doctrinal agreement, because the divergence is relocated from the experience to its expression. **Qualification:** It also purchases universality at a cost his critics press: an experience placed prior to all creeds cannot be corrected by any of them, and the "one depth" claim reads suspiciously like Advaita generalised into a neutral framework.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: In a 2025-type stem, do not answer from generic "Indian spirituality". The **named work** must supply the theses.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not equate Radhakrishnan with Śaṅkara. He is an interpreter working after and beyond classical Advaita, and the assimilation charge is precisely about that gap.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not reduce "the Vedāntic tradition" to Advaita in a 2021-type stem. Rāmānuja and Madhva are inside the tradition and report a different structure.

MINI RECAP

Experience first, creed second. Integral intuition - cognition, feeling and will united. Self-certifying and claimed universal. *The Hindu View of Life* (1927). Objection - Advaitic assimilation; reply - depth not description; verdict - contested.

SESSION 9 - THE INDIAN EXPERIENCE-TYPES BRIDGE: ADVAITA, YOGA, DEVOTION, BUDDHISM

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. "Indian religious experience" names at least four different structures, not one.

Technical definition. Advaita reports **identity**; classical Yoga reports **isolation** of consciousness; devotional traditions report a **relation** to a personal Lord sustained by grace; Buddhism reports **insight** into impermanence, no-permanent-self and conditioned arising, oriented to cessation rather than to a creator.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

There is no single "Indian mysticism": identity, isolation, relation and insight are four different logical structures with four different termini, and collapsing them into one is the Indian counterpart of the flat four-mark error about James.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

identity · isolation (kaivalya) · relation and grace · insight · consciousness (puruṣa) · cessation (nirvāṇa) · impermanence · no-permanent-self (anātman) · conditioned arising (pratītyasamutpāda) · tradition-mediated

How to use them: this bridge is what makes an "Indian and Western" comparison specific instead of decorative. Use it, then stop: complete school doctrine belongs to the Paper I owners.

VISUAL - FOUR STRUCTURES, FOUR TERMINI, FOUR CONTROLS

TRADITION	EXPERIENCE-STRUCTURE	CLAIMED TERMINUS	CONTROL
ADVAITA	non-dual recognition through hearing, reflection and contemplation	the self AS Brahman	NOT an encounter between two independently existing terms
YOGA	disciplined concentration culminating in seedless absorption and discriminative freedom	isolated consciousness (puruṣa)	Yoga's special Lord is NOT the creator-object of every experience
DEVOTIONAL (bhakti)	love, surrender, remembrance, prayer and worship	a personal Lord	relation and grace remain REAL - do not redescribe as Advaitic identity
BUDDHISM	meditative insight into impermanence, no-permanent-self and conditioned arising	Dharma / cessation (nirvāṇa) - NOT a creator God	noetic and transformative claims remain tradition-mediated

LOGICAL FORMS: identity (one term) | isolation (one term, withdrawn) | relation (two terms) | insight (no term of that kind at all)

ANALYSIS: THE BRIDGE IS A BRIDGE. Meditation stages, liberation doctrine and school metaphysics remain with the relevant Paper I owners. Cross it; do not camp on it.

Columns one to three give the comparison; column four gives the control that stops each comparison from being over-read.

TEACHING

[FACT] Advaita. Non-dual recognition, reached through hearing, reflection and contemplation, whose terminus is the self as Brahman. The control: it is **not** an encounter between two independently existing terms.

[FACT] Yoga. Disciplined concentration culminating in seedless absorption and discriminative freedom, whose terminus is **isolated consciousness** (*puruṣa*). The control: Yoga's special Lord is not the creator-object of every experience.

[FACT] Devotional traditions. Love, surrender, remembrance, prayer and worship, whose terminus is a **personal Lord**. The control: relation and grace remain real and must not be redescribed as Advaitic identity.

[FACT] Buddhism. Meditative insight into impermanence, no-permanent-self and conditioned arising, oriented to **Dharma and cessation (nirvāṇa)** rather than to a creator God. The control: its noetic and transformative claims remain tradition-mediated.

[INFERENCE] Why the four controls matter more than the four rows. Anyone can list four traditions. The marks are in the controls, because each control blocks a specific misreading that an examiner is watching for: dualising Advaita, theologising Yoga, Advaitising devotion, and theologising Buddhism. A Buddhist "object" is especially treacherous, since the very category of an object to be encountered may mislead.

[INFERENCE] The comparative payoff. These four structures put real pressure on both Stace and Zaehner. Zaehner's monistic/theistic pair captures Advaita against devotion but has no comfortable slot for Buddhist insight, where there is no absolute to be identical with and no person to relate to. Stace's introvertive type captures something of Advaita and of certain meditative states but must then treat the traditions' own descriptions of their termini as mere interpretation - which is exactly Katz's objection.

Objection. These are four doctrinal *descriptions*, not four experiences; the differences may live entirely in the theology. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** Partly conceded - and this is why the constructivism session comes first. But the differences are not only doctrinal: the practices differ, the preconditions differ, the reported before-and-after differ, and a devotional tradition that treats grace as ineliminable is describing a different *practice*, not just applying a different label. Concede the mediation; refuse the reduction.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Indian religious experience is plural in structure, not merely in vocabulary. **Named evidence:** Advaita reports identity with Brahman; classical Yoga reports the isolation of consciousness (*puruṣa*); devotional traditions report a graced relation to a personal Lord; Buddhism reports insight into conditioned arising terminating in cessation (*nirvāṇa*). **Analysis:** These are four different logical forms - identity, withdrawal, relation and insight - so any claim of a single Indian mystical core must explain, not assume, their convergence. **Qualification:** The comparison is bounded: it is a bridge for this clause, and complete school doctrine remains with the Paper I owners.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not write "Indian mysticism" as though it were one position. Name the structure.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not give Buddhism a divine object in order to make the comparison tidy.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not expand this session into a Paper I answer on Yoga or Vedānta. It is a comparison bridge.

MINI RECAP

Four structures - identity, isolation, relation, insight. Four termini - Brahman-as-self, *puruṣa*, the personal Lord, cessation. Four controls - no two terms, no creator-Lord, no Advaitised devotion, no theologised Buddhism.

SESSION 10 - THE OBJECT: SACRED, HOLY, AND WHETHER GOD CAN BE IT (2018 OWNER-MODULE)

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. The "object of religion" is whatever ultimate reality, power, state or value religious life is directed towards.

Technical definition. Three generic candidates compete: Otto's **holy**, a phenomenological quality disclosed in numinous awe; Durkheim's **sacred**, a social classification defined relationally against the profane; and Eliade's **sacred**, which manifests (*hierophany*) and thereby structures space and time. "God" is the theistic candidate for the same slot.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

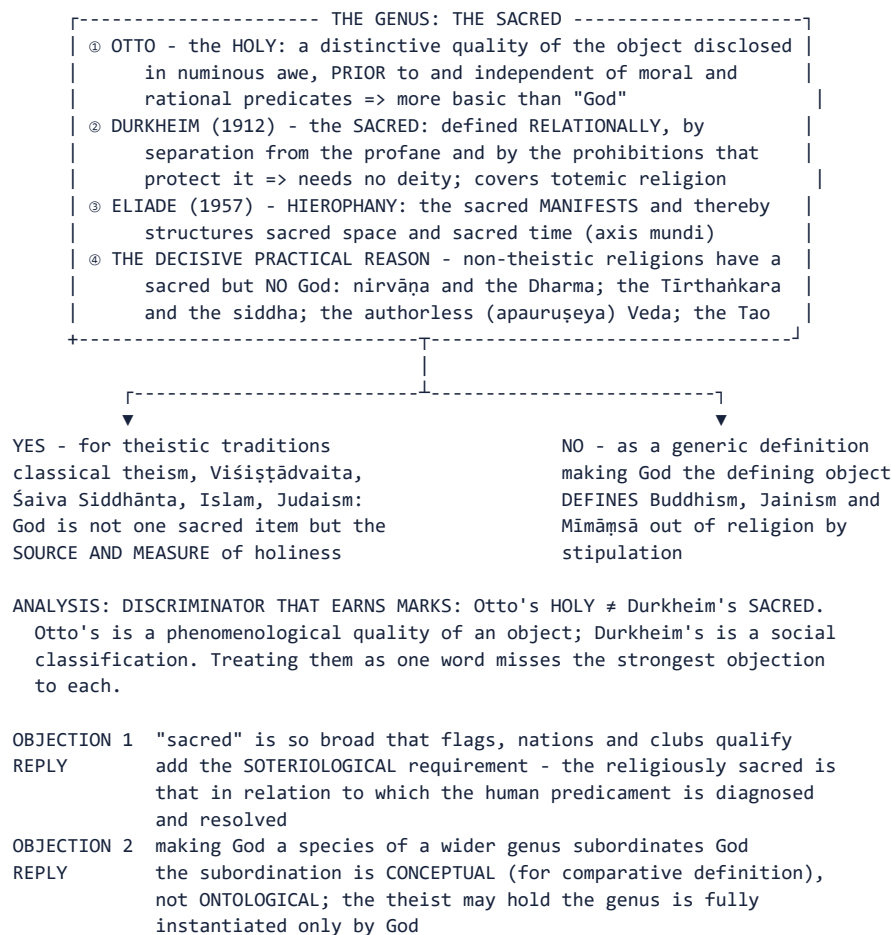
"Sacred" is the **genus**; God is theism's **species** of it - which is why one can certainly have God as the object of religion, and why one cannot make God the *definition* of it without stipulating Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā out of religion altogether.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

sacred · holy · profane · hierophany · axis mundi · wholly other · generic versus paradigm · source and measure of holiness · non-theistic religions · soteriological condition · pure (pavitra, śuddha) · auspicious (maṅgala) · meritorious (puṇya) · crossing-place (tīrtha) · authorless Veda (apauruṣeya)

How to use them: the 2018 stem **grants** the generic category and asks about the specific one. The answer must therefore be **graded**, never yes/no - and the grading is the marks.

VISUAL - THE GENUS, THE SPECIES, AND THE TWO OBJECTIONS



Top panel: why the generic term won. Middle: the graded answer, both halves. Bottom: the discriminator and the two objections that must be answered.

TEACHING

[FACT] The exact stem structure (2018, Q7(a), 20 marks). "The terms 'Sacred' and 'Holy' have come to serve as generic names for the object of religion. **Do you agree that one can have God as the object of religion?**"

ANALYSIS: It grants the generic category and asks whether the specific one can also serve. Answer in degrees.

[FACT] Why 'sacred/holy' became generic. (1) **Otto**: the holy names a distinctive quality of the object disclosed in numinous awe, prior to and independent of moral and rational predicates. (2) **Durkheim** (1912): the sacred is defined **relationally**, by separation from the profane and by the prohibitions that protect it - a definition needing no deity, covering totemic religion. (3) **Eliade** (1957): the sacred manifests (*hierophany*) and thereby structures space and time; the sacred is "the opposite of the profane". (4) The decisive practical reason: **non-theistic religions have a sacred but no God** - *nirvāṇa* and the Dharma, the Tīrthaṅkara and the *siddha*, the authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda, the Tao.

[FACT] The graded answer. (i) **Yes, for theistic traditions:** for classical theism, Viśiṣṭādvaita, Śaiva Siddhānta, Islam and Judaism, God is not merely *an* instance of the sacred but its **source and measure** - everything else is holy by relation to God. (ii) **But not as a generic definition**, since that stipulates whole religions out of the category. (iii) The correct relation: **'sacred' is the genus, God one species** of it, the personal-theistic species.

[FACT] The discriminator. ANALYSIS: Otto's holy is **not** identical with Durkheim's sacred. Otto's is a phenomenological quality of an object; Durkheim's is a social classification. A candidate who treats them as one word misses the strongest objection to each.

[FACT] Indian parity. Pure (*pavitra*, *śuddha*), auspicious (*maṅgala*), meritorious (*puṇya*), crossing-place (*tīrtha* - Eliade's sacred space in Indian dress), sacred field (*kṣetra*), temple (*devālaya*); sacred time in *parvan* days, *muhūrta* and the ritual calendar; and the sanctity of the Veda as **authorless** (*apauruṣeya*) - sanctity without a sanctifier.

ANALYSIS: Indian traditions often organise the sacred through **purity and auspiciousness** rather than through Otto's dread, which is a genuine limit on Otto's cross-cultural claim.

[INFERENCE] A refinement on the word "object". In theistic mysticism and prayer God is the intentional pole of address, not a finite item passively inspected; in Advaita and in Radhakrishnan the ultimate is realised as the depth of the self rather than confronted; in Buddhism substantial "object" language may itself mislead. Comparative philosophy therefore needs "object" to mean **the ultimate intentional or soteriological pole**, not invariably a separately existing person.

Objection 1. "Sacred" becomes so broad that flags, nations and football clubs qualify, and the category loses content.

Reply. [FACT] Add the requirement of a **soteriological relation**: the sacred in religion is that in relation to which the human predicament is diagnosed and resolved. That excludes mere collective sentiment.

Objection 2. Treating God as one species of the sacred subordinates God to a wider genus, which theists will reject.

Reply. [FACT] The subordination is **conceptual**, for purposes of comparative definition, not **ontological**; the theist may consistently hold that the genus is fully instantiated only by God.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: God can be the object of religion, but cannot be its generic definition. **Named evidence:** Otto's holy, Durkheim's relational sacred (1912) and Eliade's hierophany (1957) supply a category that covers *nirvāṇa*, the Tirthaṅkara and the authorless Veda, none of which is a God. **Analysis:** Since a definition must cover the definiendum, a God-centred definition fails by excluding recognised religions, whereas a sacred-centred definition includes theism as its paradigm case without loss. **Qualification:** The genus must be restricted by a soteriological condition or it will admit flags and nations; and the theist's protest is answered by noting that the subordination is conceptual, not ontological.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not answer 2018 with a flat yes or a flat no. The stem's structure demands a graded verdict.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Otto's holy with Durkheim's sacred - the single highest-yield discriminator in this module.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the non-theistic cases. They are the *reason* the generic term exists, not decoration.

MINI RECAP

Genus: the sacred (Otto's holy, Durkheim's relational sacred, Eliade's hierophany, plus the non-theistic religions).
Species: God, for theism, as source and measure. Discriminator: holy ≠ sacred. Two objections: over-breadth, answered by soteriology; subordination, answered as conceptual.

SESSION 11 - VERIDICALITY I: CREDULITY, TESTIMONY, DEFEATERS AND THE NATURALISTIC CRITIQUE

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. The veridicality question asks whether a religious experience is *of* a real object or merely a state of the subject.

Technical definition. The standard pro-veridicality apparatus is Swinburne's **principle of credulity** (if it seems to a subject that X is present, then probably X is present, absent special considerations) extended by a **principle of testimony** (others' reports are probably as they report, absent special considerations); the standard anti-veridicality apparatus is a set of **defeaters** - naturalistic explanation, unreliable conditions, and the diversity of incompatible reports.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

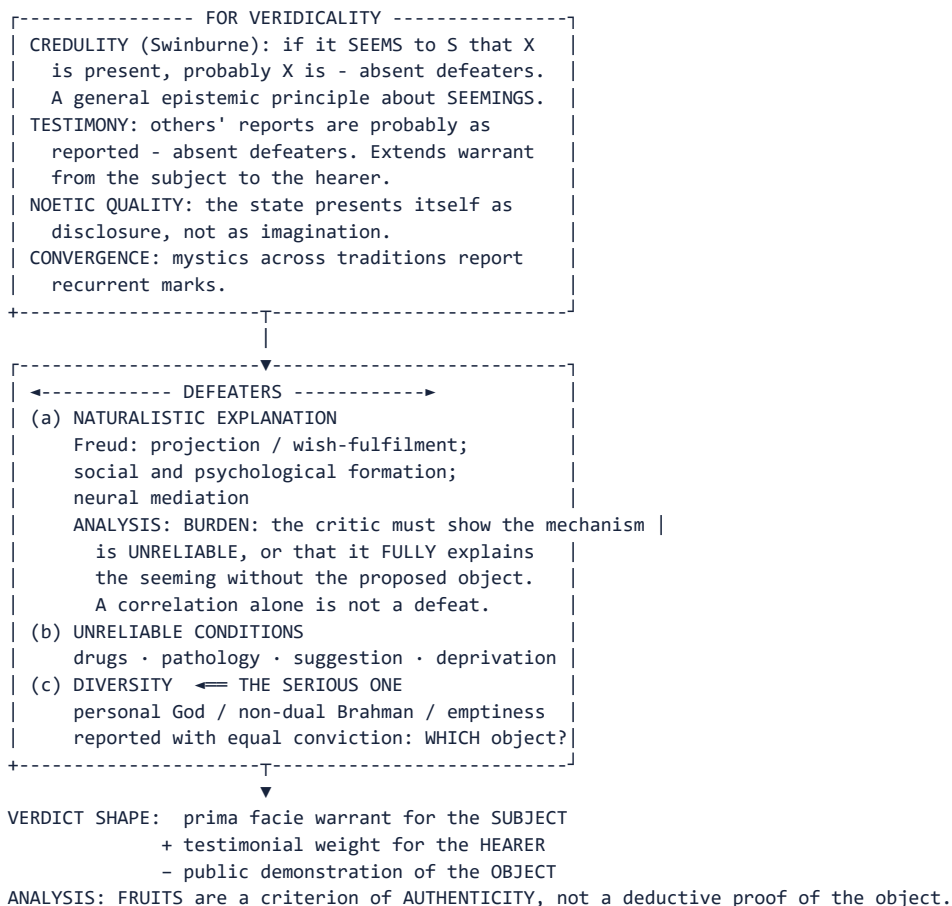
Religious experience confers *prima facie*, defeasible justification on the subject and testimonial weight on the hearer; it does not establish its object publicly - and **diversity, not neurology, is the serious defeater**, because causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

principle of credulity · principle of testimony · prima facie versus ultima facie · defeater · projection and wish-fulfilment (Freud) · neural correlate · unreliability requirement · convergence of mystics · fruits as authenticity not proof

How to use them: the phrase to deploy is "causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things". It is the most efficient single sentence in the whole clause.

VISUAL - THE WARRANT LEDGER



Top block, the credit side; middle block, the debit side with the burden that each defeater must discharge; bottom, the balance to write as your verdict.

TEACHING

[FACT] The object, tradition by tradition. Theistic traditions -> a **personal God**; Advaita -> **Brahman / ātman**, non-dual; Otto -> the **numinous / holy**; Buddhism -> insight oriented to Dharma and cessation (*nirvāṇa*), not encounter with a personal creator.

[FACT] The case for veridicality. The **principle of credulity** - if it seems to one that X is present, probably X is, absent defeaters; the **noetic quality** of the state; and the **convergence** of mystics.

[FACT] The case against. Naturalistic explanations - Freud's projection and wish-fulfilment, social and psychological formation, neural mediation - and the **diversity** of experiences across religions, which raises the question of which object is real.

[FACT] The burden clause, which most scripts miss. ANALYSIS: A causal or neural correlation is **not automatically an epistemic defeat**: the critic must show either that the mechanism is **unreliable**, or that it **fully explains the seeming without the proposed object**. Explaining neural correlation does not by itself explain away the putative object.

[FACT] What the pro-side actually gets. Religious experience supplies **prima facie but defeasible** warrant when phenomenology, subject reliability, coherence and fruits survive the defeaters. The presupposition is that perceptual and religious seemings are sufficiently analogous - which is exactly what the critic questions.

[FACT] The four standard criticisms and their replies. (1) **Naturalistic explanation:** neurology, deprivation or suggestion can produce experiences - reply: origin does not by itself falsify content; defeaters must show unreliability. (2) **Conflicting objects:** traditions report incompatible realities - reply: interpretation may vary while contact is common; **rejoinder:** this reply can become unfalsifiable. (3) **Ineffability:** if indescribable, no doctrinal inference follows - reply: partial analogical report remains possible; ineffability limits exhaustiveness, not every statement. (4) **Moral fruits:** good effects do not prove metaphysical truth - reply: fruits are a criterion of authenticity, not a deductive proof of the object.

[INFERENCE] Ranking the defeaters, which is what earns the top band. Naturalistic explanation is the *loudest* defeater and the weakest, because it must discharge the unreliability burden and usually cannot. Diversity is the *quietest* and the strongest, because it does not need to show that any mechanism is unreliable: it only needs to observe that mutually incompatible objects are reported with identical conviction, so the credulity principle, applied evenly, licenses contradictions.

Objection. The principle of credulity is question-begging: it grants religious seemings the same standing as perceptual ones and thereby assumes the analogy in dispute. **Reply.** **[INFERENCE]** Swinburne's defence is that any *restriction* of the principle to sense-perception is arbitrary and would, applied consistently, undermine memory and other minds. The reply has force, but it buys only *prima facie* standing - and *prima facie* standing is exactly what the diversity defeater then attacks.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Religious experience gives the subject defeasible warrant and gives the public no demonstration. **Named evidence:** Swinburne's principles of credulity and testimony supply the positive case; Freud's projection thesis and the cross-tradition conflict of a personal God with non-dual Brahman and with emptiness supply the two defeaters. **Analysis:** Because the naturalistic defeater must additionally show unreliability while the diversity defeater need show only incompatibility, the second is the stronger, and a verdict that concentrates on neuroscience has attacked the weaker case. **Qualification:** None of this touches the occurrence of the experience or its transformative value; what it limits is the inference from seeming to object.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not infer truth from intensity, sincerity or moral transformation. Fruits authenticate; they do not demonstrate.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat a neural correlate as a refutation. Name the unreliability burden.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse Swinburne's credulity principle with Alston's practice argument (Session 12). One is about seemings; the other is about socially established practices.

MINI RECAP

Credit - credulity, testimony, noetic quality, convergence. Debit - naturalism (with a burden), unreliable conditions, diversity (the serious one). Balance - *prima facie* for the subject, testimonial for the hearer, no public demonstration.

SESSION 12 - VERIDICALITY II: ALSTON'S PERCEPTUAL MODEL AND DOXASTIC PRACTICES

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Alston argues that some religious experience really is a kind of perceiving - a direct awareness of God *appearing* to the subject - and that beliefs formed on it are innocent until proven guilty.

Technical definition. In *Perceiving God: The Epistemology of Religious Experience* (1991) William Alston holds that mystical perception shares perception's structure, that beliefs formed on it ("**M-beliefs**", from mystical perception) enjoy *prima facie* justification, and that engagement in an established **doxastic practice** is **practically rational** even though no such practice can be validated non-circularly.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Alston's achievement is to shift the burden: the sceptic must show what makes religious practice *relevantly worse* than sense perception, rather than simply demanding a non-circular proof that no practice whatever can supply - and his own concession, that religious diversity has no non-circular resolution, is where the argument stops and an honest answer stops with it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

mystical perception (M-perception) · M-beliefs · the theory of appearing · doxastic practice · socially established practice · epistemic circularity · prima facie versus ultima facie · practical rationality (not proof) · Christian Mystical Practice · "sit tight" · override systems

How to use them: the single most common misreport in this clause is that Alston "proves religious experience reliable". He does not. State what he actually claims and you have already outperformed most scripts.

VISUAL - THE SIX-STEP ARGUMENT AND ITS EXACT CONCLUSION

- ① THEORY OF APPEARING - perception = something PRESENTING ITSELF to a subject;
sensory content is not essential to that structure
▼
- ② MYSTICAL PERCEPTION SHARES THE STRUCTURE - an apparent object, a mode of
presentation, and a resulting belief about that object => M-beliefs
▼
- ③ BELIEFS ARE FORMED WITHIN DOXASTIC PRACTICES - socially established,
internally organised, with their own inputs, outputs and OVERRIDE procedures
▼
- ④ NO DOXASTIC PRACTICE CAN BE SHOWN RELIABLE WITHOUT CIRCULARITY - sense
perception cannot be validated except by using sense perception; the same
holds for memory and induction
▼
- ⑤ WE ARE NONETHELESS PRACTICALLY RATIONAL in engaging in sense perception
▼
- ⑥ THEREFORE engagement in an established religious practice (Alston's
"Christian Mystical Practice", CMP) is PRACTICALLY RATIONAL, absent
sufficient reason to think it unreliable

----- WHAT IS AND IS NOT CLAIMED -----	
CLAIMED	prima facie justification for M-beliefs; PRACTICAL RATIONALITY of engaging in the practice
NOT CLAIMED	proof that the practice is reliable; ultima facie justification

THE DIVERSITY OBJECTION - which Alston himself calls the most serious:
CMP, Buddhist, Advaitic and Islamic practices are each socially established
and self-supporting; if that makes engagement rational, it makes engagement
in INCOMPATIBLE practices rational, and they cannot all be tracking one reality.
ALSTON'S ANSWER: it is rational to "SIT TIGHT" in one's own practice absent a
neutral adjudicating ground - while conceding this is uncomfortable and could
be overturned by a better argument.

SECOND OBJECTION: mystical perception lacks the cross-checking, prediction and
intersubjective agreement that make sensory practice self-correcting.
REPLY: CMP does have internal override systems - discernment criteria,
doctrinal tests, spiritual direction - weaker than science's, but not absent.

*Follow the numbered chain for the argument; read the boxed pair for the claim you must not overstate; read the two
starred blocks for the objections that convert exposition into evaluation.*

TEACHING

[FACT] The doctrine. Some religious experience is genuinely **perceptual in structure** - a direct awareness of God
appearing to the subject - and beliefs formed on its basis, **M-beliefs**, enjoy *prima facie* justification.

[FACT] The argument, step by step. (1) The **theory of appearing**: perception consists in something's presenting
itself to the subject, and sensory content is not essential to that structure, so a non-sensory presentation can still be
perception. (2) Mystical perception shares perception's structure: an apparent object, a mode of presentation, and a
resulting belief. (3) Beliefs are formed within **doxastic practices** - socially established, internally organised
belief-forming practices with their own inputs, outputs and override procedures. (4) **No doxastic practice can be
shown reliable without circularity**: sense perception cannot be validated except by using sense perception, and the

same holds for memory and induction. (5) We are nonetheless **practically rational** in engaging in sense perception. (6) Therefore participation in an established religious practice, and acceptance of its outputs, is **practically rational** absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable.

[FACT] The presuppositions. ANALYSIS: That perception is defined by its **structure** rather than by sensory content; and that "socially established practice" is an **epistemically significant** category.

[FACT] The distinctions that keep the claim honest. *Prima facie* (defeasible) justification versus *ultima facie* (all things considered). **Practical rationality of engagement**, not proof of reliability - "a much weaker and much more defensible claim than it is usually reported as". And Alston's practice argument is **distinct from Swinburne's principle of credulity**, which is a general epistemic principle about *seemings* rather than a practice-based argument.

[FACT] The canonical illustration. A novice cannot show that sense perception is reliable without already relying on it; the demand for non-circular validation, uniformly applied, destroys all our practices.

[FACT] The diversity objection - Alston's own verdict on it. Multiple mutually incompatible mystical practices are each socially established and self-supporting; if that makes engagement rational, it makes engagement in incompatible practices rational, which cannot all be tracking the same reality. Alston's response is the honest one: it is rational to **"sit tight"** in one's own practice in the absence of a neutral adjudicating ground, while acknowledging the discomfort and that a better argument might overturn it.

[FACT] The second objection and reply. Unlike sense perception, mystical perception lacks the cross-checking, prediction and intersubjective agreement that make sensory practice self-correcting. Reply: the practice does have **internal override systems** - discernment criteria, doctrinal tests, spiritual direction - weaker than science's, but not absent.

[INFERENCE] How Alston connects to the rest of the clause. His override systems are the same materials that Session 16 uses as public criteria of authenticity, and his diversity concession is the same defeater that Session 13 handles through Hick. Alston is therefore the natural bridge between the epistemology of religious experience and the problem of its plurality.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Alston makes engagement in religious practice rational without making religious experience probative.

Named evidence: *Perceiving God* (1991) argues from the theory of appearing to M-beliefs, and from the epistemic circularity of sense perception, memory and induction to the practical rationality of Christian Mystical Practice.

Analysis: The argument works by parity, so its conclusion can be no stronger than the parity permits: it earns religious practice the same immunity from a self-defeating demand, not a superior warrant. **Qualification:** Alston himself identifies diversity as the most serious objection and answers only that one may rationally "sit tight" absent neutral adjudication - so an honest script stops exactly where he stops.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not report Alston as proving religious experience reliable. He claims **practical rationality of engagement**.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate Alston with Swinburne. Practices versus seemings.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not omit his own diversity concession. Including it is what separates a strong script from a merely correct one.

MINI RECAP

Theory of appearing -> M-perception -> M-beliefs, *prima facie* justified. Doxastic practices are circular but rational. Claim: practical rationality, not proof. Objection: diversity - Alston concedes and sits tight.

SESSION 13 - PLURAL AND CONFLICTING EXPERIENCES: THE DIVERSITY DEFEATER AND HICK'S REPLY

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Different traditions report meeting different ultimate realities, each with complete conviction. The diversity problem asks what that fact does to the evidential value of any one report.

Technical definition. Conflicting reports of a personal God, of non-dual Brahman and of emptiness generate a **cross-tradition defeater**: applied evenly, the principle of credulity licenses incompatible conclusions. Hick's reply is **plural mediation** - the traditions are culturally conditioned responses to one ultimate **Real** ("the Real *an sich*") experienced through different lenses.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religious diversity challenges the **inference** from experience far more than it challenges the **occurrence** of experience - and any reply that saves the inference by making the Real indescribable has paid for consistency with content.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

diversity defeater · incompatible objects · the Real (an sich) · culturally conditioned response · lens · indeterminacy objection · unfalsifiability rejoinder · family resemblance · occurrence versus interpretation versus veridicality

How to use them: keep this bounded. The complete pluralist theory and the absolute-truth debate belong to the Religious Pluralism owner; here diversity functions strictly as an **epistemic defeater** and Hick strictly as a **reply** to it.

VISUAL - THE DEFEATER, THE REPLY, AND THE PRICE OF THE REPLY

REPORTS, ALL DELIVERED WITH EQUAL CONVICTION

personal God (relation)	non-dual Brahman (identity)	emptiness / cessation (no such term)	isolated consciousness (withdrawal)
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THE DEFEATER: apply the principle of credulity **EVENLY** and it licenses **INCOMPATIBLE** conclusions. So either the principle is restricted (on what principled ground?) or some seemings are non-veridical (which ones?).

HICK: PLURAL MEDIATION
one Real *an sich*,
experienced through
culturally conditioned
lenses

EXCLUSIVISM: one is right
and the rest mistaken
(bites the bullet; owes an
account of the others'
sincerity and fruits)

CONSTRUCTIVISM: they
are different **EXPERIENCES**,
not one differently
described (Katz)

ANALYSIS: THE PRICE: if the Real is beyond all determinate description, it cannot ground the **DETERMINATE** claims the traditions actually make; and a reply that accommodates every report risks becoming **UNFALSIFIABLE**.
(Owner's own rejoinder: "this can become unfalsifiable.")

SAFE VERDICT SHAPE: diversity does not show that nothing was experienced;
it shows that **CONVERGENCE** cannot be used as evidence for a determinate object.

Top: the data. Middle: the argument that makes the data a defeater. Bottom: the three exits and the price attached to the most popular one.

TEACHING

[FACT] The defeater. Conflicting reports of a personal God, of non-dual Brahman and of emptiness generate a **cross-tradition defeater problem**. This is the canonical example given in the owner's veridicality dossier, and it is the objection Alston himself calls the most serious.

[FACT] Hick's reply. The various experiences are **culturally shaped responses to one ultimate Real** - "the Real *an sich*" experienced through different lenses.

[FACT] The pressure on the reply. ANALYSIS: An **unknowable Real may be too indeterminate** to support the specific claims traditions make. And the owner records a second rejoinder in its own criticisms list: the reply that "interpretation may vary while contact is common" **can become unfalsifiable**.

[FACT] Diversity suggests construction. The constructivist reads the same data differently: the traditions are not variously interpreting one contact but undergoing genuinely different, tradition-formed experiences (Session 6).

[INFERENCE] The move that scores. Separate three questions and answer them separately. Did something occur? - diversity is silent; the reports stand. How was it interpreted? - diversity is decisive; interpretation is plainly tradition-relative. Was it veridical? - diversity is a genuine defeater, because incompatible objects cannot all be met. Stating this three-way split *before* choosing an exit is what an "analyse" or "evaluate" directive rewards.

[INFERENCE] A weaker claim that survives. One may claim **family resemblance or analogous transformation** rather than identity of content - the Advanced dossier's own formulation. That is a defensible retreat position: it keeps the comparative enterprise alive without asserting a single object.

Objection. If diversity defeats religious experience, it equally defeats ordinary perception, where observers also disagree. **Reply.** **[INFERENCE]** The disanalogy is procedural, not psychological. Where perceivers disagree about a physical object, there are agreed methods of resolution - move closer, measure, ask a third party, repeat the observation. Religious practices possess **internal** override systems (Alston's discernment criteria) but no **cross-practice** adjudicating procedure. The problem is not that religious observers disagree; it is that nothing in the practice is designed to settle disagreement across practices.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Religious diversity is an epistemic problem about inference, not about occurrence. **Named evidence:** The credulity principle applied evenly licenses a personal God, non-dual Brahman and emptiness together; Hick replies with culturally conditioned responses to one Real *an sich*; Alston concedes that no non-circular resolution exists. **Analysis:** Since the conflicting reports concern the object rather than the state, diversity removes the convergence argument while leaving the phenomenology untouched. **Qualification:** Hick's rescue costs determinacy - a Real beyond description cannot underwrite determinate doctrine - and the milder claim of family resemblance is the more defensible residue.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not conclude "therefore all religious experience is false". Diversity is a defeater for an inference, not a disproof of a class of states.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present Hick's Real as an agreed solution. State its indeterminacy cost and the unfalsifiability rejoinder.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not import the exclusivism-pluralism debate wholesale. That is the Religious Pluralism owner's territory.

MINI RECAP

Incompatible objects, equal conviction. The credulity principle over-generates. Exits - Hick's mediated Real, exclusivism, constructivism. Price of Hick - indeterminacy and unfalsifiability. Safe residue - family resemblance, and no convergence argument.

SESSION 14 - MYSTICAL EXPERIENCE AND REVELATION (2023 OWNER-MODULE)

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Mystical experience is a **mode of awareness**; revelation is a **claimed disclosure** by the ultimate. They are intimately related but not the same thing.

Technical definition. Mystical experience can be a **vehicle of revelation** - God or the Real disclosed experientially - which is **non-propositional revelation**. Propositional revelation, by contrast, is the communication of truths, and it can occur without any mystical state at all.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mystical experience and revelation are related as **vehicle to cargo**: the state can carry a disclosure without being one, which is why the two may coincide, come apart, or be mistaken for each other - and each of those three possibilities has a different consequence for religious life.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

mode versus content · vehicle of revelation · non-propositional revelation · propositional revelation · experiencing-as · reception versus occurrence · discernment · significance for religious life · the reception boundary

How to use them: the 2023 stem has **two** deliverables - the relation *and* their significance in the religious life. Structure the answer in halves and label them.

VISUAL - THE FOUR COMBINATIONS

	REVELATION CLAIMED	NO REVELATION CLAIMED
MYSTICAL STATE PRESENT	① VEHICLE CASE the state is received as disclosure of the Real; Hick's non-propositional model; "experiencing-as"	② PURE EXPERIENCE CASE a unitive or numinous state reported without any claim to disclose a message or a will
NO MYSTICAL STATE	③ PROPOSITIONAL CASE truths delivered through prophet, text or tradition, with no unitive state involved	④ NEITHER

=> CELLS ② AND ③ PROVE NON-IDENTITY. If mystical experience were revelation, ② would be impossible; if revelation were mystical experience, ③ would be impossible. Both plainly occur.

SIGNIFICANCE FOR RELIGIOUS LIFE - three functions of the vehicle case:
 ORIGIN founders' disclosures generate traditions
 RENEWAL later mystics re-authenticate a tradition from within
 RISK an unchecked private disclosure can override the community
 => hence DISCERNMENT: Teresa's criteria, the guru's testing, the community's doctrinal norms (Session 16)

ANALYSIS: RECEPTION BOUNDARY: this session owns the RELATION. Faith's reception of revelation belongs to the Reason, Revelation and Faith owner. Say so in one clause and move on; do not annex the neighbouring clause.

The four-cell grid proves the non-identity; the lower block supplies the second half of the printed demand.

TEACHING

[FACT] The relation. Mystical experience can be a **vehicle of revelation** - God or the Real disclosed experientially. This is non-propositional revelation, and the two are **intimately linked** without being identical.

[FACT] The non-identity, argued rather than asserted. ANALYSIS: The owner's trap list is explicit: distinguish mystical experience from revelation; one may mediate the other, but they are not identical. **[INFERENCE]** The four-cell grid supplies the argument. A unitive state may be reported with no disclosure-claim attached (cell □); and a

tradition may hold that truths were delivered through prophet, text or community without any unitive state (cell □). Each cell alone refutes one direction of the identification.

[FACT] The model. Hick's **non-propositional / experiencing-as** account is the owner's named framework for revelatory experience: an event or presence is *received as* disclosure. **[INFERENCE]** Note carefully what that phrasing concedes - the "as" is contributed by the receiver, which is why the same event can be religiously ambiguous.

[INFERENCE] Significance in the religious life - the second deliverable. Three functions. **Origin:** founders' disclosures generate traditions and supply their normative content. **Renewal:** later mystics re-authenticate the tradition from within, keeping it from decaying into pure convention. **Risk:** an unchecked private disclosure can override community, scripture and moral judgement, which is exactly why every mature tradition maintains discernment procedures. A script that names only the first two has described the benefit and hidden the cost.

[INFERENCE] The Indian parallel, kept bounded. In Advaita, scripture (*śruti*) functions as the authoritative removal of ignorance while realisation is the cognitive event; the two are related as instruction to insight, not as message to messenger. This gives an Indian analogue of the vehicle/cargo distinction without importing the Paper I doctrine of scriptural authority.

Objection. If revelation is what the receiver takes the event to be, revelation is just interpretation, and the distinction between disclosure and projection collapses. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** The distinction is preserved by **discernment**, not by phenomenology. Traditions do not treat every experiencing-as as revelation: they apply criteria of coherence, conformity, moral fruits and communal testing. Those criteria establish authenticity rather than truth - which is the honest limit, and it is the same limit Session 16 reaches from the public-discourse side.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Mystical experience is a possible vehicle of revelation, not a synonym for it. **Named evidence:** Hick's non-propositional model treats the event as received "as" divine disclosure, while propositional revelation delivered through prophet or text requires no unitive state at all. **Analysis:** Because each can occur without the other, the relation is contingent and functional, so what matters religiously is which functions the vehicle performs - origination, renewal, and the risk of unchecked private authority. **Qualification:** The distinction survives only because traditions run discernment procedures; those procedures test authenticity and conformity, not the truth of what is claimed to be disclosed.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not identify mystical experience with revelation. Cells □ and □ of the grid exist.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the 2023 stem with the relation alone. "Expound their significance in the religious life" is a second, separately marked task.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not annex the Reason, Revelation and Faith clause. Reception of revelation belongs there; state the boundary in a clause.

MINI RECAP

Vehicle, not cargo. Four cells prove non-identity. Hick's experiencing-as supplies the model. Significance - origin, renewal, risk. Control - discernment tests authenticity, not truth.

SESSION 15 - PRAYER AND WORSHIP: THE DISTINCTION AND THEIR PLACE (2020 OWNER-MODULE)

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Prayer is **speaking to**; worship is **counting as supremely worth**.

Technical definition. **Prayer** is *address* - communicative directedness toward the divine, whether petition, intercession, thanksgiving, confession, adoration or wordless contemplation. **Worship** is *acknowledgement of worth* - the ascription of supreme value to the sacred, characteristically ritual, embodied, communal and regulated.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Prayer presupposes a **responsive** ultimate; worship presupposes only a **supremely valuable** one - which is why worship, not prayer, is the more nearly universal religious act, and why the non-theistic religions are decisive test-cases rather than curiosities.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

address versus ascription of worth · adoration as the overlap · A-C-T-S (adoration, confession, thanksgiving, supplication) · petitionary prayer problem · Aquinas' secondary cause · Stump's friendship defence · Rachels' moral-autonomy argument · the nine-fold devotion (navadhā bhakti) list · free of passion (vītarāga) · unseen potency (apūrva) · contemplative worship (upāsānā) · relational organ versus evaluative organ

How to use them: the 2020 stem has **two printed deliverables** - "distinguish" and "determine their place". Give roughly half the answer to each, and label both.

VISUAL - THE SIX-AXIS BENCH, THE TWO PROBLEMS, AND THE THREE DECIDING CASES

AXIS	PRAYER	WORSHIP
Essential act	address / communication	ascription of supreme worth (homage)
Direction	person-to-person (I-Thou)	creature-before-the-holy
Form	verbal or silent; may be spontaneous	ritual, embodied, rule-governed
Locus	often private	characteristically corporate
Presupposes	a God who can HEAR and RESPOND	a reality of supreme value; RESPONSE NOT REQUIRED
Non-theistic availability	ANALYSIS: strained	available

OVERLAP: ADORATION - address (so prayer) AND ascription of worth (so worship). LIMIT CASE: wordless contemplative prayer, where address persists after articulated request disappears.

KINDS OF PRAYER: A-C-T-S = Adoration · Confession · Thanksgiving · Supplication (add intercession and contemplative prayer)

[- PROBLEM 1: PETITIONARY PRAYER -----] ① omniscient => he already knows the need ② perfectly good => he will already do what is best ③ immutable => prayer cannot change him ④ petition is pointless, or an attempt to manipulate perfection AQUINAS we pray not to change the divine disposition but to OBTAIN WHAT GOD HAS DETERMINED SHALL BE OBTAINED THROUGH PRAYER - a genuine SECONDARY CAUSE written into the causal order STUMP ("Petitionary Prayer", 1979) asking PROTECTS THE RELATIONSHIP: unrequested benefaction from an overwhelmingly superior being risks spoiling or overwhelming the recipient ANALYSIS: RESIDUE this justifies petition's VALUE, not that outcomes causally depend on it	
[- PROBLEM 2: WORSHIP AND MORAL AUTONOMY -----] RACHELS, "God and Human Autonomy" (1971) ① worship entails unqualified, unconditional obedience ② moral agency requires never abdicating final judgement to another's will ③ no being could be WORTHY OF WORSHIP, so God (so defined) does not exist REPLIES worship recognises WORTH, not a contract of blind obedience · a perfectly good being's commands never require abdicating moral judgement, since they coincide with it · the argument assumes an atomistic autonomy that even secular ethics rejects for relations of legitimate authority and trust	
[- THREE INDIAN CASES THAT DECIDE THE QUESTION -----] JAINISM the Tirthaṅkara is free of passion (vītarāga) and CANNOT RESPOND; image-veneration (caitya-vandana) is worship without any possibility of petition being answered MĪMĀṂSĀ efficacy lies in the unseen potency (apūrva) generated by correct performance; the deity is a GRAMMATICAL DATIVE in the injunction, not an agent who grants ADVAITA contemplative worship (upāsana) of a qualified form is genuinely efficacious at the everyday level (vyāvahārika) and is TRANSCENDED, not repudiated, at the ultimate level (pāramārthika) BUDDHISM ritual honour (pūjā) before an image is standardly commemorative and dispositional - cultivating one's own mind - though devotional Pure Land traditions complicate this	

Bench first (deliverable one), then the two philosophical problems, then the four cases that decide the placement (deliverable two).

TEACHING

[FACT] The distinction. Prayer is **address**; worship is **acknowledgement of worth**. Prayer can be silent, solitary and spontaneous; worship is typically enacted, corporate and liturgically ordered. **Adoration is the overlap**: it is both prayer (address) and worship (ascription of worth).

[FACT] The kinds of prayer. The classical Western scheme is summarised as **A-C-T-S**: Adoration, Confession, Thanksgiving, Supplication - a convenient enumeration for the "kinds of prayer" part of the stem. **[INFERENCE]** Contemplative or wordless prayer is the limit case, where address survives the disappearance of articulated request;

silence alone therefore does not convert prayer into worship.

[FACT] The problem of petitionary prayer. (1) If God is omniscient, he already knows the need. (2) If God is perfectly good, he will already do whatever is best. (3) If God is immutable, prayer cannot change him. (4) Therefore petition is either pointless or an attempt to manipulate perfection.

[FACT] Aquinas' reply. We pray not in order to change the divine disposition but so that we may **obtain what God has determined shall be obtained through prayer** - prayer is written into the causal order as a genuine **secondary cause**, not as an override of the primary one.

[FACT] Stump's reply. Eleonore Stump, "Petitionary Prayer" (*American Philosophical Quarterly*, 1979): the value of petition lies in **protecting the relationship**. Unrequested benefaction from an overwhelmingly superior being risks spoiling or overwhelming the recipient; asking preserves the friendship-structure within which the giving is good for the recipient. **ANALYSIS: Residual difficulty:** this justifies petition's *value*, not the claim that outcomes causally depend on it.

[FACT] The problem of worship. James Rachels, "God and Human Autonomy" (1971): (1) worship entails unqualified, unconditional obedience; (2) moral agency requires that one never abdicate final judgement to another's will; (3) so no being could be *worthy of worship*, and therefore God, defined as a fitting object of worship, does not exist. **Replies:** worship is recognition of **worth**, not a contract of blind obedience; a perfectly good being's commands never require abdicating moral judgement, since they coincide with it; and the argument assumes an **atomistic conception of autonomy** that even secular ethics rejects for relationships of legitimate authority and trust.

[FACT] The Indian vocabulary. Petition (*prārthanā*), praise (*stuti / stotra*), repetition of a name or mantra (*japa*), meditation (*dhyāna*), structured contemplative worship (*upāsana*), ritual service (*pūjā / arcana*), salutation (*vandana*), self-offering (*ātma-nivedana*) - the last five appear in the nine-fold devotion (*navadhā bhakti*) list.

[FACT] The three deciding cases. Jainism: the Tīrthaṅkara is free of passion (*vītarāga*) and cannot respond, so image-veneration (*caitya-vandana*) is **worship without any possibility of petition being answered**. **Mīmāṃsā:** ritual efficacy lies in the unseen potency (*apūrva*) generated by correct performance; the deity is a **grammatical dative** in the injunction rather than an agent who grants. **Advaita:** contemplative worship (*upāsana*) of a qualified form is genuinely efficacious at the everyday level (*vyāvahārika*) and is **transcended, not repudiated**, at the ultimate level (*pāramārthika*). **Buddhism:** ritual honour (*pūjā*) before an image is standardly explained as **commemorative and dispositional** - cultivating one's own mind - rather than petitionary, although devotional Pure Land traditions complicate this.

[FACT] Their place in religion - the second deliverable. Prayer is the **relational** organ of religion: it constitutes the personal I-Thou dimension and is the practical form of faith. Worship is the **evaluative and communal** organ: it enacts the sacred/profane boundary, forms the community, transmits tradition and disciplines desire. **A religion can survive the loss of petition** (Jainism, Mīmāṃsā, classical Buddhism); **no religion survives the loss of worship** in the broad sense, because nothing would then mark the ultimate as ultimate.

Objection. The distinction is verbal: in practice worshippers pray and pray-ers worship, so nothing turns on it. **Reply.**

[INFERENCE] The three Indian cases are precisely the disproof. In Jainism and Mīmāṃsā the practices come apart in reality, not merely in definition: an entire ritual life is sustained where petition-as-request is doctrinally impossible. A distinction that generates correct predictions about which traditions retain which practices is not verbal.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Prayer and worship differ in their essential act and therefore in their presuppositions. **Named evidence:** The A-C-T-S scheme classifies prayer as address, while Jain veneration of a *vītarāga* Tīrthaṅkara and Mīmāṃsā's *apūrva* sustain full ritual worship where petition can obtain nothing. **Analysis:** Because worship requires only supreme value and prayer requires responsiveness, the two come apart exactly where a tradition denies a responsive deity - which shows the distinction is doing real classificatory work. **Qualification:** They overlap in adoration and interpenetrate in practice, so the claim is about essential act and presupposition, not about liturgical separation.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not answer with synonyms. Prayer = address, presupposing a responsive God; worship = ascription of supreme worth, retained by non-theistic traditions.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the second deliverable. "Determine their place in religion" is separately marked.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Aquinas thinks prayer changes God's mind. He says the opposite: prayer is a secondary cause within what God has already ordained.

MINI RECAP

Address versus ascription of worth; adoration overlaps. A-C-T-S. Petition problem - Aquinas' secondary cause, Stump's friendship defence, residual difficulty. Worship problem - Rachels, and three replies. Deciding cases - Jain *viṭarāga*, Mīmāṃsā *apūrva*, Advaita *upāsanā*, Buddhist *pūjā*. Place - relational organ and evaluative organ; petition is dispensable, worship is not.

SESSION 16 - RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE IN PUBLIC DISCOURSE (2019 OWNER-MODULE)

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Can something first-personal, hard to put into words and self-authenticating be discussed in a shared space of reasons at all?

Technical definition. The printed question is not "is religious experience real?" but "**how far** can it be made a topic of public discourse?" - so the answer must be a **degree**, marking precisely what is publicly assessable and what is not.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Religious experience is publicly **discussable** and privately **probative**: coherence, tradition-conformity, fruits and disciplined replicability can all be examined in public, but the evidential force the experience carries for its subject cannot be transferred with them.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

ineffability · privileged access · no shared checking procedure · private-language considerations · public reason · phenomenological description · coherence · discernment norms · moral fruits · replicability through disciplined practice · doxastic practice · translation proviso · authenticity versus truth

How to use them: the directive "how far ... Analyse" forbids yes/no. Structure: case against -> case for -> **the exact line you draw**. The line is the answer.

VISUAL - THE LADDER OF PUBLICITY

▲ MORE PUBLIC

|

| ⑥ DOXASTIC-PRACTICE ARGUMENT (Alston) - a socially established,
internally self-supporting practice free of massive inconsistency is
a legitimate topic of PUBLIC ARGUMENT ABOUT PRACTICES

| ⑤ REPLICABILITY THROUGH DISCIPLINED PRACTICE - yoga, meditation (dhyāna),
contemplation (nididhyāsana): repeatable procedures with stated
preconditions and predicted outcomes. Vivekananda and Radhakrishnan
press this as an "experimental" claim ANALYSIS: REPORT AS THEIR CLAIM;
the experiment cannot be run by an uncommitted observer - closer to
the training-dependence of expert perception than to a laboratory test

| ④ MORAL AND PRACTICAL FRUITS - transformation of conduct is OBSERVABLE

| ③ DOCTRINAL AND TRADITIONAL DISCERNMENT NORMS - Teresa of Ávila's criteria
for distinguishing genuine locutions from delusion; the guru's
verification; the teacher's (ācārya's) testing

| ② COHERENCE - internally consistent, and consistent with what is otherwise
known

| ① PHENOMENOLOGICAL DESCRIPTION - James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner built
public typologies out of first-person documents: PUBLIC WORK ON
PRIVATE DATA. Even ineffability is REPORTABLE.

|

+----- THE LINE -----+

| Everything above is publicly assessable and tests AUTHENTICITY.
| Nothing above transfers the EVIDENTIAL FORCE the experience has for its
| subject. CONCEDE THIS EXPLICITLY - the concession is worth marks.

+-----+

| THE CASE AGAINST, five moves:

| (1) INEFFABILITY resists the articulation discourse requires

| (2) PRIVILEGED ACCESS - James concedes mystical states are authoritative
| only for the one who has them

| (3) NO SHARED CHECKING PROCEDURE, unlike perception

| (4) WITTGENSTEIN'S private-language considerations - a wholly private
| criterion is no criterion

| (5) RAWLSIAN PUBLIC REASON - for coercive political decisions, offer
| reasons others could reasonably accept

▼ LESS PUBLIC

BRIDGE: HABERMAS - religious citizens may express themselves in religious
language in the INFORMAL public sphere, subject to an institutional
TRANSLATION PROVISIO before formal state decision-making.
=> THE "HOW FAR" GETS A DETERMINATE ANSWER: fully in the informal sphere,
conditionally in the formal one.

Read the ladder upward for the six criteria; the horizontal line is the concession that must be stated; the bottom band is the case against and the political bridge that converts the degree into a determinate answer.

TEACHING

[FACT] The exact question. Not "is religious experience real?" but "how far can it be made a topic of public discourse?" - i.e. can a first-personal, ineffable, self-authenticating state enter a shared space of reasons at all?

[FACT] The case for no. (1) **Ineffability** by definition resists the public articulation that discourse requires. (2) **Privileged access:** the subject's warrant is not transferable; James himself concedes mystical states are authoritative only for the one who has them. (3) **No shared checking procedure:** unlike perception, there is no agreed method of correcting an erroneous report. (4) **Wittgenstein's private-language considerations** press the worry that a wholly private criterion is no criterion. (5) **Rawlsian public reason** holds that for coercive political decisions citizens should offer reasons others could reasonably accept, which excludes appeals to private revelation from that specific arena.

[FACT] The case for yes - six intersubjective criteria. (1) **Phenomenological description:** even ineffability is *reportable*, and James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner built comparative typologies out of first-person documents - public work on private data. (2) **Coherence:** internally consistent and consistent with what is otherwise known. (3) **Doctrinal and traditional norms:** every mature tradition operates discernment procedures - Teresa of Ávila's criteria for distinguishing genuine locutions from delusion; the guru's verification of a disciple's state; the teacher's (ācārya's) testing. (4) **Moral and practical fruits:** James's criterion is intrinsically public, since transformation of conduct is observable by others. (5) **Replicability through disciplined practice:** the strongest Indian contribution - yoga, meditation (dhyāna) and contemplation (nididhyāsana) are presented as **repeatable procedures with stated preconditions and predicted outcomes**; Vivekananda and Radhakrishnan press this as a claim that religious experience is **experimental** rather than merely private. ANALYSIS: Report it as **their claim** and note its limit: the

"experiment" cannot be run by an uncommitted observer, so it is closer to the training-dependence of expert perception than to a public laboratory test. (6) **Alston's doxastic-practice framework**: a socially established, internally self-supporting practice free of massive internal inconsistency makes participation rational even without non-circular validation, and that makes it a legitimate topic of *public argument about practices*, if not of public verification of episodes.

[FACT] The bridge to the public sphere. Habermas's post-secular position: religious citizens may express themselves in religious language in the **informal** public sphere, subject to an institutional **translation proviso** - reasons must be rendered into generally accessible terms before entering formal state decision-making. This gives the "how far" a determinate answer: **fully in the informal sphere, conditionally in the formal one.**

[FACT] The concession that must be made. ANALYSIS: Discussing an experience publicly is not the same as **warranting** it publicly; the six criteria test **authenticity, not truth**. The honest answer says so.

[INFERENCE] Why the Indian material is decisive here rather than decorative. The Western case for publicity rests mostly on *description* and *consequences* - both third-personal. The Indian claim adds a **procedure**: a stated method with preconditions and predicted outcomes. That is a stronger form of publicity, because it is in principle repeatable. Its limit is equally sharp: repeatability that requires commitment is not neutral testability, which is why the honest formulation is "expert perception", not "laboratory science".

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Religious experience enters public discourse as data, description and disciplined practice, and stops short of public verification. **Named evidence:** James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner built public typologies from private documents; Teresa's discernment criteria and the guru's testing supply traditional norms; Alston's doxastic-practice argument licenses public argument about practices; Habermas's translation proviso fixes the political boundary.

Analysis: Each criterion is genuinely intersubjective, yet each tests coherence, conformity, fruitfulness or procedure rather than the existence of the object, so publicity increases without evidential transfer. **Qualification:** Therefore the correct answer is graded and not affirmative: religious experience is publicly discussable and privately probative, and the replicability claim must be reported as a claim rather than endorsed.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "public discourse" as "public proof". They are different achievements, and the difference is the answer.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not endorse the "science of the soul" claim. Attribute it, and state its limit.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not answer "how far" with yes or no. Draw the line explicitly and defend where you drew it.

MINI RECAP

Against - ineffability, privileged access, no checking procedure, private-language worries, public reason. For - description, coherence, discernment, fruits, replicability, doxastic practices. Bridge - Habermas's translation proviso. Concession - authenticity, not truth. Verdict - publicly discussable, privately probative.

SESSION 17 - THE INDIAN-WESTERN PARITY BENCH AND THE TEN-ROW COMPARISON

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. A parity bench is a set of axes on which the Indian and Western accounts can be compared without either being flattened into the other.

Technical definition. Six axes carry the comparison - structure of the experience, duration, method, authority, object-term and ritual correlate - each with a **discriminating point** that states exactly what the difference proves.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The two traditions do not differ merely in vocabulary: theistic mysticism reports a **relation** that presupposes two terms, while Advaita reports an **identity** that abolishes one - and a common-core theory must explain that difference away rather than assume it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

relation versus identity · isolation · stable knowledge (jñāna) versus transiency · disciplined and repeatable method · self-established (svataḥ-siddha) but tested by teacher and scripture · generic object-term · ritual correlate · worship without a responsive deity

How to use them: one axis, used precisely, beats six axes listed. Choose the axis the stem is about and run it to a discriminating point.

VISUAL - SIX AXES, AND WHAT EACH DIFFERENCE PROVES

AXIS	WESTERN	INDIAN	DISCRIMINATING POINT
STRUCTURE of the experience	encounter / union with an Other (Otto, theistic mysticism)	IDENTITY-recognition (Advaita) or ISOLATION (Sāṃkhya-Yoga)	relation vs identity is a LOGICAL, not a stylistic difference
DURATION	transient (James's USUAL mark)	liberating knowledge (jñāna) is STABLE and ESTABLISHED, not episodic	exactly why James's GRADING of his marks matters
METHOD	grace, contemplation, sacrament	disciplined, staged, repeatable (eightfold path; hearing-reflection-contemplation)	India's REPLICABILITY claim in the public-discourse question
AUTHORITY	authoritative for the SUBJECT only (James)	self-established (svataḥ-siddha), but tested by teacher and scripture	both restrict transferability; India adds INSTITUTIONAL DISCERNMENT
OBJECT-TERM	God, the Holy, the numinous	Brahman, puruṣa, nirvāṇa, the Tīrthaṅkara	the generic term must be "SACRED", not "GOD"
RITUAL CORRELATE	prayer, sacrament, liturgy	contemplative worship (upāsana), ritual service (pūjā), mantra-repetition (japa), meditation (dhyāna)	Jain and Mīmāṃsā worship WITHOUT a responsive deity

The fourth column is where the marks are. A comparison without a discriminating point is a table, not an argument.

TEACHING

[FACT] The ten-row account bench. The owner's comparison grid runs: **James** - defining ineffable and noetic, usual transient and passive; object the "MORE"; risk subjectivism. **Otto** - non-rational awe; object the numinous/holy; risk reification of emotion. **Schleiermacher** - feeling of dependence; object the Infinite. **Stace** - extrovertive and introvertive; object the One; risk that interpretation does all the work. **Zaehner** - nature, monistic, theistic; object nature, the isolated soul, or a personal God; risk a confessional ranking. **Alston** - perception-like with an appearing object; *prima facie* justification and practical rationality; risk the diversity of established practices. **Advaita** - non-dual, self-certifying bliss; object Brahman as self; risk the content/criterion problem. **Radhakrishnan** - integral intuition; object the Spirit/Real; risk Advaitic assimilation. **Theistic mysticism** - union or communion with a personal God; risk conflict with non-dual reports. **Buddhism** - insight and awakening; object *nirvāṇa* or emptiness with no creator; risk that the "object" category itself misleads. **Durkheim and Eliade** - socially and cosmically structured; object the **sacred**; risk over-breadth.

[FACT] The six parity axes. Structure (encounter and union versus identity-recognition or isolation); duration (transient versus stable *jñāna*); method (grace, contemplation and sacrament versus disciplined, staged and repeatable practice); authority (authoritative for the subject only, versus self-established but tested by teacher and scripture); object-term (God, the Holy, the numinous, versus Brahman, *puruṣa*, *nirvāṇa*, the Tīrthaṅkara); ritual correlate (prayer, sacrament and liturgy versus *upāsana*, *pūjā*, *japa* and *dhyāna*, with Jain and Mīmāṃsā worship lacking a responsive deity).

[INFERENCE] How to use one axis well. For a James stem, use **duration**: his grading is what admits stable *jñāna*. For a public-discourse stem, use **method**: repeatability is India's contribution and its limit. For an object stem, use **object-term**: the generic word must be "sacred". For a comparison stem, use **structure**: relation against identity. Each axis has a natural home question, and matching them is the fastest route to a specific answer.

[INFERENCE] The risk column is the assessment. Reproducing the ten rows describes the field; naming each account's characteristic risk evaluates it. An answer that says "Otto risks reifying an emotion; Stace risks letting interpretation do all the work; Radhakrishnan risks Advaitic assimilation; Alston risks the parity of incompatible practices" has assessed four positions in one sentence each.

Objection. Parity benches manufacture symmetry: forcing Indian material into Western axes distorts it. **Reply.**

[INFERENCE] The risk is real, and the control is to let the axes be **contested** rather than assumed. "Object-term" is precisely such an axis: the Indian entries include a terminus (*nirvāṇa*) for which "object" may be the wrong category, and saying so *is* the comparison rather than a failure of it.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Indian and Western accounts differ in logical form, not only in vocabulary. **Named evidence:** Otto and theistic mysticism report encounter with a wholly other; Advaita reports identity in *aham brahmāsmi*; Sāṃkhya-Yoga reports the isolation of consciousness; Jain and Mīmāṃsā ritual sustains worship with no responsive deity. **Analysis:** Relation requires two terms and identity abolishes one, so a common-core theory owes an explanation of that asymmetry rather than a demonstration of similarity. **Qualification:** The comparison must allow its own categories to be contested, since for Buddhism the very term "object" may misdescribe a terminus that is a cessation rather than a being.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not list six axes without discriminating points. The fourth column is the answer.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "Indian" as a single position. Advaita, Yoga, devotion, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and Buddhism sit on different rows.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not use "God" as the generic object-term in a comparative sentence. Use "sacred", then specify.

MINI RECAP

Ten accounts, each with a risk. Six axes - structure, duration, method, authority, object-term, ritual correlate. One discriminating point per axis. One rule - match the axis to the stem.

SESSION 18 - ANSWER ARCHITECTURE, DIRECTIVE DECODING, VERDICT LADDER AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. This session converts everything above into scripts that an examiner can reward.

Technical definition. It supplies three architectures by mark-weight, an eight-row directive decoder keyed to the eight printed questions, a five-band graded verdict ladder with three verdict templates, and a factual-and-quotation discipline table.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Every question in this clause has a **nature** half and an **object** half; answer both explicitly, and state whether the object is *encountered* or *realised* - that one sentence is the difference between a good script and an average one.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

directive fidelity · graded verdict · defeater statement · nature half and object half · encountered versus realised · claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

How to use them: decode the directive before writing a word. Six of the eight printed stems in this clause carry **two** deliverables; answering one of them is the commonest structural failure.

VISUAL - THREE ARCHITECTURES

10 MARKS (≈150 words)

define the experience -> list structured marks -> identify object ->
ONE epistemic objection -> limited verdict

15 MARKS (≈250 words)

nature/object distinction -> the thinker's account and its presupposition ->
canonical example -> Indian/Western contrast -> veridicality objection and reply

20 MARKS (≈350 words)

phenomenology -> claimed object -> warrant from credulity/testimony/fruits ->
naturalistic AND diversity defeaters -> Indian-Western comparison ->
graded verdict separating PERSONAL justification from PUBLIC proof
+ name the DEFEATER that would change the verdict

VISUAL - THE DIRECTIVE DECODER, KEYED TO THE EIGHT PRINTED STEMS

Directive	What the examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
Do you agree that...? Discuss	an explicit, graded position on the <i>printed</i> proposition	grant what is true in it, then mark the limit	2018 Q7(a) - God as object of religion
How far can X...? Analyse	a degree , not a yes/no	case against -> case for -> the exact line you draw	2019 Q7(c) - public discourse
Distinguish A and B and determine their place	two deliverables - obey both	half on the differentia, half on the function	2020 Q7(b) - prayer and worship
Explain X in the light of [tradition]	tradition-internal categories, not generic ones	use <i>anubhava</i> , <i>aparokṣānubhūti</i> , <i>nirvikalpa</i> - not "mystical feeling"	2021 Q7(c) - Vedāntic
Discuss the nature and variety of X as presented by [thinker]	both nouns: the <i>marks</i> and the <i>typology</i>	graded marks + varieties (healthy-minded / sick soul, conversion, mysticism)	2022 Q7(c) - James
Examine the relation between A and B and expound their significance	a relation plus a significance claim	relation first; then what religious life gains from it	2023 Q8(c) - mystical experience and revelation
Discuss the main features of X	an enumerated feature-list with discriminators	each feature must contrast with a rival account	2024 Q8(c) - Advaita
Evaluate the nature and object of X as explained by [thinker] in [named work]	fidelity to the named work, then assessment	name the work's own theses before criticising	2025 Q8(a) - Radhakrishnan, <i>The Hindu View of Life</i>

VISUAL - THE GRADED VERDICT LADDER

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	lists James's four marks flat; mentions Otto	no object-analysis; no veridicality question
Average (≈50%)	marks + numinous + Advaita; correct terms	marks ungraded; Indian experience described as "mystical feeling"
Good (≈60%)	nature/object separated; one epistemic objection raised	typologies (Stace/Zaehner) and the diversity defeater absent
Strong (≈65-70%)	graded marks; identity-versus-relation stated; credulity and defeater apparatus; Indian parity argued	Alston's practical-rationality claim overstated as proof
Top (≈70%+)	all the above plus a discriminating distinction (defining versus usual marks; Otto's holy ≠ Durkheim's sacred; constructivism versus the Pure Consciousness Event; <i>prima facie</i> versus <i>ultima facie</i>) plus a statement of the defeater that would change the verdict	-

Three verdict templates.

- ANALYSIS: *Veridicality stem*: "Religious experience confers *prima facie*, defeasible justification on the subject and testimonial weight on the hearer; it does not establish its object publicly. Diversity, not neurology, is the serious defeater - causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things."
- ANALYSIS: *Thinker stem*: "___'s account is strongest as **phenomenology** and weakest as **epistemology**: describing the structure of an experience accurately does not show that the structure is satisfied by a real object."
- ANALYSIS: *Indian-Western stem*: "The two traditions do not differ merely in vocabulary. Theistic mysticism reports a **relation** that presupposes two terms; Advaita reports an **identity** that abolishes one. A common-core theory must explain that difference away, and Zaehner's refusal to do so is his most defensible move."

TEACHING - FACTUAL AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

Item	Status	Safe use
James's marks	FACT: <i>The Varieties of Religious Experience</i> , Lectures XVI-XVII	ineffability + noetic quality are defining ; transiency + passivity are "usual" - always grade them
"By their fruits ye shall know them"	FACT: Matthew 7:16/20; used by James as a criterion	attribute to scripture; James adopts, does not coin
"Medical materialism"	FACT: James's own term (<i>Varieties</i> , Lecture I)	the fallacy of dismissing a state by its origin
<i>Mysterium tremendum et fascinans</i>	FACT: Rudolf Otto, <i>The Idea of the Holy</i> (1917)	Otto's own Latin
"Feeling of absolute dependence"	FACT: Schleiermacher, <i>The Christian Faith</i>	cite by work
Extrovertive / introvertive	FACT: W. T. Stace, <i>Mysticism and Philosophy</i> (1960)	two types + shared marks + common-core thesis
Nature / monistic / theistic	FACT: R. C. Zaehner, <i>Mysticism Sacred and Profane</i> (1957)	ANALYSIS: note the confessional criticism of his ranking
Constructivism	FACT: Steven Katz, "Language, Epistemology and Mysticism" (1978)	"there are no unmediated experiences"
Pure Consciousness Event	FACT: Robert Forman	the reply to Katz at the contentless limit
<i>Perceiving God</i>	FACT: William Alston (1991)	practical rationality of a doxastic practice - not proof of reliability
Principle of credulity	FACT: Richard Swinburne	distinct from Alston's practice argument
"Petitionary Prayer"	FACT: Eleonore Stump, <i>American Philosophical Quarterly</i> (1979)	the friendship / relationship defence
"God and Human Autonomy"	FACT: James Rachels (1971)	the moral-autonomy argument against worship
Sacred / profane	FACT: Durkheim (1912); hierophany FACT: Eliade (1957)	do not merge with Otto's holy
<i>Aham brahmāsmi</i>	FACT: Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 1.4.10	cite the Upaniṣad
<i>The Hindu View of Life</i>	FACT: S. Radhakrishnan (1927)	the named work in the 2025 stem - use its own theses
Vivekananda's "science of the soul" claim	ANALYSIS: a claim about method, widely made in his lectures	report as his claim; do not present as established

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: A religious-experience script is graded on directive fidelity before it is graded on content. **Named evidence:** Six of the eight printed stems in this clause carry two deliverables - "distinguish ... and determine"; "examine the relation ... and expound their significance"; "nature *and* variety"; "nature *and* object"; "do you agree" after a granted premise; "how far". **Analysis:** Because each of those formulations allocates marks to a second task, a complete treatment of the first task alone caps the script well below its content value. **Qualification:** Directive fidelity is necessary and not sufficient: without the graded marks, the identity-versus-relation distinction and a named defeater, an obedient answer still stops in the "good" band.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not conclude with a summary. Conclude with a **graded verdict** that answers the directive.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not invent a year for Schleiermacher, Swinburne, Hick, Forman or Teresa. Cite by work.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not spend the 20-marker on brain regions or a catalogue of mystical cases. Master the phenomenological marks, the claimed object, the warrant test, the strongest critique and one Indian comparison.

MINI RECAP

Three architectures. Eight directives, six of them double-barrelled. Five bands, the top one requiring a discriminating distinction and a named defeater. Three verdict templates. One quotation table - and no invented years.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** using a length-balanced, non-patterned assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and the four positions each carry exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. The four analytical layers, and the jump that is illegitimate

A candidate writes: "The experience was overwhelming and life-changing, so its object must be real." Which analytical failure does this best illustrate?

- A. It confuses doctrinal authenticity with psychological genuineness, since the tradition's own recognition test has not yet been consulted at all.
- B. It denies mediation, since a state of that intensity could not have been shaped by the concepts and expectations the subject already possessed.
- C. It confuses interpretation with claimed object, since the tradition's naming of the ultimate has simply been read back into what was presented.
- D. It jumps from phenomenology directly to epistemic force, since the felt intensity of the state is being treated by itself as warrant for its claimed object.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this names a real distinction, but the candidate's sentence says nothing about conformity to a tradition; the fault is in the inference from felt intensity, not in a missing doctrinal test.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing in the sentence denies mediation; it could be granted entirely and the inference from intensity to reality would still be invalid.
- **C:** Incorrect: that describes the naming-to-meeting jump, in which a tradition's vocabulary is treated as identifying the object; here the premise offered is intensity, not vocabulary.
- **D:** Correct: layer one is what the experience is like and layer four is what it justifies, and "overwhelming, therefore real" moves from the first to the fourth without passing through claimed object or interpretation.

Examiner trap 1: Scripts that begin with a vivid narration of a mystical episode almost always commit this jump in their second paragraph; open instead by naming which of the four layers the stem is buying.

MCQ 2. Which marks entitle a state to be called mystical

In *The Varieties of Religious Experience*, which pair does James treat as jointly sufficient to entitle a state to be called mystical?

- A. Transiency and passivity, since brevity and receptivity are the two features that separate a mystical state from ordinary discursive reasoning.
- B. Ineffability and noetic quality, since defiance of adequate expression and presented insight together settle the classification.
- C. Passivity and noetic quality, since being grasped by a superior power is what marks a genuine disclosure.
- D. Ineffability and transiency, since a state that could be adequately stated, or sustained at will, would be an ordinary episode of cognition.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: these are the two marks James describes as "less sharply marked" and merely usual; promoting them to definitional status is exactly the error his grading is designed to prevent.
- **B:** Correct: James's own grading makes ineffability, "the handiest" mark, and noetic quality, insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect, the two marks that entitle a state to the name.
- **C:** Incorrect: it pairs one defining mark with one usual mark, which reproduces the flat-list error in a subtler form and would exclude states that are not felt as passive.
- **D:** Incorrect: transiency is a usual accompaniment, not a criterion, and treating brevity as definitional would disqualify stable realisation from the category altogether.

Examiner trap 2: The flat four-mark list is the single commonest error in this clause; write the two-plus-two grading in the first body paragraph of any James answer.

MCQ 3. What James's grading makes possible

Why does the grading of James's marks matter for the Indian-Western comparison?

- A. Because transiency is only a usual mark, a stable and established liberating knowledge (*jñāna*) can still count as a mystical state.
- B. Because passivity is definitional, only those experiences produced entirely by grace, with no preparatory discipline at all, count as mystical states.
- C. Because ineffability is only usual, traditions that describe their highest experiences in elaborate technical detail remain fully classifiable as mystical.
- D. Because noetic quality is only usual, an experience carrying no sense of insight or disclosure whatever can still be classified as a mystical state.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: since duration is a statistical accompaniment rather than a criterion, Advaitic *jñāna* - settled knowledge rather than an episode - is not disqualified, and the comparison the paper rewards becomes possible.
- **B:** Incorrect: passivity is one of the two usual marks, and James expressly allows that voluntary preliminary operations may facilitate the onset.
- **C:** Incorrect: ineffability is one of the two defining marks, so the option inverts James's grading and would make the classification depend on descriptive richness.
- **D:** Incorrect: noetic quality is the second defining mark, and removing it would leave a mere feeling with no claim to disclosure at all.

Examiner trap 3: Candidates who list four equal marks have, without noticing, defined the Indian case out of the mystical category and then cannot run the comparison the question wants.

MCQ 4. Medical materialism and the maxim about fruits

Which statement about James's method is accurate?

- A. He coined the maxim about fruits himself and then used medical materialism as his working test of religious authenticity in the case histories.
- B. He rejects medical materialism as a fallacy about origins and adopts the scriptural maxim about fruits as the criterion in its place.
- C. He accepts medical materialism for the clearly pathological cases and rejects the appeal to fruits on the ground that it is pragmatically circular.
- D. He treats medical materialism as a method of discernment and derives the maxim about fruits from his own psychology.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses both attributions - the maxim is Matthew 7:16/20, which James adopts, and medical materialism is the fallacy he names in order to reject it.
- **B:** Correct: medical materialism is James's own term in Lecture I for discrediting a state by its physiological or pathological origin, and the biblical maxim is the consequential criterion he adopts in its place.
- **C:** Incorrect: James makes no such concession, and the appeal to fruits is precisely the test he retains after refusing origin-based dismissal.
- **D:** Incorrect: medical materialism is a fallacy for James, not a procedure, and the maxim is scriptural rather than a product of his psychology.

Examiner trap 4: Attributing "by their fruits ye shall know them" to James rather than to Matthew is a small error that a well-read examiner reads as a large one.

MCQ 5. The second deliverable of the 2022 stem

The 2022 stem asks for the nature *and variety* of religious experiences as presented by James. Which set correctly supplies the "variety" half?

- A. Extrovertive and introvertive mysticism, together with the five phenomenological marks that are shared between the two types.
- B. Nature mysticism, monistic mysticism and theistic mysticism, ranked in ascending order of completeness and adequacy.
- C. Healthy-mindedness and the sick soul, the divided self resolved in conversion, saintliness as durable fruits, and mysticism.
- D. Propositional revelation, non-propositional revelation, and the faithful experiencing-as of a religiously ambiguous event.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is Stace's classification from *Mysticism and Philosophy*, not James's survey of the forms of personal religion.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is Zaehner's threefold scheme with its contested ranking, and attributing it to James confuses two authors writing half a century apart.
- **C:** Correct: these are the varieties of personal religion James actually studies - two temperaments before evil, the divided self resolved by conversion, the durable fruits of saintliness, and the experiential pole of mysticism.
- **D:** Incorrect: this belongs to the analysis of revelation and derives from Hick's model, not from James's psychological survey.

Examiner trap 5: A script that answers 2022 with the four marks alone has completed one of two printed deliverables and has capped its own marks.

MCQ 6. The anatomy of the numinous

Which reading of *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* is correct?

- A. Wholly other and incommensurable with ordinary categories, at once overpowering in its majesty and irresistibly attractive.
- B. Mysterious in its origin, terrifying in the moral demand it imposes, and delightful in the reward that it holds out to the obedient.
- C. Unknown for the present, dreadful in the judgement it pronounces, and fascinating precisely because it can never in principle be understood.
- D. Incomprehensible by definition, frightening to the ignorant and the unprepared, and pleasing only to those who have already been made holy.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Otto's three components are the mystery of the wholly other, the *tremendum* of awefulness, overpoweringness and energy, and the *fascinans* that attracts even while it terrifies.
- **B:** Incorrect: it moralises the *tremendum* into a demand and the *fascinans* into a reward, which is exactly the rational-ethical schematisation Otto says comes *after* the numinous datum.
- **C:** Incorrect: the *mysterium* is not merely what is not yet known but what is incommensurable with ordinary categories, and permanent unintelligibility is not what *fascinans* names.
- **D:** Incorrect: it distributes dread and attraction across two different classes of person, whereas Otto's point is that both are present in one state, in one subject, at once.

Examiner trap 6: Write the Latin in full once and then translate it; a script that uses the phrase without unpacking all three components has quoted rather than explained.

MCQ 7. Non-rational, schematisation, and the Schleiermacher comparison

Which statement about Otto is most accurate?

- A. The numinous is irrational, so moral and rational predicates contradict it and must be dropped from theology altogether as category mistakes.
- B. The numinous is identical with Schleiermacher's feeling of absolute dependence, restated in Latin vocabulary for a twentieth-century readership.
- C. The numinous is non-rational - not reducible to conceptual or moral judgement - and is later schematised by rational and ethical concepts alike.
- D. The numinous is a rational intuition of perfect goodness from which the accompanying feelings of awe and fascination are subsequently derived.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Otto claims non-rationality and denies irrationality, and he retains moral and rational predicates as later schematisations rather than discarding them.
- **B:** Incorrect: dependence characterises the subject's own condition, whereas the numinous is constituted by its directedness to a wholly other; Otto's account is usually read as a correction of Schleiermacher, not a translation of him.
- **C:** Correct: non-rational means not exhausted by conceptual-moral judgement, and Otto holds that rational and ethical predicates are applied to the holy afterwards, in schematisation.
- **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the order of Otto's analysis by making the moral intuition primary and the numinous derivative, which is the position he wrote *The Idea of the Holy* to refute.

Examiner trap 7: Glossing "non-rational" as "irrational" converts Otto's central claim into one he explicitly denies, and examiners treat it as a comprehension failure rather than a slip.

MCQ 8. Stace's introvertive type and his methodological move

Which description of Stace's position is correct?

- A. Introvertive mysticism perceives the One shining through the many, while extrovertive mysticism excludes all sensory and conceptual content whatever.
- B. Both types are equally complete, and Stace declines to rank them at all on the ground that any ranking would be confessionally motivated.
- C. The two types share no phenomenological marks, and whatever unity they have is asserted at the level of doctrine rather than of experience.
- D. Introvertive mysticism excludes all sensory and conceptual content, leaving a unitary contentless consciousness that Stace treats as the higher type.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the descriptions are transposed - perceiving the One through the multiplicity of sensed objects is the extrovertive type, not the introvertive.
- **B:** Incorrect: Stace does rank, treating introvertive mysticism as the higher and more complete type; the confessional-ranking charge is levelled at Zaehner.
- **C:** Incorrect: Stace's whole argument depends on shared marks - objectivity, blessedness, holiness, paradoxicality and ineffability - reported within the descriptions themselves.
- **D:** Correct: the introvertive type is defined by the exclusion of sensory and conceptual content, and Stace's separation of experience from interpretation then grounds the common-core thesis.

Examiner trap 8: The extrovertive and introvertive labels are frequently transposed under time pressure; anchor them by remembering that extrovertive looks *outward* through the senses.

MCQ 9. Zaehner's typology and how to handle his ranking

Which treatment of Zaehner is defensible?

- A. Retain the ranking, since theistic mysticism preserves the creature-creator distinction and is on that ground the more complete and adequate type.
- B. Reject the whole scheme, since a classification produced by a religious convert with a confessional commitment can carry no philosophical content.
- C. Retain the nature, monistic and theistic classification while dropping the ranking, since monistic and theistic reports genuinely differ in logical form.
- D. Merge his three types with Stace's two, since taken together they yield a comprehensive fivefold classification of the varieties of mystical state.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: preserving a distinction is a structural feature, not a measure of completeness, and the ranking is the element most widely criticised as confessionally motivated.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is a genetic fallacy of the same shape James condemned as medical materialism, and it discards a classification that does real comparative work.
- **C:** Correct: the classification survives the criticism because identity-reports and relation-reports differ in logical form, and a common-core theory owes an explanation of that difference.
- **D:** Incorrect: the two schemes are rivals answering opposite questions about a common core, so adding them together produces confusion rather than a fivefold typology.

Examiner trap 9: Merging Stace and Zaehner into one "typology of mysticism" destroys the very disagreement the topic exists to examine.

MCQ 10. Katz, Forman and where the dispute is decided

Which statement about the constructivism debate is accurate?

- A. Katz holds that there are no unmediated experiences at all, and Forman's Pure Consciousness Event contests that thesis at the contentless limit.
- B. Katz holds that all mystics undergo one and the same experience, and Forman argues that they undergo many experiences that are differently described.
- C. Forman holds that tradition constitutes the experience itself, and Katz replies that a contentless state refutes that claim.
- D. Both hold that mediation makes mystical reports fabrications, and they differ only over which traditions are most heavily implicated in the fabrication.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Katz's 1978 thesis makes tradition, expectation and practice constitutive of the experience, and Forman's contentless state is offered as the one case that offers nothing for concepts to shape.
- **B:** Incorrect: it reverses the positions, assigning the common-core thesis to the constructivist and constructivism to his critic.
- **C:** Incorrect: the names are transposed; Forman is the defender of the contentless case, not the proponent of constitution by tradition.
- **D:** Incorrect: neither concludes that mediation entails fabrication, and mediated perception is still perception, which is precisely why the debate concerns an inference rather than the reports.

Examiner trap 10: Constructivism attacks the *inference* from cross-cultural similarity to a shared object; treating it as a proof that mystical experience is invented overstates it in a way the examiner will mark down.

MCQ 11. The structure of Advaitic realisation

Which formulation states the main structural feature of Advaitic religious experience?

- A. A purified subject perceives Brahman as a supremely subtle object presented to the inner sense after long preparatory discipline.
- B. A devotee enters into loving union with Brahman while the distinction between worshipper and worshipped is carefully preserved throughout.
- C. A meditator isolates consciousness from materiality, so that the self remains alone, unrelated and free of every further modification.
- D. Subject-object duality collapses in a non-dual recognition in which the realiser *is* Brahman.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: describing the realisation as a subject perceiving Brahman as an object is precisely the error the doctrine of self-luminosity is designed to exclude.
- **B:** Incorrect: preserved distinction in loving union is Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita and Zaehner's theistic type, not Śaṅkara's non-dualism.
- **C:** Incorrect: the isolation of consciousness from matter is Sāṃkhya-Yoga's aloneness (*kaivalya*), a different structure with a different terminus.
- **D:** Correct: the non-dual (*nirvikalpa*) recognition abolishes the subject-object structure, which is why "I am Brahman" states an identity rather than a relation.

Examiner trap 11: Any sentence of the form "experience of Brahman" invites the objection that Advaita has been dualised; prefer "recognition that the self is Brahman".

MCQ 12. The correct technical use of *anirvacanīya*

In Advaita's technical vocabulary, *anirvacanīya* is properly predicated of which of the following?

- A. *Māyā* and the world-appearance, as indescribable in the terms of either reality or unreality alike.
- B. Brahman itself, understood as the one reality from which all words turn back without ever having grasped what they were reaching for.
- C. The liberating realisation itself, understood as a state whose quality cannot be conveyed to anyone who has not already undergone it.
- D. The qualified Lord, understood as a form that is neither straightforwardly identical with Brahman nor straightforwardly different from Brahman.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the term marks the status of *māyā* and the world-appearance as distinct from both the real and the unreal (*sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*), which is its settled technical use.
- **B:** Incorrect: Brahman's inexpressibility is carried by different vocabulary - beyond objectifying speech (*avācya*), "from which words turn back" - and using *anirvacanīya* here is the scripted error.
- **C:** Incorrect: that is James's ineffability transposed into Sanskrit; the realisation's incommunicability is not what the technical term denotes.
- **D:** Incorrect: the qualified Lord's status is handled by other categories, and the option quietly imports a distinct doctrinal dispute.

Examiner trap 12: A 2025 Religious Language question prints *anirvacanīyatā* in its correct sense; importing it into an Advaita experience answer shows an examiner exactly where the reading stopped.

MCQ 13. Radhakrishnan's inversion

Which statement best represents Radhakrishnan's position in *The Hindu View of Life*?

- A. Creeds generate the very experiences that later appear to confirm them, so doctrine is epistemically prior to intuition in every developed religion.
- B. Direct spiritual experience of the Real is primary and self-certifying, while dogma, creed and ritual are secondary interpretations of that experience.
- C. Religious intuition is a private feeling with no cognitive content at all, so the resulting tolerance follows simply from mutual ignorance of the Real.
- D. Institutional religion is the only reliable route to intuition, which cannot be reached by individual discipline outside an established community.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses the inversion that defines his position, in which experience generates doctrine rather than being generated by it.
- **B:** Correct: religion is grounded in direct, intuitive experience of the Real, which is self-certifying and claimed universal, with creed and ritual as secondary interpretations.
- **C:** Incorrect: integral intuition is explicitly a mode of *knowing* that unites cognition, feeling and will, and his tolerance rests on a shared depth, not on shared ignorance.
- **D:** Incorrect: it makes institutions primary, which is the position his account subordinates to experience.

Examiner trap 13: In a stem that names *The Hindu View of Life*, generic "Indian spirituality" content scores poorly; name the work's own theses before evaluating them.

MCQ 14. "In the light of the Vedāntic tradition"

Why is it a mistake to answer a Vedāntic-experience stem with Advaita alone?

- A. Because Advaita denies that religious experience occurs at all, so another school in the tradition must supply the account.
- B. Because the Vedāntic schools agree entirely on the structure of the experience and differ only over the technical vocabulary that each of them prefers.
- C. Because Advaita is a comparatively later development and therefore cannot be taken to represent the classical position of the tradition as a whole.
- D. Because Rāmānuja and Madhva belong to the tradition and report relation rather than identity, so the tradition contains both of the structures.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Advaita's entire soteriology culminates in direct realisation, so it plainly affirms rather than denies that such experience occurs.
- **B:** Incorrect: the disagreement is structural, since Viśiṣṭādvaita and Dvaita preserve the worshipper whom Advaita's identity-claim dissolves.
- **C:** Incorrect: the chronological claim is neither accurate as stated nor the reason the reduction fails; the reason is internal plurality.
- **D:** Correct: Viśiṣṭādvaita makes selves and world real modes dependent on a personal Brahman and Dvaita hardens the difference further, so "the tradition" contains identity-recognition and intentional encounter together.

Examiner trap 14: The printed word is "tradition", not "Advaita"; reducing the one to the other forfeits the internal comparison that the stem is designed to elicit.

MCQ 15. Four Indian structures and their termini

Which pairing of tradition and claimed terminus is correct throughout?

- A. Advaita - a personal Lord; Yoga - Brahman as the self; devotion - cessation; Buddhism - isolated consciousness alone.
- B. Advaita - the self as Brahman; Yoga - isolated consciousness; devotion - a personal Lord; Buddhism - cessation.
- C. Advaita - cessation; Yoga - a personal Lord; devotion - isolated consciousness; Buddhism - the self as Brahman throughout.
- D. Advaita - isolated consciousness; Yoga - cessation; devotion - the self as Brahman; Buddhism - a personal creator Lord.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: every pairing is displaced, and giving Buddhism the isolation of consciousness attributes a Sāṃkhya-Yoga terminus to a tradition that denies a permanent self.
- **B:** Correct: Advaita's terminus is the self as Brahman, Yoga's is isolated consciousness (*puruṣa*), devotion's is a personal Lord, and Buddhism's is Dharma and cessation (*nirvāṇa*) rather than a creator.
- **C:** Incorrect: assigning cessation to Advaita and Brahman to Buddhism inverts the two traditions whose difference the comparison most needs.
- **D:** Incorrect: it gives Buddhism a personal Lord, which contradicts the standard control that its terminus is not encounter with a creator God.

Examiner trap 15: Writing "Indian mysticism" as a single position is the Indian counterpart of the flat four-mark error; name the structure and the terminus.

MCQ 16. The genus and the species in the 2018 stem

What is the defensible answer to whether one can have God as the object of religion?

- A. No, because the sacred is purely a social classification whereas God is a phenomenological quality disclosed only in numinous awe.
- B. Yes without qualification, since every religion in fact directs its worship toward some supreme personal being under one description or another.
- C. Yes for theistic traditions, in which God is the source and the measure of all holiness, but not as a generic definition of religion.
- D. No, because the non-theistic traditions are more numerous than the theistic ones and their categories should therefore prevail in any definition.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it misassigns the two analyses, since the social classification is Durkheim's sacred and the phenomenological quality is Otto's holy, and neither yields a flat negative.
- **B:** Incorrect: it is falsified by Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā, which sustain a sacred without a responsive personal deity.
- **C:** Correct: God is the paradigm species for theistic traditions and the source and measure of everything else held holy, while a God-centred *definition* would stipulate whole religions out of the category.
- **D:** Incorrect: the argument is conceptual rather than statistical, and counting traditions is not how the adequacy of a definition is decided.

Examiner trap 16: The stem grants the generic category and asks about the specific one, so a flat yes or no answers a question that was not printed.

MCQ 17. Otto's holy against Durkheim's sacred

Which statement expresses the discriminating difference correctly?

- A. Otto's holy is defined by the prohibitions that separate it from the profane, whereas Durkheim's sacred is a quality disclosed to the subject in numinous awe.
- B. Otto's holy is a phenomenological quality of an object disclosed in awe, while Durkheim's sacred is a social classification defined by separation from the profane.
- C. Both are social classifications, differing only over whether the community doing the classifying is a tribal one or a modern industrial one.
- D. Both are phenomenological qualities of the object, differing only over whether it is dread or fascination that predominates in the resulting state.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two accounts have been transposed, since prohibition and separation are Durkheim's apparatus and numinous disclosure is Otto's.
- **B:** Correct: Otto analyses how an object appears in awe, whereas Durkheim analyses how a community sets something apart, and treating them as one word misses the strongest objection to each.
- **C:** Incorrect: it erases Otto's phenomenology entirely and turns his central category into sociology.
- **D:** Incorrect: it erases Durkheim's functional definition, which is precisely the account that requires no deity at all.

Examiner trap 17: This is the highest-yield discriminator in the 2018 module; a script that uses "sacred" and "holy" interchangeably has forfeited it.

MCQ 18. Credulity, testimony and the serious defeater

Which statement is the most defensible summary of the veridicality debate?

- A. The principle of credulity establishes the object publicly, since a seeming is evidence for everyone who hears of it and not merely for the subject.
- B. Neuroscience is the decisive defeater, since a state possessing an identifiable neural correlate stands in need of no further object to explain it.
- C. Fruits demonstrate the object, since a durable moral transformation of the kind James describes could not possibly follow from a false belief.
- D. Experience gives *prima facie* warrant to the subject and testimonial weight to the hearer, with diversity rather than neurology the serious defeater.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: credulity yields defeasible warrant for the one to whom it seems, extended only by testimony, and it never converts a seeming into a public demonstration.
- **B:** Incorrect: correlation identifies mediation, and a defeat additionally requires showing that the mechanism is unreliable or fully explains the seeming without the object.
- **C:** Incorrect: fruits are a criterion of authenticity rather than a proof, and beneficial consequences plainly can follow from beliefs that are false.
- **D:** Correct: this is the graded verdict the clause supports, and diversity outranks neurology because it needs only incompatibility, not a demonstration of unreliability.

Examiner trap 18: Spending the critique on brain regions attacks the weaker defeater; the diversity of incompatible objects is where the argument actually bites.

MCQ 19. The burden carried by a naturalistic explanation

What must a naturalistic explanation establish before it counts as an epistemic defeater?

- A. That the experience was reported by a subject who had an antecedent interest in its turning out to be true rather than illusory.
- B. That the experience can be induced artificially, at least in some subjects, under controlled laboratory conditions.
- C. That the mechanism is unreliable, or that it fully explains the seeming without the proposed object.
- D. That the tradition supplying the interpretation is historically later than the experience it purports to describe and interpret.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: interest is a reason for caution, not a defeater, and applied consistently it would disqualify most testimony including scientific testimony.
- **B:** Incorrect: inducibility shows a sufficient cause, not an unreliable one; ordinary perception can also be induced artificially without becoming non-veridical.
- **C:** Correct: causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things, so the critic must attack reliability or show that the seeming is fully accounted for without the object.
- **D:** Incorrect: the relative dating of a tradition bears on interpretation rather than on the reliability of the experience-producing mechanism.

Examiner trap 19: "It has a neural correlate, therefore it is nothing" is the mirror image of "it felt overwhelming, therefore it is real"; both skip the burden the argument requires.

MCQ 20. What Alston actually concludes

Alston's conclusion in *Perceiving God* is most accurately stated as which of the following?

- A. Mystical perception has been shown to be reliable, so the beliefs formed within it are justified all things considered and not merely defeasibly.
- B. Religious experience proves God's existence, since the theory of appearing applies to non-sensory presentations as much as to sensory ones.
- C. No belief-forming practice whatever is rational, since not one of them can be validated without falling into epistemic circularity.
- D. Engagement in a socially established religious practice is practically rational, and beliefs formed in it are *prima facie* justified.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Alston expressly denies that reliability has been shown, and his justification is *prima facie* rather than *ultima facie*.
- **B:** Incorrect: the theory of appearing is a claim about the structure of perception, not a proof of an object's existence.
- **C:** Incorrect: it inverts the argument, which uses the circularity of sense perception to defend rather than to condemn practice-based belief.
- **D:** Correct: the conclusion is the practical rationality of engaging in a socially established doxastic practice, with M-beliefs enjoying defeasible justification absent sufficient reason to think the practice unreliable.

Examiner trap 20: Reporting Alston as proving religious experience reliable is the standard overstatement in this clause and is easy for an examiner to detect.

MCQ 21. Alston's own concession, and Hick's price

Which pairing of objection and response is correctly stated?

- A. Alston concedes that incompatible practices cannot all track one reality and answers only that one may rationally "sit tight"; Hick's Real is charged with indeterminacy.
- B. Alston resolves the diversity problem by ranking the competing practices against one another; Hick avoids indeterminacy by describing the Real in detail.
- C. Alston denies that the rival mystical practices are genuinely socially established; Hick denies that the traditions conflict with one another at all.
- D. Alston abandons the parity argument as soon as diversity is raised against him; Hick abandons the Real altogether in favour of a modest exclusivism.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Alston treats diversity as the most serious objection and offers only rational persistence absent neutral adjudication, while the standing objection to Hick is that an unknowable Real cannot support determinate doctrine.
- **B:** Incorrect: Alston explicitly declines to rank practices, and detailed description of the Real is precisely what Hick's position forbids.
- **C:** Incorrect: he affirms that rival practices are established, which is exactly what generates the objection, and Hick's whole theory is built on the fact of conflict.
- **D:** Incorrect: neither retreats in that way; Alston keeps the parity argument and Hick keeps the Real, each paying a stated price.

Examiner trap 21: Including Alston's own concession is what separates a strong script from a merely correct one; omitting it makes the exposition look second-hand.

MCQ 22. Mystical experience and revelation

Which consideration best shows that mystical experience and revelation are not identical?

- A. Mystical states are ineffable, whereas revelation is by definition fully expressible in a determinate set of communicated propositions.
- B. Revelation always occurs in a public setting before witnesses, whereas mystical experience always occurs in solitude and without observers.
- C. A unitive state may be reported with no disclosure-claim, and truths may be held revealed through a text with no unitive state at all.
- D. Mystical experience concerns the sacred as such, whereas revelation concerns only the moral commands that are issued to a community.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: revelation is not by definition propositional, since the non-propositional model treats it as divine self-disclosure received in an event.
- **B:** Incorrect: the locations are not fixed in that way, and the contrast between public and solitary does not track the distinction at issue.
- **C:** Correct: each case is actual, and each refutes one direction of the identification, which is why the relation is contingent and functional rather than definitional.
- **D:** Incorrect: it narrows revelation arbitrarily to moral content and ignores its standard doctrinal and self-disclosing forms.

Examiner trap 22: The 2023 stem has a second deliverable - the significance of the relation in religious life - and origination, renewal and the risk of unchecked private authority are the three functions to name.

MCQ 23. Prayer, worship, and the cases that decide between them

Which statement captures the essential distinction and its decisive test cases?

- A. Prayer is address presupposing a responsive God; worship is ascription of supreme worth, which Jain and Mīmāṃsā practice retain without petition.
- B. Prayer is characteristically public and worship characteristically private, and the Indian material merely illustrates that difference without deciding it.
- C. Prayer and worship are synonyms in actual practice, and the distinction survives only as a Western liturgical convention.
- D. Worship requires a responsive deity and prayer does not, which is precisely why the non-theistic traditions retain prayer alone and abandon worship.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the essential acts differ - address against ascription of worth - and the Tīrthaṅkara who is free of passion and Mīmāṃsā's unseen potency (*apūrva*) supply full ritual worship where petition can obtain nothing.
- **B:** Incorrect: the locations are reversed, since prayer is often private and worship characteristically corporate, and the Indian cases decide rather than merely illustrate.
- **C:** Incorrect: the distinction generates correct predictions about which traditions retain which practice, so it is not merely verbal or liturgical.
- **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the presuppositions, since responsiveness is what prayer-as-request needs and supreme value is all that worship needs.

Examiner trap 23: The 2020 stem prints two tasks - distinguish, and determine their place - so an answer that stops after the differentia has completed half the question.

MCQ 24. The graded answer on public discourse

Which conclusion answers "how far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse?" most defensibly?

- A. Fully, since disciplined practices such as meditation and contemplation constitute a genuinely repeatable public experiment open to any observer.
- B. Publicly discussable as description, coherence, tradition-conformity, fruits and practice, but privately probative, since these test authenticity rather than truth.
- C. Not at all, since ineffability and privileged access together make any informative public statement about the experience strictly impossible.
- D. Only politically, since the sole legitimate public question is whether religious reasons may lawfully enter formal state decision-making at all.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the replicability claim must be reported as Vivekananda's and Radhakrishnan's claim and carries its own limit, since the procedure cannot be run by an uncommitted observer.
- **B:** Correct: the six intersubjective criteria are genuinely public and genuinely limited, so the required "how far" is answered by a line drawn between authenticity and evidential transfer.
- **C:** Incorrect: even ineffability is reportable, and James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner built public typologies out of first-person documents.
- **D:** Incorrect: Habermas's translation proviso settles the political sub-question only, leaving the descriptive, doctrinal and practical criteria untouched.

Examiner trap 24: "How far ... Analyse" forbids a yes or a no; the marks are in the line you draw and in your defence of where you drew it.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

MCQ 25. Remedial - "James gives four equally necessary marks of every religious experience"

Which correction is best?

- A. Two marks are defining and two are usual, and all four of them describe mystical states rather than religious experience as such.
- B. All four marks are jointly necessary, but they apply only to conversion experiences rather than to mystical states as James classifies them.
- C. Only one mark is strictly necessary, namely passivity, and the remaining three are optional refinements that some reports happen to add.
- D. The four marks are jointly necessary for religious experience in general, but not for the mystical states that form one variety within it.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: it repairs both halves of the error at once - the grading of the marks and the restriction of their scope to mystical states.
- **B:** Incorrect: it keeps the flat list and then narrows it to the wrong class, since conversion is a separate variety in James's survey.
- **C:** Incorrect: passivity is one of the two merely usual marks and is the least suitable candidate for a single necessary condition.
- **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the scope restriction, extending the marks to religious experience at large while withdrawing them from the states they were formulated for.

Examiner trap 25: Correcting only the scope, or only the grading, leaves half the error standing; state both in one sentence.

MCQ 26. Remedial - "If a mystical experience is ineffable, it is meaningless"

Which reformulation is correct?

- A. Ineffability entails that no true statement whatever can be made about the state, so a disciplined silence is the only honest response available.
- B. Ineffability is a rhetorical exaggeration on the mystic's part, since mystics in fact describe their states at very considerable length.
- C. Ineffability limits the exhaustiveness of report, not the possibility of every statement, so partial and analogical description remains available.
- D. Ineffability applies to the claimed object rather than to the state, so the state itself can in principle be described completely and exactly.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it treats a limit on adequacy as a prohibition on speech, which would make James's own two lectures of description impossible.
- **B:** Incorrect: dismissing the mark as exaggeration removes one of the two marks James makes definitional rather than explaining it.
- **C:** Correct: the mark restricts adequacy rather than intelligibility, which is why comparative typologies could be built from first-person reports at all.
- **D:** Incorrect: it relocates the mark to the object and then over-claims, since complete description of the state is not what any account here asserts.

Examiner trap 26: Equating ineffability with meaninglessness also destroys the public-discourse answer, because it removes the phenomenological description that the "yes" case is built on.

MCQ 27. Remedial - "Advaita is the perception of Brahman as an object"

Which correction is best?

- A. Advaita treats Brahman as an object of inference rather than of perception, so the correct vocabulary for the realisation is inferential throughout.
- B. Advaita treats the realisation as a non-objective recognition of the self as Brahman, since self-luminous consciousness cannot be an object at all.
- C. Advaita treats Brahman as an object presented within a specially purified perception that becomes available only after very long preparatory discipline.
- D. Advaita treats Brahman as an object throughout the period of practice and as a subject only at the final moment of liberation itself.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: substituting inference for perception keeps the objectifying structure that the doctrine of self-luminosity rejects.
- **B:** Correct: witnessing consciousness is presupposed by subject-object cognition and therefore cannot itself be objectified, so the realisation is recognition rather than presentation.
- **C:** Incorrect: purifying the perception does not remove the objectification; it merely refines it, leaving the same structural error in place.
- **D:** Incorrect: the two-stage account is not Advaita's, and it would make the decisive structural claim depend on a change of standpoint at the last moment.

Examiner trap 27: Answers that say "experience of Brahman" invite the dualising objection even when the surrounding paragraph is correct; change the phrase, not just the argument.

MCQ 28. Remedial - "Otto's holy and Durkheim's sacred are the same idea"

Which correction is best?

- A. They are one and the same idea expressed in two different disciplinary vocabularies, so nothing philosophical whatever turns on the difference between them.
- B. They differ only in their intended scope, since Otto's account covers the theistic religions and Durkheim's covers the tribal and totemic ones.
- C. Otto analyses a phenomenological quality disclosed in awe, while Durkheim analyses a social classification defined by separation and by prohibition.
- D. Otto analyses a social classification and Durkheim a phenomenological quality, so the attribution usually made in textbooks is exactly reversed.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the difference determines which objection each account faces, so treating it as terminological removes the evaluative content of the module.
- **B:** Incorrect: the contrast is one of method rather than of coverage, and Durkheim's definition is designed to be perfectly general.
- **C:** Correct: one describes how an object appears to a subject in numinous awe, the other describes how a community sets something apart, and each attracts a different criticism.
- **D:** Incorrect: it simply transposes the two authors, which is the same error in a different direction.

Examiner trap 28: This distinction is worth stating explicitly even in answers that are not about 2018, because it also disciplines the use of "sacred" as the generic object-term.

MCQ 29. Remedial - "Alston proved that religious experience is reliable"

Which correction is best?

- A. Alston proved reliability for one practice only, namely the Christian mystical one, and left every other established religious practice unexamined.
- B. Alston proved that religious experience is in fact unreliable, and therefore defends religious belief entirely on grounds that are not experiential.
- C. Alston abandoned the reliability question altogether and defended religious belief instead as properly basic in Plantinga's Reformed-epistemology sense.
- D. Alston argues only for the practical rationality of engaging in an established practice, since no practice at all can ever be validated non-circularly.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no reliability proof is offered for any practice, and rival practices are precisely what he concedes he cannot adjudicate.
- **B:** Incorrect: it inverts his conclusion, since he defends the rationality of engagement rather than attacking the practice.
- **C:** Incorrect: proper basicity is Plantinga's apparatus in the Reformed-epistemology debate; Alston's route is the parity of doxastic practices.
- **D:** Correct: the parity argument yields practical rationality and *prima facie* justification for M-beliefs, not a demonstration of reliability.

Examiner trap 29: Overstating Alston also weakens the answer, because the overstated version is easy to refute while the accurate version shifts the burden onto the sceptic.

MCQ 30. Remedial - "The experience has a neural correlate, so it is nothing"

Which correction is best?

- A. Neural correlates are wholly absent in the genuine mystical states, and that absence is what distinguishes them from episodes of ordinary perception.
- B. Neural correlation shows mediation; a defeat further requires showing unreliability, or a full explanation of the seeming without the object.
- C. Neural correlation is wholly irrelevant to philosophy of religion and should therefore be excluded from any philosophical answer entirely.
- D. Neural correlation proves veridicality, since the presence of a physical basis shows that the experience in question was not merely imagined.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the empirical claim is unsupported, and the position would make mystical states uniquely disembodied for no stated reason.
- **B:** Correct: causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things, so the critic must attack reliability or show that the seeming is fully accounted for without the proposed object.
- **C:** Incorrect: the material is legitimate as a form of the naturalistic critique; what is illegitimate is treating correlation as conclusion.
- **D:** Incorrect: it commits the mirror error, converting a mechanism into a warrant instead of into a defeat.

Examiner trap 30: The clause's own guidance restricts dated news anchors and warns against filling answers with brain-region catalogues; one accurate sentence on mediation is worth more than a paragraph of neuroscience.

MCQ 31. Remedial - "Indian mysticism is one thing"

Which correction is best?

- A. Indian traditions differ only over the deity that is named, since every one of them culminates in a loving union with some personal Lord.
- B. Indian traditions differ only over the method employed, since every one of them culminates in the same non-dual realisation of one reality.
- C. Indian traditions all agree with Zaehner's monistic type, so the whole comparison can safely be run on a single row of the bench.
- D. Indian traditions report at least four different structures - identity, isolation, relation and insight - with four different termini.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: union with a personal Lord is the devotional structure alone and is explicitly denied by Advaita's identity-claim and by Buddhist analysis.
- **B:** Incorrect: it assimilates Yoga, devotion and Buddhism to Advaita, which is the very assimilation charge pressed against Radhakrishnan.
- **C:** Incorrect: Zaehner's monistic type does not accommodate devotional relation or Buddhist insight, so a single row cannot carry the comparison.
- **D:** Correct: Advaita reports identity, Sāṃkhya-Yoga isolation, devotional traditions a graced relation and Buddhism insight terminating in cessation, and each carries its own control.

Examiner trap 31: A comparison paragraph that says "Indian mysticism" without naming a structure reads as second-hand even when its individual facts are correct.

MCQ 32. Remedial - answering only one of two printed deliverables

A stem reads: "Distinguish between prayer and worship and determine their place in religion." A script gives an excellent six-axis distinction and stops. What is the correct diagnosis?

- A. The script has completed one of two separately marked tasks, so its ceiling is set by the missing placement analysis.
- B. The script is complete as it stands, since determining their place in religion follows automatically once the essential distinction has been drawn.
- C. The script has failed outright, because a distinction offered without supporting examples cannot be credited by an examiner at all.
- D. The script should have omitted the distinction entirely, since the instruction to determine their place already subsumes the earlier task.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: six of the eight printed stems in this clause carry two deliverables, and a complete treatment of the first alone caps the script below its content value.
- **B:** Incorrect: placement requires a further argument about the relational and evaluative functions of each practice, which no distinction supplies by itself.
- **C:** Incorrect: an excellent distinction is creditable work; the defect is incompleteness, not worthlessness.
- **D:** Incorrect: the stem prints both tasks, and dropping the first would forfeit the marks allocated to it.

Examiner trap 32: Decode the directive before writing: "distinguish ... and determine", "examine ... and expound", "nature and variety", "nature and object" are all double-barrelled, and the second barrel is where scripts most often fail.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified previous-year questions - 8 complete solutions

Word bands used throughout. 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words. Every question below is reproduced in its **exact printed wording** from the audited Philosophy of Religion previous-year ledger, 2018-2025, in which this clause owns exactly one part in every paper. **The model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

Timing skeleton. 10 marks - 1 minute to decode, 1 to outline, 6 to write, 1 to check. 15 marks - 1 / 2 / 10 / 2. 20 marks - 2 / 3 / 13 / 2. **Standing penalties in this clause:** an ungraded four-mark list; an unanswered second deliverable; a verdict that summarises instead of deciding; and any invented year for Schleiermacher, Swinburne, Hick, Forman or Teresa.

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: The terms 'Sacred' and 'Holy' have come to serve as generic names for the object of religion. Do you agree that one can have God as the object of religion? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Explain why "sacred" and "holy" can cover religion generally; distinguish their major meanings; then give a graded answer on whether God may be religion's object without making God its universally necessary object.

Model solution: The "object of religion" is that ultimate reality, power, state or value toward which religious consciousness and practice are directed. My thesis is graded: God can certainly be the object of religion in theistic traditions, but cannot define the object of religion generically. "Sacred" is the broader comparative category; God is the theistic paradigm within it.

The terms "holy" and "sacred" are not exact synonyms. In *The Idea of the Holy*, Rudolf Otto treats the Holy, prior to its moral schematisation, as the **numinous**—the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. Its object is experienced as mysterious and "wholly other," producing creature-feeling, dread and fascination. Otto's account is phenomenological: it describes how the object appears. Emile Durkheim, by contrast, defines the sacred socially through its separation from the profane and the prohibitions and communal practices surrounding it. Mircea Eliade adds the idea of **hierophany**: the sacred manifests and structures religious space, time and orientation. Thus Otto's holy is a distinctive quality disclosed in experience, whereas Durkheim's sacred is a social classification. Collapsing them obscures the difference between phenomenology and function.

These generic terms are useful because religion is wider than theism. Buddhism relates life to Dharma, nirvāṇa and awakening without a creator-God. Jainism venerates the liberated Tīrthaṅkara and *siddha*, not a world-creating deity. Mīmāṃsā treats the Veda as *apauruṣeya* and ritual efficacy through *apūrva*, without requiring a divine author or grantor. Indian categories such as *pavitra*, *maṅgala*, *tīrtha* and *kṣetra* also show that purity, auspiciousness, sacred space and soteriological power—not only Otto's awe—organise religious life.

Nevertheless, God can be the object of religion. In classical theism, Judaism, Islam, Christianity, Viśiṣṭādvaita and many bhakti traditions, prayer, worship and revelation are intentionally directed toward a personal divine reality. God is not merely one sacred item among others but the source and measure of holiness: persons, texts and places are holy through relation to God. "Object" here must not imply an ordinary finite object passively inspected. It means the intentional pole of faith, worship and encounter—an inexhaustible subject who addresses the worshipper.

Two objections qualify this account. First, "sacred" may become so broad that flags, nations or celebrities count as religious objects. The reply is to add a **soteriological condition**: the religiously sacred is related to the diagnosis and overcoming of the fundamental human predicament. Second, a theist may object that calling God a "species" of the sacred subordinates God to a higher genus. The reply is conceptual, not ontological: comparative philosophy needs a category covering diverse religions; it does not deny the theist's claim that God is ontologically ultimate.

Finally, identifying a claimed object must be separated from establishing its reality. Otto may accurately describe numinous intentionality without proving a numinous being, just as Durkheim may explain sacred classification without exhausting its possible transcendent reference. The phenomenology of an object, the specification of that object and the warrant for believing it exists are distinct questions.

An Indian-Western comparison further qualifies the word "object." In theistic mysticism and prayer, God is encountered through an I-Thou relation. Radhakrishnan and Advaita, however, interpret the highest realisation non-dually: Brahman is not confronted as an Other but realised as the depth of self. Buddhism may regard even substantial "object" language as misleading. Hence comparative philosophy must allow object to mean the ultimate intentional or soteriological pole, not invariably a separately existing personal being.

Therefore, one can have God as the object of religion, decisively so within theism. But God cannot serve as religion's universal defining object without excluding non-theistic religions by stipulation. The best verdict is: **the sacred is the comparative genus; God is theism's paradigm instance and, for the believer, the source of all holiness.**

Why this earns marks: Directly answers the "do you agree" clause; distinguishes Otto, Durkheim and Eliade; supplies Indian non-theistic counter-cases; separates object from warrant; handles two objections; ends with a graded verdict.

PYQ 2 - 2019, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse? Analyse.

Demand decoding: Give a degree, not a yes/no. Separate public description and assessment from public proof, identify limits created by privacy and ineffability, and state precisely what remains publicly discussable.

Model solution: Religious experience can enter public discourse extensively as **reported data, interpreted meaning and disciplined practice**, but only limitedly as publicly compelling evidence for its transcendent object. The crucial distinction is between discussing an experience, testing the authenticity of its report and proving what the experience claims to disclose.

The case against public discourse begins with first-person privacy. William James calls mystical states ineffable and grants them authority primarily for the experiencer, not for outsiders. Their felt certainty is not transferable. Unlike ordinary perception, there may be no neutral procedure by which observers reproduce the episode and correct misidentification. Wittgenstein's private-language considerations deepen the worry: a wholly private criterion cannot sustain a stable distinction between seeming right and being right. In political settings, Rawlsian public reason also bars private revelation from functioning as a coercive reason binding citizens who do not share it.

Yet privacy does not entail silence. First, **phenomenological descriptions** are public: James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner constructed comparative classifications from first-person testimony. Even saying that an experience is ineffable conveys its limits and effects; ineffability means resistance to exhaustive expression, not unintelligibility. Second, reports can be tested for internal coherence, consistency with other beliefs and absence of obvious pathology or manipulation. Third, traditions maintain public rules of discernment-spiritual direction, doctrinal checks and the guru's examination of a disciple. Fourth, James's test by "fruits" concerns observable moral integration and conduct, though good effects establish authenticity more readily than metaphysical truth.

The Indian contribution strengthens the intersubjective case. *Yoga, dhyāna* and *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* are presented as disciplined procedures with stated preconditions and expected transformations. This is not laboratory replication, because training and commitment shape access; nevertheless, it resembles expert perception, which also requires acquired capacities. William Alston's account of socially established doxastic practices similarly makes religious experience a legitimate subject of public argument about inputs, outputs and override procedures, while not proving the practice reliable from a neutral standpoint.

The strongest objection remains that these criteria test sincerity, coherence and authenticity, not the existence of God or Brahman. That objection should be conceded. Habermas offers an appropriate political analogue: religious claims may enter the informal public sphere in their own language, but must be translated into generally accessible reasons before formal state decisions.

Thus religious experience is publicly discussable in description, comparison, interpretation, moral consequences and disciplined modes of cultivation. Its first-person evidential force, however, cannot be transferred intact. The analytically defensible verdict is: **publicly assessable and privately probative, but not publicly demonstrative.**

Why this earns marks: Obeyes "how far"; distinguishes discourse, authenticity and truth; uses James, Wittgenstein, Alston and Indian disciplines; concedes the decisive limitation; gives a precise graded conclusion.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Distinguish between prayer and worship and determine their place in religion.

Demand decoding: Complete both tasks: establish the essential differentia between prayer and worship, including overlap and non-theistic cases, and then explain the distinct function of each in religious life.

Model solution: Prayer and worship overlap, especially in adoration, but they are not synonyms. **Prayer is address or communication directed toward the divine; worship is the acknowledgement and enactment of supreme worth.** Prayer normally presupposes an addressee capable of hearing; worship requires only a reality regarded as ultimately valuable.

Prayer may be verbal or silent, spontaneous or prescribed, private or congregational. Its classical forms are summarised by ACTS: adoration, confession, thanksgiving and supplication; intercession and contemplative prayer may be added. Worship is characteristically embodied, ritual and communal-prostration, liturgy, offering, praise and sacred observance. Adoration is the intersection: as address it is prayer; as attribution of unsurpassable worth it is worship. Petition, however, is prayer without necessarily being the core of worship.

Wordless contemplation is a limit case: communicative directedness can remain even when articulated requests disappear, so silence alone does not convert prayer into worship.

This distinction exposes different philosophical problems. Petitionary prayer appears redundant if God is omniscient, perfectly good and immutable: God already knows the need, wills the best and cannot be altered. Aquinas replies that prayer does not change the divine will; God may ordain that certain goods be obtained **through** prayer, making it a secondary cause. Eleonore Stump further argues that asking has relational value: it preserves a friendship-like structure between giver and recipient. The reply explains prayer's place even if it does not prove that events causally depend on petitions.

Worship faces James Rachels' autonomy objection: unconditional obedience seems incompatible with responsible moral agency. But worship need not mean surrendering moral judgement. It can be recognition of perfect worth, gratitude and self-transformation; obedience to a perfectly good being would not license evil.

Indian traditions show why worship is broader than prayer. Jain *caitya-vandana* honours a *vītarāga* Tīrthaṅkara who neither intervenes nor answers petitions. Mīmāṃsā locates ritual efficacy in *apūrva*, not a granting deity. Buddhist *pūjā* can be commemorative and dispositional. Advaita treats *upāsana* of saṁyama Brahman as spiritually effective at the *vyāvahārika* level, though ultimately transcended in non-dual knowledge. Hence worship survives where petitionary address is absent.

Prayer is religion's **relational organ**: it gives practical form to dependence, trust, confession and hope. Worship is its **evaluative and communal organ**: it marks the sacred as ultimate, forms a community and disciplines desire through embodied practice. A religion may survive without petition; it cannot survive without worship in the broad sense of orienting life toward what is held supremely valuable. Therefore worship is more nearly universal, while prayer expresses the specifically dialogical dimension of religion.

Why this earns marks: Gives a sharp essential distinction, identifies overlap, addresses petition and autonomy, uses Aquinas, Stump and Rachels, adds decisive Indian non-theistic cases, and determines each practice's religious function.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the concept of religious experience in the light of Vedāntic tradition.

Demand decoding: Use Vedānta's own categories and acknowledge internal plurality. Explain immediate realisation, its preparation, nature and object, then distinguish Advaitic identity from qualified-non-dual and dualistic encounter.

Model solution: In Vedānta, religious experience is not merely an intense feeling but the culmination of a disciplined search for liberating knowledge of the relation among self, world and Brahman. Its common aspiration is **direct realisation-anubhava** or *aparokṣānubhūti*-yet Vedāntic schools differ on whether this realisation is identity with Brahman or communion with a distinct Lord.

The Upaniṣadic background gives priority to transformative knowledge. Scripture (*śruti*) discloses what sense perception cannot, reason removes contradiction, and spiritual discipline makes the aspirant fit for realisation. Thus experience is not an isolated psychological episode. It arises through ethical preparation, hearing (*śravaṇa*), reflection (*manana*), meditation (*nididhyāsana*), devotion or divine grace, according to the school concerned.

For Śaṅkara's Advaita, the highest experience is the non-objective recognition that ātman is Brahman, articulated by *aham brahmāsmi*. Subject-object duality belongs to ignorance; Brahman cannot be confronted as an external object because it is self-luminous consciousness presupposed by every act of knowing. The realisation is non-dual, self-certifying and liberating, and stable *jñāna* is more important than a passing ecstasy. It is beyond exhaustive objectifying language, but not unintelligible. Nor should it be called *anirvacanīya*: technically, that term characterises māyā or world-appearance, not Brahman-realisation.

Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita rejects the erasure of difference. Brahman is personal, with selves and world as real modes dependent upon God. Religious fulfilment therefore takes the form of loving knowledge, devotion and communion, not the disappearance of the worshipper. Madhva's Dvaita makes the distinction stronger: God and soul remain eternally different, and saving experience is a grace-enabled relation to Viṣṇu. Vedānta consequently includes both **identity-recognition** and **intentional encounter**.

The epistemic status also varies accordingly. Advaita calls realisation self-certifying because self-luminous consciousness is not established through a second cognition. Devotional schools place greater weight on scripture, grace and the transformed relation of dependence. In every case, however, the experience is soteriological: it is assessed by whether it removes ignorance, egoism and bondage, not simply by its emotional intensity. This distinguishes Vedāntic *anubhava* from an unregulated private impression.

An objection follows: if these accounts have incompatible structures, "Vedāntic experience" may be only doctrinal interpretation imposed upon ambiguous states. The reply is not to manufacture a flat common core. Rather, mediation need not equal fabrication: each school offers a disciplined practice, conceptual grammar and tests of transformation through which experience is identified. Still, these internal criteria do not by themselves prove the metaphysical object to outsiders.

Therefore Vedāntic religious experience is best understood as tradition-guided, transformative and soteriological directness to the Real. Its distinctive philosophical range runs from Advaita's non-dual self-recognition to the devotional schools' enduring relation with a personal Brahman.

Why this earns marks: Uses internal Vedāntic vocabulary; covers preparation and liberation; distinguishes Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja and Madhva; preserves identity-versus-relation; handles the mediation objection without flattening differences.

PYQ 5 - 2022, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the nature and variety of religious experiences as presented by William James.

Demand decoding: Present James's empirical-pragmatic method, correctly grade the marks of mystical states, and cover the wider varieties of personal religion rather than reducing the answer to a flat four-item list.

Model solution: In *The Varieties of Religious Experience*, William James studies religion empirically through first-person documents and pragmatically through its effects on life. Religious experience is primarily personal before it becomes institutional, and its value cannot be dismissed merely by tracing a neurological or pathological origin. James calls such dismissal "medical materialism": causal origin alone does not decide truth or worth.

James's celebrated four marks apply specifically to **mystical states**, not to all religious experience, and they are not equal. **Ineffability** and **noetic quality** are the two defining marks. The experience cannot be adequately conveyed to one who has not undergone it, yet it presents itself as insight into depths unavailable to discursive intellect. Ineffability is therefore not unintelligibility, and noetic force is felt authority rather than independently demonstrated knowledge.

Transiency and **passivity** are usual but less sharply marked accompaniments. Mystical states are commonly brief; once they begin, the subject feels grasped by a superior power, though voluntary practices may prepare their onset.

James's "variety" is broader than mysticism. He contrasts healthy-minded religion, which affirms goodness and harmony, with the religion of the "sick soul," acutely conscious of evil, guilt and dividedness. The divided self seeks unification, often through conversion. Saintliness names the durable moral and affective fruits of religious transformation. Mysticism represents the direct experiential pole in which the self feels connected with a wider "MORE," sometimes mediated through the subconscious. James accordingly judges religious life by enduring fruits rather than unusual intensity alone.

These forms are not a rigid hierarchy. James's case-based method asks how temperaments confront evil, attain unification and produce a workable religious life. It preserves plurality within personal religion instead of deriving every case from one creed.

His great strength is methodological openness: he takes testimony seriously without allowing private conviction to coerce outsiders. Mystical experience may rationally authorise the experiencer, but it establishes no unconditional authority over others. This is also the limit of his epistemology. Good fruits may authenticate transformation but cannot prove that the "MORE" exists; culturally conflicting experiences intensify the problem.

An Indian comparison clarifies James's own grading. Advaitic *jñāna* can be stable and established rather than transient, and the culmination of disciplined inquiry rather than sheer passivity. It can still qualify as mystical because James makes ineffability and noetic quality defining, while transiency and passivity are only usual.

Thus James offers a rich phenomenology and psychology of personal religion-healthy-mindedness, sick soul, conversion, saintliness and mysticism-while keeping its metaphysical object open. His account is strongest as empirical classification and pragmatic assessment, not as a proof of veridicality.

Why this earns marks: Correctly grades James's marks; covers method, "medical materialism," "MORE," conversion and saintliness; distinguishes personal authority from public proof; uses Indian comparison analytically.

PYQ 6 - 2023, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Examine the relation between mystical experience and revelation and expound their significance in the religious life.

Demand decoding: Define both terms, analyse several possible relations without identifying them, and then separately explain what each contributes to religious life, including criteria that limit private revelation.

Model solution: Mystical experience is an immediate or apparently immediate awareness of, union with or identity in ultimate reality. Revelation is disclosure of religious truth or divine reality. They may converge, but they are not identical: mystical experience concerns a mode of consciousness, while revelation concerns disclosure and its claimed authority.

Their relation can take three forms. First, mystical experience may be a **vehicle of non-propositional revelation**: God or the Real is disclosed through presence rather than sentences. Otto's numinous encounter and theistic mysticism exemplify disclosure as experienced relation. Second, propositions may arise as interpretations of the experience; the experience is primary, while doctrines articulate what was encountered. William James's noetic quality explains why mystics regard their states as revelatory, but James restricts their authority to the subject. Third, prior revelation can discipline experience. A scriptural and ritual tradition supplies categories, practices and criteria through which an episode is cultivated and identified.

The relation differs in Indian traditions. In Advaita, *śruti* does not reveal Brahman as an external object. It removes ignorance and prepares *aparokṣānubhūti*, the recognition that ātman is Brahman. Here revelation and mystical realisation are complementary: textual testimony points, reason clarifies, and non-dual awareness fulfils the teaching. Theistic Vedānta, by contrast, can interpret mystical experience as grace-enabled communion with a personal God, preserving knower-known relation.

Their significance in religious life is substantial. Revelation supplies orientation, a shared narrative and normative content; mystical experience vivifies these rather than leaving them as second-hand belief. It can deepen prayer and worship, produce conversion, unify the divided self and renew institutions through prophetic or saintly witness. Its moral fruits also provide public evidence of transformation, even when its object remains disputed.

Conversely, revelation without lived appropriation can harden into external authority, while mysticism without revelatory or rational regulation can become incommunicable or self-authorising. Their conjunction gives religious life both experiential depth and accountable form.

The strongest objection is epistemic: private experiences generate conflicting revelations and can legitimate fanaticism. Steven Katz's constructivism adds that traditions may shape the experience itself, not merely its later description. The reply must be discriminating, not credulous. Mediation does not automatically mean fabrication, since ordinary perception is concept-laden too; nevertheless, claims require tests of coherence, moral fruits, tradition-sensitive discernment and compatibility with responsible reason. Such tests establish authenticity more readily than metaphysical truth.

Therefore mystical experience may mediate and personally confirm revelation, while revelation may interpret and regulate mystical life. Their significance lies in joining lived transformation to inherited meaning. But no private mystical claim should acquire unconditional public or moral authority merely because it feels self-certifying.

Why this earns marks: Defines both poles; gives three relations; integrates James, Otto, Katz and Advaita; explains religious significance separately; confronts conflict and fanaticism; ends with a qualified assessment.

PYQ 7 - 2024, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the main features of religious experience according to Advaita Vedānta.

Demand decoding: Enumerate Advaita's distinctive features in tradition-specific terms, explain how its "object" differs from an intentional object, and assess the content and criterion objection.

Model solution: For Advaita Vedānta, the highest religious experience is not a subject's encounter with an external God but the immediate recognition of non-dual reality: ātman is Brahman. Its central term is *aparokṣānubhūti*, direct realisation, and its soteriological result is the destruction of ignorance and liberation.

First, the experience is **non-dual**. Ordinary cognition divides knower, knowing and known; Advaita regards this division as conditioned by *avidyā*. In liberating knowledge the supposed separation is sublated. *Aham brahmāsmi* therefore expresses identity, not proximity or emotional union between two already constituted beings.

Second, it is **self-luminous and self-certifying**. Consciousness is not known through another act, since every act of knowing presupposes it. Brahman, as the reality of consciousness, cannot be converted into an object without reproducing the duality to be overcome. The "object" of experience is thus realised as one's own Self; strictly, the object-pole disappears.

Third, the realisation is beyond exhaustive objectifying speech. Upaniṣadic negation such as *neti neti* removes limiting predicates, while mahāvākyas disclose identity. This is not meaninglessness. Nor is the realisation technically *anirvacanīya*: in Advaita that term characterises māyā or world-appearance as neither simply real nor unreal. Brahman is real; its non-objectifiability is better expressed through the limits of speech.

Fourth, the experience is transformative and blissful (*ānanda*), terminating bondage rooted in misidentification. Fifth, it is not merely a brief altered state. *Śravaṇa*, *manana* and *nididhyāsana* culminate in stable *jñāna*. James's transiency and passivity are therefore, at most, usual marks of many mystical episodes, not requirements Advaita must satisfy.

Sixth, Advaita distinguishes the empirical and ultimate standpoints. Devotion and *upāsana* directed toward saṁgha Brahman remain valid and purificatory at the *vyāvahārika* level; non-dual knowledge discloses nirguṇa Brahman at the *pāramārthika* level. They are not simply discarded as meaningless. This graded structure explains how intentional religious practice can prepare for a realisation in which intentional duality is finally overcome.

The strongest objection is that a contentless, non-dual state cannot justify the determinate judgement "I am Brahman"; perhaps doctrine constructs the interpretation. Advaita replies that *śruti* functions as a *pramāṇa* that removes ignorance rather than producing a new object. Like the tenth-man instruction, it discloses an already present fact; disciplined reflection blocks arbitrary interpretation. Still, this establishes tradition-internal intelligibility more readily than public proof.

Hence Advaitic religious experience is immediate, non-dual, self-luminous, non-objective, liberating and stabilised as knowledge. Its philosophical distinctiveness lies in **identity-recognition**, unlike Otto's encounter with the wholly other or theistic mysticism's relation to a personal God.

Why this earns marks: Lists and explains the main features; avoids the *anirvacanīya* error; uses mahāvākya and method; contrasts identity with encounter; presents the strongest objection and a bounded reply.

PYQ 8 - 2025, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: Evaluate the nature and object of Religious Experience as explained by Radhakrishnan in 'The Hindu View of Life'.

Demand decoding: Remain faithful to the named work; separately identify the nature and object of experience; explain the priority of experience over dogma and ritual; then evaluate universality, mediation and veridicality with a graded verdict.

Model solution: In *The Hindu View of Life*, S. Radhakrishnan presents religion fundamentally as realised spiritual life rather than assent to a closed creed. My thesis is that his account powerfully explains the immediacy, integrality and transformative force of religious experience, but its movement from experiential certainty to a universal spiritual object remains philosophically contestable.

The **nature** of religious experience is direct *anubhava*: an immediate, intuitive apprehension of reality, not a conclusion mechanically inferred from sense-data or discursive reasoning. Radhakrishnan's "intuition" is not a hunch or anti-intellectual feeling. It is an **integral awareness** in which cognition, feeling and will are unified. Discursive reason analyses and divides; spiritual intuition apprehends wholes and transforms the person. It is therefore noetic as well as affective, and its authenticity appears in a reorientation of conduct and character.

The experience is also self-certifying for the subject. Its immediacy resembles the Advaitic claim that consciousness is self-revealing. Yet Radhakrishnan does not treat religious life as a licence for arbitrary private impressions. Preparation, ethical purification, contemplation and the inherited wisdom of the tradition discipline intuition. Experience is primary, but reason remains necessary to interpret it, compare claims and prevent fanaticism.

Its **object** is the spiritual Real or Spirit that is also the depth of the self. Religious experience overcomes the ordinary separation of subject and object; the ultimate is not encountered as one finite item among others. In this Advaitically inflected account, one does not merely perceive God from outside but participates in or realises a deeper unity of self and reality. Nevertheless, Radhakrishnan allows personal symbols and devotional forms a genuine place in finite religious life. The impersonal and personal are not simply competing deities; personal conceptions can mediate an ultimate reality exceeding complete conceptual determination.

This priority of experience explains his view of Hinduism as non-dogmatic and dynamically receptive. Creeds, rituals, myths and institutions are secondary formulations of realised spiritual depth. Their plurality need not prove that the Real is plural; it may show that one depth is interpreted through different histories and temperaments. His view thus supports inter-religious hospitality and gives Indian *anubhava* parity with Western appeals to revelation or mystical encounter.

Several comparisons sharpen the account. Like James, Radhakrishnan treats personal experience and transformative fruits as more fundamental than institution, but he makes a stronger metaphysical claim about spiritual reality. Unlike Otto's intentional encounter with the numinous "wholly other," his highest experience tends toward non-dual integration. Like Advaita, he distinguishes non-objective realisation from ordinary perception, though his comparative philosophy emphasises universality across traditions.

Three objections arise. First, self-certifying certainty for the subject is not public proof of the object. Swinburne's principle of credulity may grant prima facie warrant absent defeaters, and Alston may defend rational participation in an established doxastic practice, but neither establishes Radhakrishnan's Spirit conclusively. Second, religious diversity may resist reduction to one experiential core: theistic communion, Buddhist emptiness and Advaitic identity differ logically, not merely verbally. Radhakrishnan risks assimilating them to Advaita. A modest reply is to claim family resemblance and analogous transformation rather than identical content. Third, constructivists argue that concepts and practices shape experience itself. The proper answer is that **mediation is not necessarily fabrication**; all perception is interpreted. Yet this reply also requires abandoning the claim of a wholly tradition-free intuition.

Radhakrishnan is therefore strongest as a phenomenology and philosophy of lived religion: he explains why spiritual realisation precedes, animates and criticises dogma. He is less decisive as an epistemologist, because intensity, self-certification and good fruits do not by themselves prove a common spiritual object. The graded verdict is that his account gives religious experience prima facie personal authority and profound comparative value, while the universality and veridicality of its object remain defensible hypotheses rather than demonstrated conclusions.

Why this earns marks: Anchors the answer in *The Hindu View of Life*; separates nature from object; explains integral intuition and secondary dogma; compares James, Otto and Advaita; tests universality, constructivism and warrant;

delivers an evaluative verdict.

Original solved Mains practice - 6 models

The following are original, independently prepared practice questions and model answers, not UPSC PYQs or official solutions.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Does the ineffability of religious experience prevent it from yielding knowledge? Examine.

Model solution: Ineffability limits the communication and doctrinal use of religious experience, but it does not automatically prevent every kind of knowledge. The issue turns on distinguishing **knowledge by acquaintance**, partial propositional articulation and publicly demonstrable knowledge.

William James identifies ineffability and noetic quality as the defining marks of mystical states. The mystic cannot adequately transfer the quality of the state to a non-participant, yet experiences it as insight into a deeper reality. This is not self-contradictory. Taste and pain also exceed complete description while supporting correct first-person judgements. Mystics can additionally make limited claims-unity, peace, dependence or non-duality-without claiming exhaustive capture.

Religious language may therefore function negatively, analogically or symbolically: it can exclude false literal pictures and direct attention without reproducing the experience. Such disciplined partial speech is weaker than a complete definition but stronger than silence.

However, noetic feeling is not sufficient warrant. If an experience is wholly ineffable, determinate inferences such as "a personal creator exists" may outrun its content. Conflicting reports of God, Brahman and emptiness strengthen this objection. Good moral fruits establish transformation more readily than the metaphysical truth of the interpretation.

A qualified reply distinguishes the experience from its interpretation. Negative and analogical language may communicate boundaries; traditions can test coherence, preparation and fruits. Advaita similarly treats Brahman as non-objectifiable but uses *śruti* and reason to remove error. Still, these resources give tradition-internal articulation, not coercive public proof.

Therefore ineffability does not reduce religious experience to unintelligibility. It may yield immediate or acquaintance-like knowledge and defeasible personal warrant, but it restricts exhaustive description and weakens the move to detailed, universally binding doctrine.

Why this earns marks: Direct thesis; James correctly graded; acquaintance/proposition/public-proof distinction; diversity objection; Advaita comparison; qualified verdict.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Compare Otto's numinous encounter with Advaita's non-dual awareness as two accounts of religious experience.

Model solution: Otto and Advaita both resist reducing religion to discursive belief, but their experiences have fundamentally different logical structures: Otto describes an **intentional encounter with an Other**, whereas Advaita describes **identity-recognition in which otherness is sublated**.

In *The Idea of the Holy*, Otto calls the object the numinous, experienced as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. The subject feels creaturely, overwhelmed and yet attracted before the "wholly other." "Non-rational" means irreducible to ordinary moral and conceptual predicates, not irrational. The subject and numinous object remain distinct.

Advaita's *aparokṣānubhūti* is direct recognition that ātman is Brahman. Since self-luminous consciousness presupposes every objectifying cognition, Brahman cannot be one external item perceived by a subject. *Aham brahmāsmi* expresses non-dual identity. The realisation is liberating and stabilised as *jñāna*, not necessarily the transient passivity often found in mystical episodes.

Both accounts stress immediacy, non-exhaustive language and transformation. Yet assimilating them into a single "mystical feeling" erases the difference between relation and identity. The strongest objection to Otto is that awe may be psychologically explained without a numinous object; the strongest objection to Advaita is that a contentless state cannot justify the specific judgement of Brahman-identity. Otto can reply that causal explanation does not exhaust intentional structure; Advaita replies that *śruti* removes ignorance rather than constructing an object.

Their soteriological orientations also differ. Otto's analysis begins from a creature's response to holiness and awaits ethical-theological schematisation; Advaita places the experience within a path whose cognitive culmination removes *avidyā*. The former centres reverent encounter, the latter liberating knowledge.

Thus the accounts are comparable as non-discursive phenomenologies, but not interchangeable. Otto preserves encounter; Advaita culminates in non-dual recognition.

Why this earns marks: Clear comparator; precise doctrines; non-rational clarified; identity-versus-relation made decisive; matched objections and replies; concise verdict.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "The moral fruits of a religious experience authenticate the subject but do not verify the transcendent object." Critically discuss.

Model solution: The proposition is substantially correct: moral fruits are powerful evidence that an experience has reorganised a life and may count against pathology or self-deception, but they do not by themselves verify God, Brahman or another transcendent object.

William James evaluates religion pragmatically "by its fruits," examining conversion, saintliness, integration of the divided self and durable conduct rather than extraordinary intensity. This criterion has three strengths. First, effects are publicly observable even when the original state is private. Second, enduring compassion, courage and freedom from ego provide evidence that the report is not a fleeting mood. Third, fruits allow comparison across traditions without requiring prior agreement about theology. Indian traditions similarly test realisation through freedom from attachment, ethical discipline and transformed conduct; the guru does not accept every ecstasy as liberating knowledge.

Nevertheless, beneficial consequences do not entail metaphysical truth. A false belief can inspire sacrifice, while a veridical perception can produce no moral improvement. Different religions generate admirable lives while making incompatible claims about a personal God, non-dual Brahman or emptiness. To infer a transcendent object solely from fruits commits a pragmatic substitution: usefulness replaces truth. Further, social approval of "good fruits" may reflect the evaluator's own moral norms.

A defender can offer a cumulative rather than deductive argument. Fruits may raise credibility when joined with coherent phenomenology, reliable character, disciplined preparation, absence of known defeaters and convergence of testimony. Swinburne's principle of credulity permits an initial presumption in favour of apparent experience; transformation may strengthen that presumption by making deception less likely. Alston's doxastic-practice model likewise includes override and discernment procedures. Yet neither move makes fruits independently sufficient.

An objection to the original proposition is that "authentication of the subject" may itself be too strong: impressive conduct can coexist with mistaken interpretation. The correction is to say that fruits support the authenticity and seriousness of the transformation, not the infallibility of the subject.

There is also a reverse caution: absence of spectacular virtue does not automatically falsify an experience. Moral development may be gradual, socially obstructed or uneven. Fruits should therefore be assessed longitudinally and proportionately, not used as an instant binary test. Their force lies in consilience with other evidence rather than in a single heroic act.

Therefore moral fruits have genuine but bounded epistemic value. They publicly corroborate sincerity, integration and practical depth; as one strand in a cumulative case, they may support *prima facie* warrant. They neither deductively verify the transcendent object nor resolve conflicts among religious interpretations.

Why this earns marks: Tests both halves of the statement; uses James and Indian discernment; distinguishes utility, authenticity and truth; offers a cumulative reply; gives a calibrated verdict.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Is mystical experience best understood through a common core or through irreducible religious diversity? Discuss with reference to Stace, Zaehner and constructivism.

Model solution: Neither an undifferentiated common core nor absolute diversity is adequate. Mystical reports display recurring phenomenological families, but their objects and logical structures are too different to be treated as one neutral experience with optional labels.

W. T. Stace offers the strongest common-core account. Extrovertive mysticism perceives unity through sensory multiplicity; introvertive mysticism excludes sensory and conceptual content, leaving unitary consciousness. Both display objectivity, blessedness, sacredness, paradox and ineffability. By separating experience from interpretation, Stace explains why Christian, Advaitic and Buddhist descriptions may diverge while sharing experiential depth.

The objection is that "interpretation" may be carrying all inconvenient differences. Identity with Brahman, communion with God and insight into emptiness do not merely attach different names to one relation: one abolishes subject-object duality, another preserves it, and a third may reject any substantial self or ultimate substance.

R. C. Zaehner therefore distinguishes nature, monistic and theistic mysticism. His classification protects the difference between oneness with nature, isolation or identity of soul, and loving union with a personal God. Its weakness is his confessional ranking of theistic mysticism as highest. The classification can be retained while the hierarchy is dropped.

Steven Katz radicalises diversity through constructivism: expectations, language and practices shape the experience itself, so there is no unmediated common event. This explains tradition-specific content but risks making experience merely self-confirming. Robert Forman's Pure Consciousness Event challenges Katz at the contentless limit: if no content is present, what exactly is constructed? Katz may reply that preparation, recognition and memory remain mediated even if the episode is sparse.

A further complication is that "common core" can name more than one claim. It may mean identical phenomenal content, a shared formal structure, or merely recurrent transformative consequences. Evidence against identical content need not eliminate formal similarities such as unity or ineffability. Conversely, agreement about peaceful effects does not establish one metaphysical object. The debate becomes clearer when these levels are not conflated.

Advaita is therefore an especially useful test: its identity-claim may share formal unity with Stace's core while resisting reduction to Zaehner's theistic relation.

A defensible synthesis treats the evidence through **family resemblance**. Stace's extrovertive/introvertive distinction and recurring marks identify cross-cultural patterns; Zaehner correctly preserves monistic/theistic difference; constructivism warns that reports cannot be stripped clean of formation. Mediation need not equal fabrication, but it blocks easy proof of a universal identical core.

Thus mystical experience is neither simply one nor wholly many. It consists of overlapping phenomenological families whose intentional objects and doctrinal structures may remain irreducibly different.

Why this earns marks: Reconstructs all three positions; avoids accepting Zaehner's ranking; uses identity-versus-relation; includes Forman's reply; reaches a discriminating synthesis.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Can religious experience provide *prima facie* justification for belief in a transcendent reality? Evaluate with reference to Swinburne, Alston and Indian claims of direct realisation.

Model solution: Religious experience can provide *prima facie*, defeasible justification for the experiencer, and weaker testimonial support for others, but it does not amount to public proof of a transcendent reality. The defensibility of this claim depends on parity with ordinary epistemic practices and on how seriously religious diversity functions as a defeater.

Richard Swinburne's **principle of credulity** gives the initial argument. If it epistemically seems to a subject that X is present, then, other things being equal, probably X is present. We normally trust perception unless there are specific reasons for doubt; consistently applied, this presumption should not be withdrawn merely because the apparent object is God. His related principle of testimony allows others some reason to trust sincere reports. The warrant remains defeasible by unreliability, conflicting evidence, background improbability or a superior explaining-away account.

William Alston develops a more practice-centred defence in *Perceiving God*. On his theory of appearing, perception is constituted by an object's seeming to present itself, not necessarily by sensory qualities. Some experiences of God can therefore be "M-perceptions" generating M-beliefs. Such beliefs arise within Christian Mystical Practice, a socially established doxastic practice with recognised inputs, outputs and override procedures. Sense perception, memory and induction cannot be non-circularly validated without using those very practices. Since demanding an external proof from religion alone would be asymmetrical, participation in an established mystical practice may be practically rational, and its outputs *prima facie* justified.

Alston's conclusion is deliberately modest. He does not prove that the practice is reliable or that every M-belief is justified all things considered. He shifts the burden to the sceptic to identify a relevant epistemic inferiority rather than merely citing circularity common to all practices.

Indian traditions supply both reinforcement and complication. Advaita calls *aparokṣānubhūti* immediate and self-certifying: Brahman is not perceived as external but recognised as self-luminous consciousness. *Śruti*, reason and *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* discipline the recognition; the guru and ethical transformation provide tests. Yoga and contemplative traditions also present repeatable training and predicted transformations, approximating expert perception. Yet these claims are not neutral observations. Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves communion with a personal Brahman; Buddhism may report emptiness without a creator; thus the "object" and structure differ.

Three objections are decisive. First, naturalistic accounts attribute experience to neural activity, suggestion, deprivation or wish-fulfilment. This can become a defeater when it demonstrates unreliability, but a neural mechanism alone does not explain away the object: ordinary perception is neurally mediated too. Causal mediation and truth-value are distinct.

Second, religious experiences lack the robust public cross-checking, prediction and agreement of sense perception. Alston replies that traditions do possess discernment and override systems, though they are weaker. This difference justifies a lower confidence level, not necessarily zero warrant.

Third, **diversity** is stronger than neurology. Mutually incompatible practices may each be established and internally coherent. Alston's suggestion that participants may rationally "sit tight" preserves practical rationality but does not resolve truth. Hick's culturally mediated responses to the Real offer one reconciliation, while constructivists contend that traditions shape the experiences themselves. A modest response claims family resemblance, not identical content; however, this weakens inference to any specific transcendent object.

The warrant must therefore be indexed. For the subject, a coherent experience arising within disciplined practice, producing fitting fruits and surviving known defeaters may rationally ground belief. For a hearer, testimony supplies some evidence but competes with plural testimony. For public reason, the episode can be assessed for authenticity and coherence, not converted into demonstration.

Thus religious experience can provide *prima facie* justification, especially personal and practice-relative justification. Swinburne explains the initial presumption; Alston explains rational practice; Indian traditions add non-sensory directness and disciplined replication. But diversity and limited cross-checking prevent the move from defeasible warrant to universally binding proof.

Why this earns marks: Defines the exact epistemic level; reconstructs Swinburne and Alston without overclaiming; supplies Indian parity; ranks naturalism, cross-checking and diversity objections; differentiates subject, testimony and public proof.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Religious experience is always mediated, but mediation does not necessarily amount to fabrication." Critically evaluate.

Model solution: The statement is defensible if "mediation" means that concepts, practices, language, embodiment and expectations condition how an experience occurs and is recognised, while "fabrication" means that these conditions wholly produce an object with no independent constraint. Religious experience is probably never interpretation-free; it does not follow that it is therefore unreal.

Steven Katz gives the strongest mediation thesis. Against perennialism, he argues that there are no unmediated mystical experiences. A Jewish mystic formed by covenantal theism, an Advaitin trained in *neti neti*, and a Buddhist analysing non-self do not first undergo a neutral event and later attach different descriptions. Their disciplines and categories help structure what is salient and possible within the experience. This explains why reports display detailed doctrinal differences rather than merely different vocabulary.

The thesis gains force from the contrast between **intentional encounter** and **non-dual awareness**. Otto's subject confronts the numinous "wholly other"; theistic mysticism preserves a relation to a personal God; Advaita's *aparokṣānubhūti* sublates the subject-object distinction; Buddhism may deny both a permanent subject and substantial absolute. These are logically different structures. Zaehner's distinction among nature, monistic and theistic mysticism therefore preserves something that Stace's common-core account risks flattening.

Yet mediation does not entail fabrication. Ordinary perception is also shaped by concepts, attention and expert training while remaining answerable to objects. A radiologist sees patterns a novice misses; acquired categories improve access rather than inventing anatomy. Religious disciplines may similarly cultivate capacities and impose correction. Experiences also surprise, resist expectation and transform prior commitments, suggesting that subjects do not simply write the desired script.

William Alston's doxastic-practice account supplies an epistemic form of this reply. Beliefs emerge from socially established practices with inputs and override systems; no practice, including sense perception, is validated from a wholly external standpoint. Religious mediation can therefore be rational without being incorrigible. Indian methods such as *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*, yogic discipline and guru-guided discernment make explicit that preparation is intended to remove distortion, not manufacture an object.

Robert Forman challenges constructivism through the Pure Consciousness Event, a supposedly contentless state with nothing for concepts to shape. This objection is strongest against a total claim that every experiential feature is doctrinally constructed. Katz can still reply that entry, recognition, memory and interpretation remain mediated. Consequently, Forman may establish a minimally common experiential limit without proving a common metaphysical object.

Radhakrishnan moves further toward a perennial depth. In *The Hindu View of Life*, direct integral intuition of the spiritual Real precedes creeds, which are secondary formulations. This supports inter-religious openness, but risks treating theistic communion and Buddhist emptiness as imperfect expressions of an Advaitic unity. A more defensible version speaks of family resemblance or analogous transformation rather than identical content.

The strongest objection to the statement is sceptical: once there is no unmediated access, how can one distinguish disclosure from tradition-induced projection? Three criteria help without guaranteeing truth: experiential coherence and resistance to wish-fulfilment; public fruits and stable transformation; and communal override procedures capable of rejecting episodes. Cross-traditional convergence adds limited support, while persistent incompatible objects remains a defeater.

The opposite error is neuro-reduction. Showing neural or psychological mediation explains a mechanism, not necessarily away the object. A genuine perception and a hallucination both have neural causes; what matters is whether the causal process is appropriately connected to reality and survives defeaters.

Therefore mediation is unavoidable and philosophically informative: it qualifies claims of pure, universal experience and requires humility about interpretation. But fabrication is a further conclusion demanding evidence of systematic unreliability or unconstrained projection. The best verdict rejects both naïve immediacy and total constructivism: religious experience may be mediated disclosure, though its object receives only defeasible, tradition-situated warrant.

Why this earns marks: Defines the key terms; reconstructs Katz; compares Stace, Zaehner, Forman, Alston and Radhakrishnan; integrates Indian practice; distinguishes causal mechanism from epistemic defeat; finishes with a graded middle position.

Timed-paper compression plan

This clause is unusual: it owns exactly **one part in every paper from 2018 to 2025**, and that part alternates between 15 and 20 marks. The compression problem is therefore predictable, and the plan below is question-shaped rather than generic.

If the stem is	Cut first	Never cut
a thinker stem (2022 James, 2025 Radhakrishnan)	biography, publication context, the second and third rival accounts	the graded marks or the named work's own theses; one objection with its reply
a tradition stem (2021 Vedāntic, 2024 Advaita)	the Western comparison down to one sentence	the tradition's own vocabulary; the identity-versus-relation point; the internal plurality where the stem says "tradition"
an object stem (2018 sacred and holy)	Eliade's spatial apparatus; the Indian vocabulary list	the non-theistic cases; the holy ≠ sacred discriminator; the graded verdict
a two-deliverable stem (2020 prayer and worship, 2023 experience and revelation)	one of the three Indian cases; one reply to Rachels	either deliverable - half-answering costs more than thin coverage of both

If the stem is	Cut first	Never cut
a degree stem (2019 public discourse)	two of the six criteria	the concession that the criteria test authenticity, not truth; the line you draw

The 60-second recovery drill. If time is collapsing, write four sentences in this order and stop: (1) the layer the stem is on; (2) the account, with its one decisive discrimination; (3) the strongest objection, named; (4) the graded verdict, with the defeater that would change it. Four correct sentences of this shape outscore two pages of narration.

What not to over-study. Do not fill answers with brain-region catalogues, long mystical case-lists, or claims that ineffability makes experience unintelligible. Master the phenomenological marks, the claimed object, the warrant test, the strongest critique and one Indian comparison.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Status. Everything below is **second-order enrichment**. No core answer in this clause depends on it, and none of it repairs a gap in the Basic block. Add **one** advanced move to a 15-marker, or **one to two** to a 20-marker, and only after the owner's own material is on the page. **Why this block is short.** Three of the modules that previously sat here - prayer and worship, public discourse, and the sacred and the holy - carry **printed previous-year questions** (2020, 2019 and 2018), and the Advanced dossier's promotion ledger of 15 August 2026 records that the Stace/Zaehner typology and the perceptual model of religious experience "now live in Core and must not be described as Advanced-only". All of that material is therefore taught in the Basic block above, where it belongs.

A1 - The perceptual model against constructivism

The dispute. Perceptual models treat religious experience as *prima facie* awareness of a real object; constructivists stress mediation by concepts, practices and expectations.

Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply. *Objection:* tradition-shaped experiences cannot disclose a common object, because what is disclosed has already been determined by the tradition. *Reply:* all experience is mediated, yet mediation does not by itself erase objectivity - expert perception is heavily trained and remains perception.

Safe use. One evaluative contrast, deployed after Alston or after Swinburne-style credulity has been stated in its own terms. It is a way of pricing the perceptual model, not a substitute for it.

A2 - A perennial core against hard diversity

The dispute. Perennialists see a common experiential depth beneath doctrinal difference; critics insist that Advaita, theism and Buddhism report genuinely divergent structures.

Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply. *Objection:* a "same core" flattens doctrinal difference and quietly promotes one tradition's description into a neutral framework. *Reply:* one may claim only **family resemblance or analogous transformation**, not identity of content - a weaker thesis that survives the objection.

Safe use. In a Radhakrishnan answer, or in any plural-experience answer, as the retreat position that keeps comparison alive after the strong perennialist claim has been surrendered.

A3 - Neuro-reduction against non-reductive embodiment

The dispute. Reductionists treat neural correlations as explaining away the transcendent claim; non-reductive thinkers hold that brain mediation is compatible with genuine disclosure.

Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply. *Objection:* if the experience has a neural cause, no further object is needed to explain it. *Reply:* causal mechanism and truth-value are distinct questions, exactly as in ordinary perception, where a full neural story leaves the perceived object untouched.

Safe use. ANALYSIS: Mention only as a **current analogue** of the classical naturalistic critique, in a single sentence, and never let it dominate the answer. The clause's own guidance restricts dated news anchors and warns against brain-region catalogues.

A4 - Non-dual awareness against intentional encounter

The dispute. Advaita treats the highest experience as self-luminous non-dual awareness; theistic accounts retain a knower-known relation to God.

Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply. *Objection:* contentless awareness cannot justify doctrinal claims, since nothing determinate has been given. *Reply:* Advaita holds that doctrine prepares and interprets the recognition, while the liberating moment itself is non-objective - so the doctrinal claim is not read off the state.

Safe use. Very effective when comparing Advaita with James or Otto, or when a revelation stem asks how an experience can carry content at all. This is the *second-order* form of the identity-versus-relation point already taught in the Basic block; it sharpens the evaluation but adds no new core doctrine.

Advanced source trail

FACT: William James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience* · FACT: Rudolf Otto, *The Idea of the Holy* · FACT: Richard Swinburne, *The Existence of God* and the principle-of-credulity literature · FACT: William Alston, *Perceiving God* · FACT: S. Radhakrishnan, *The Hindu View of Life* · FACT: Advaita sources on immediate realisation (*aparokṣānubhūti*).

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Eighteen compressed retrieval cards, one per taught session, in teaching order. These are revision notes, not a second exposition: definitions, discriminations, named evidence, traps and answer routes only.

1. The four layers, and the three jumps that lose marks

- **Layers:** phenomenology (what it is like) -> claimed object (what seems given) -> interpretation (how a tradition names it) -> epistemic force (what it justifies, and for whom).
- **Jump A:** intensity -> truth. **Jump B:** naming -> meeting. **Jump C:** mediation -> fabrication. Each is a marked error.
- **Three cautions:** *subjective* = first-personal, not unreal · *ineffable* = resists adequate expression, not contentless · *neural correlate* = mediation, not disproof.
- **Three distinct achievements:** psychological genuineness, doctrinal authenticity, metaphysical veridicality. Winning one does not win the others.
- **Opening habit:** name the layer the stem is on in sentence one.

2. James - the marks, graded two-plus-two

- **Defining:** ineffability (James's "handiest" mark; must be directly experienced, more like a feeling than a proposition) and **noetic quality** ("states of insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect", carrying a curious sense of authority).
- **Usual:** transiency (brief, but may recur and develop) and passivity (voluntary preliminaries may facilitate onset; once it sets in, the mystic feels grasped and held by a superior power).
- **Scope:** marks of **mystical states**, not of every religious experience.
- **Authority clause:** authoritative for the one who has them; **no authority over outsiders**.
- **Payoff:** transiency being merely usual is what lets stable liberating knowledge (*jñāna*) count as mystical.
- **Trap:** the flat four-mark list - the commonest error in this clause.

3. James - method, and the varieties

- **Method:** empirical (first-person documents), pragmatic (fruits), anti-reductive.
- **Medical materialism** (*Varieties*, Lecture I): James's own term for discrediting a state by its physiological or pathological origin. Rejected - origin does not settle truth or worth.
- **Fruits:** "by their fruits ye shall know them", Matthew 7:16/20 - **adopted** by James, not coined.
- **Varieties:** healthy-mindedness · the sick soul · the divided self and conversion · saintliness · mysticism. *This is the second deliverable of the 2022 stem.*
- **Object:** the "**MORE**", reached through the **subconscious** - deliberately under-described.
- **Verdict shape:** strongest as phenomenology and pragmatic assessment; silent on the object.

4. Otto - the numinous, and Schleiermacher

- **Mysterium tremendum et fascinans** (*The Idea of the Holy*, 1917): *the wholly other; awefulness, overpoweringness* (majestas*) and energy; and the attracting, entrancing pole.
- **Creature-feeling:** dread, humility and fascination in a single state.
- **Non-rational ≠ irrational:** not reducible to conceptual-moral judgement; **schematisation** by rational and ethical predicates comes afterwards.
- **Schleiermacher:** essence of religion = **feeling of absolute dependence** (*The Christian Faith*) - a feeling about the subject; the numinous is object-directed.
- **Objection -> reply:** psychology can explain awe -> Otto describes intentional structure, but description is not existence.
- **Cross-cultural limit:** Indian traditions often organise the sacred through **purity and auspiciousness**, not dread.

5. Stace against Zaehner

- **Stace** (*Mysticism and Philosophy*, 1960): **extrovertive** (the One shining *through* sensed multiplicity, with an inner life in all things) and **introvertive** (all sensory and conceptual content excluded; unitary contentless consciousness; the higher type). **Shared marks:** objectivity/reality, blessedness, holiness, paradoxicality, ineffability. **Move:** separate experience from interpretation -> perennialist common core.
- **Zaehner** (*Mysticism Sacred and Profane*, 1957): **nature** (*pan-en-henic*; certain drug states placed here **against** Huxley's mescaline claims), **monistic** (Sāṃkhya-Yoga's aloneness; Advaita), **theistic** (loving union preserving the creature-creator distinction). **No common core**, plus a ranking.
- **Verdict formula:** keep both classifications, **drop Zaehner's ranking**; the residue is that identity and relation differ in logical form.
- **Trap:** they are rivals, not complements.

6. Perennialism against constructivism

- **Katz** ("Language, Epistemology and Mysticism", 1978): **there are no unmediated experiences**; tradition, expectation, concepts and practice are constitutive.
- **Forman:** the **Pure Consciousness Event** - a contentless state has nothing for concepts to shape.
- **Honest verdict:** constructivism is strong for extrovertive and theistic reports, weakest at the contentless limit.
- **Proudfoot-style attribution:** an experience is religious partly because the subject explains it religiously; pressure - classification is not phenomenology.
- **Hick:** plural mediation of one Real; pressure - indeterminacy.
- **What it defeats:** the **convergence inference**, not the occurrence.

7. Advaita - immediate realisation

- **Terms:** direct realisation (*anubhava*), immediate realisation (*aparokṣānubhūti*), non-dual (*nirvikalpa*), "I am Brahman" (*aham brahmāsmi*, Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 1.4.10).
- **Six features:** non-dual · identity, not relation · self-established (*svataḥ-siddha*) · beyond objectifying speech (*avācya*; "from which words turn back") · bliss (*ānanda*) · stable knowledge (*jñāna*), not an episode.
- **Route:** hearing -> reflection -> contemplation (*śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*). **Image:** the tenth man - instruction removes ignorance of an already present fact.
- **Firewall:** *anirvacanīya* belongs to *māyā* and the world-appearance (*sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa*), never to Brahman or its realisation.
- **Objection -> reply:** a contentless state cannot identify Brahman -> Brahman is self, not inferred object; the price is that the state leaves the space of public evidence.

8. Radhakrishnan, and Vedāntic plurality

- **The Hindu View of Life*** (1927): direct intuitive experience of the Real is **primary and self-certifying**; dogma and ritual are **secondary interpretations**. Religious experience is **integral intuition** - cognition, feeling and will united, higher than sense and reason.
- **Presupposition:** intuition **discloses reality** rather than reporting intensity. **Distinction:** not a hunch - disciplined, integral, transformative.
- **Objection -> reply:** privileges Advaitic unity and assimilates theistic difference -> universality concerns depth, not description; **adequacy remains contested**.
- **Vedāntic plurality (2021):** Śaṅkara - identity; Rāmānuja - personal Brahman, selves and world as real dependent modes, communion without dissolution; Madhva - eternal difference, grace-enabled relation.
- **Common test across schools:** soteriological - does it remove ignorance, egoism and bondage?

9. The Indian experience-types bridge

Tradition	Structure	Terminus	Control
Advaita	non-dual recognition	the self as Brahman	not two independently existing terms
Yoga	staged concentration, seedless absorption	isolated consciousness (<i>puruṣa</i>)	Yoga's special Lord is not the creator-object
Devotional	love, surrender, prayer, worship	a personal Lord	relation and grace remain real
Buddhism	insight into impermanence, no-permanent-self, conditioned arising	Dharma, cessation (<i>nirvāṇa</i>)	claims remain tradition-mediated; "object" may mislead

- **Four logical forms:** identity · isolation · relation · insight.
- **Bridge only:** school metaphysics remains with the Paper I owners.

10. Sacred, holy, God - the object question (2018)

- **Why the generic term won:** Otto's holy (phenomenological, prior to moral predicates) · Durkheim (1912), the sacred defined **relationally** against the profane, by prohibition, needing no deity · Eliade (1957), **hierophany** structuring sacred space and time · and decisively, **non-theistic religions have a sacred but no God** (*nirvāṇa* and the Dharma; the Tīrthaṅkara and the *siddha*; the authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda; the Tao).
- **Graded answer: yes** for theistic traditions, where God is the **source and measure** of holiness; **no** as a generic definition, which would stipulate Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā out of religion. **'Sacred' is the genus; God is theism's species.**
- **Discriminator:** Otto's **holy** ≠ Durkheim's **sacred** - phenomenological quality against social classification.
- **Indian parity:** *pavitra/śuddha*, *maṅgala*, *punya*, *tīrtha*, *kṣetra*, *devālaya*; *parvan* days and *muhūrta*; the Veda's sanctity without a sanctifier.
- **Objections -> replies:** over-breadth (flags, nations) -> add the **soteriological** requirement · subordination of God to a genus -> the subordination is **conceptual**, not ontological.

11. Veridicality - credulity, testimony, defeaters

- **For:** Swinburne's **principle of credulity** (it seems that X, so probably X, absent defeaters) and **principle of testimony**; the noetic mark; convergence of mystics.
- **Against:** naturalistic explanation (Freud's projection and wish-fulfilment; social formation; neural mediation) and **diversity**.
- **The burden clause:** a correlation is not a defeat - the critic must show the mechanism is **unreliable** or that it **fully explains the seeming without the object**.
- **Four criticisms -> replies:** naturalism -> origin does not falsify content; conflicting objects -> interpretation may vary while contact is common, *rejoinder*: can become unfalsifiable; ineffability -> limits exhaustiveness, not every statement; moral fruits -> authenticity, not proof.
- **Ranking:** naturalism is the loudest and weakest; **diversity is the quietest and strongest**.
- **Verdict:** *prima facie* for the subject, testimonial for the hearer, no public demonstration.

12. Alston's perceptual model

- **Perceiving God (1991). Theory of appearing -> mystical perception (M-perception) -> M-beliefs**, *prima facie** justified.
- **Doxastic practices:** socially established, internally organised, with inputs, outputs and **override procedures**.
- **Epistemic circularity:** no practice - sense perception, memory, induction - is validated non-circularly; we are nonetheless practically rational in using them.
- **Conclusion: practical rationality of engagement**, *not* proof of reliability. Distinguish *prima facie* from *ultima facie*; distinguish Alston (practices) from Swinburne (seemings).
- **Diversity objection - his own:** incompatible established practices cannot all track one reality; he answers only that one may rationally "**sit tight**" absent neutral adjudication.
- **Second objection -> reply:** no cross-checking or prediction -> internal override systems exist, weaker than science's but not absent.

13. Plural and conflicting experiences

- **The defeater:** personal God, non-dual Brahman and emptiness reported with equal conviction; credulity applied evenly licenses incompatible conclusions.
- **Hick:** culturally conditioned responses to one **Real an sich***. **Price:** indeterminacy - an unknowable Real cannot ground determinate doctrine; and the reply "interpretation varies, contact is common" **can become unfalsifiable**.
- **Other exits:** exclusivism (owes an account of others' sincerity and fruits); constructivism (different experiences, not one differently described).
- **Disanalogy with perception:** religious practices have **internal** override systems but no **cross-practice** adjudicating procedure.
- **Safe residue:** family resemblance or analogous transformation; and no convergence argument.

14. Mystical experience and revelation (2023)

- **Relation:** mystical experience can be a **vehicle** of revelation - non-propositional revelation; intimately linked, **not identical**.
- **Four cells:** vehicle case · pure experience with no disclosure-claim · propositional revelation with no unitive state · neither. Cells two and three prove non-identity.
- **Model:** Hick's non-propositional **experiencing-as** - the "as" is contributed by the receiver, which is why the event is religiously ambiguous.
- **Significance in religious life (second deliverable): origin** (founders' disclosures generate traditions) · **renewal** (later mystics re-authenticate from within) · **risk** (unchecked private disclosure overriding community and moral judgement).
- **Control:** discernment procedures test **authenticity and conformity**, not truth.
- **Boundary:** faith's *reception* of revelation belongs to the Reason, Revelation and Faith owner.

15. Prayer and worship (2020)

- **Essential acts:** prayer = **address**; worship = **ascription of supreme worth**. **Adoration is the overlap**. Wordless contemplative prayer is the limit case.
- **Six axes:** essential act · direction (I-Thou vs creature-before-the-holy) · form (spontaneous vs rule-governed) · locus (private vs corporate) · presupposition (**a responsive God vs a supremely valuable reality**) · non-theistic availability.
- **Kinds of prayer: A-C-T-S** - adoration, confession, thanksgiving, supplication (add intercession, contemplation).
- **Petition problem:** omniscient, perfectly good, immutable => petition idle. **Aquinas:** we obtain what God has ordained shall be obtained **through** prayer - a genuine **secondary cause**. **Stump** ("Petitionary Prayer", 1979): asking **protects the relationship**. **Residue:** justifies petition's value, not causal dependence.
- **Worship problem: Rachels** (1971) - worship entails unconditional obedience; autonomy forbids abdication; so nothing is worthy of worship. **Replies:** worship recognises worth, not blind obedience; a perfectly good being's commands coincide with moral judgement; the autonomy assumed is atomistic.
- **Deciding Indian cases:** Jain **free of passion (vītarāga)** - worship without answerable petition · Mīmāṃsā **unseen potency (apūrva)**, deity as grammatical dative · Advaita **contemplative worship (upāsanā)** efficacious at the everyday level, transcended not repudiated · Buddhist **ritual honour (pūjā)** as commemorative and dispositional.
- **Placement:** prayer = **relational organ**; worship = **evaluative and communal organ**. Petition is dispensable; worship is not.

16. Public discourse (2019)

- **The stem asks a degree**, not a yes/no.
- **Against:** ineffability · privileged access (James's own limit) · no shared checking procedure · Wittgenstein's private-language considerations · Rawlsian public reason for coercive decisions.
- **For - six criteria:** phenomenological description (James, Otto, Stace, Zaehner built public typologies from private documents) · coherence · discernment norms (Teresa of Ávila's criteria; the guru's verification; the teacher's testing) · moral fruits (observable) · **replicability through disciplined practice** (yoga, *dhyāna*, *nididhyāsana*; Vivekananda and Radhakrishnan's "experimental" **claim**, limited because the observer must be committed) · Alston's doxastic practices.
- **Bridge:** Habermas - full expression in the **informal** public sphere, subject to a **translation proviso** before formal state decision-making.
- **Concession:** the criteria test **authenticity, not truth**.
- **Verdict:** **publicly discussable and privately probative**.

17. The parity bench and the ten-row comparison

- **Six axes with discriminating points:** structure (relation vs identity vs isolation - a *logical* difference) · duration (transient vs stable *jñāna* - why James's grading matters) · method (grace and sacrament vs disciplined, staged, repeatable practice - India's replicability claim) · authority (subject-only vs self-established but tested by teacher and scripture - India adds institutional discernment) · object-term (God, the Holy, the numinous vs Brahman, *puruṣa*, *nirvāṇa*, the Tīrthaṅkara - the generic term must be "sacred") · ritual correlate (prayer, sacrament, liturgy vs *upāsanā*, *pūjā*, *japa*, *dhyāna* - Jain and Mīmāṃsā worship without a responsive deity).
- **Ten accounts and their characteristic risks:** James - subjectivism · Otto - reification of emotion · Schleiermacher - the Infinite reached only through the subject's own feeling · Stace - interpretation does all the work · Zaehner - confessional ranking · Alston - diversity of established practices · Advaita - the content/criterion problem · Radhakrishnan - Advaitic assimilation · theistic mysticism - conflict with non-dual reports · Buddhism - the "object" category may mislead · Durkheim and Eliade - over-breadth.
- **Rule:** match the axis to the stem; one axis run to its discriminating point beats six axes listed.

18. Answer discipline

- **Architectures.** 10 marks: define -> structured marks -> object -> one objection -> limited verdict. 15 marks: nature/object -> account and presupposition -> canonical example -> Indian/Western contrast -> objection and reply. 20 marks: phenomenology -> object -> warrant -> naturalistic **and** diversity defeaters -> comparison -> graded verdict + the defeater that would change it.
- **Directives, and what each buys.** "Do you agree ... Discuss" (2018) - a graded position on the printed proposition · "How far ... Analyse" (2019) - a degree · "Distinguish ... and determine their place" (2020) - two deliverables · "in the light of [tradition]" (2021) - tradition-internal categories · "nature and variety ... as presented by [thinker]" (2022) - marks **and** typology · "Examine the relation ... and expound their significance" (2023) - relation **plus** significance · "main features" (2024) - an enumerated list with discriminators · "Evaluate ... as explained by [thinker] in [named work]" (2025) - fidelity first, then assessment.
- **Verdict ladder.** Weak: flat four marks. Average: correct terms, ungraded marks. Good: nature/object separated, one objection. Strong: graded marks, identity-vs-relation, credulity and defeaters, Indian parity. **Top:** a discriminating distinction (defining vs usual · Otto's holy ≠ Durkheim's sacred · constructivism vs the Pure Consciousness Event · *prima facie* vs *ultima facie*) **plus** the named defeater.
- **Quotation discipline.** Datable: James 1902 · Durkheim 1912 · Otto 1917 · Radhakrishnan 1927 · Zaehner 1957 · Eliade 1957 · Stace 1960 · Rachels 1971 · Katz 1978 · Stump 1979 · Alston 1991. Cite by work, never by an invented year: Schleiermacher, Swinburne, Hick, Forman, Aquinas, Teresa, Habermas. Attribute "by their fruits" to Matthew 7:16/20. Report Vivekananda's "science of the soul" as a **claim**.
- **The one sentence to carry into every answer:** every stem here has a **nature** half and an **object** half - answer both, and say whether the object is *encountered* or *realised*.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

The same 25-panel, data-complete flow is also saved as a standalone artifact beside the graphical flowchart package. The designed graphical package is a separate representation and is not a substitute for this text-native one.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/25: The clause, the one question, and the four layers
 SYLLABUS CLAUSE (verbatim): "Religious Experience : Nature and Object (Indian and Western)."
 CENTRAL QUESTION: what does an experience taken to be of the sacred establish, and for whom?

1 PHENOMENOLOGY	2 CLAIMED OBJECT	3 INTERPRETATION	4 EPISTEMIC FORCE
what it is like	what seems given	how a tradition names it	what it justifies, and for whom

THREE ILLEGITIMATE JUMPS

- A 1 -> 4 "it felt overwhelming, therefore it was veridical" (intensity is not warrant)
 - B 3 -> 2 "my tradition names it God, therefore God was met" (naming is not meeting)
 - C 4 <- x "it has a neural correlate, therefore it is nothing" (mediation is not fabrication)
- THREE CAUTIONS: subjective = FIRST-PERSONAL, not unreal | ineffable = resists ADEQUATE expression, not contentless | neural correlate = MEDIATION, not disproof.
- THREE DISTINCT ACHIEVEMENTS: psychological genuineness | doctrinal authenticity | metaphysical veridicality. Winning one does not win the others.
- THE ONE RULE: every stem here has a NATURE half and an OBJECT half. Answer both, and say whether the object is ENCOUNTERED (relation) or REALISED (identity).

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/25: Why the clause exists, and the only datable anchors
 ORIGIN RAIL (conceptual, not calendar)

- 1 a subject reports an experience that seems to present a sacred or ultimate reality
- > 2 the report is FIRST-PERSONAL; its felt certainty is not transferable as it stands
- > 3 the subject's own tradition supplies the concepts that NAME what was met
- > 4 other traditions report INCOMPATIBLE objects with equal conviction
- > 5 a test is demanded, and every candidate test assesses AUTHENTICITY, not existence
- ==> the clause exists because stages 3, 4 and 5 cannot be waved away.

DATED PRINT ANCHORS (assert these years; invent no others)

- 1902 James, The Varieties of Religious Experience (Gifford Lectures 1901-02)
- 1912 Durkheim, The Elementary Forms of Religious Life 1917 Otto, The Idea of the Holy
- 1927 Radhakrishnan, The Hindu View of Life <== the NAMED work in the 2025 stem
- 1957 Zaehner, Mysticism Sacred and Profane 1957 Eliade, The Sacred and the Profane
- 1960 Stace, Mysticism and Philosophy 1971 Rachels, "God and Human Autonomy"
- 1978 Katz, "Language, Epistemology and Mysticism" 1979 Stump, "Petitionary Prayer"
- 1991 Alston, Perceiving God

CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY YEAR: Schleiermacher (The Christian Faith); Swinburne (The Existence of God); Hick (Philosophy of Religion); Forman (The Problem of Pure Consciousness); Aquinas (Summa Theologiae); Teresa of Avila (her criteria of discernment); Habermas (translation proviso); Brhadaranyaka Upanisad 1.4.10; Taittiriya Upanisad 2.4.1; the navadha bhakti list.

ANACHRONISM CONTROL: Otto (1917) answers James (1902); Stace (1960) answers Zaehner (1957); Katz (1978) answers the common core; Forman answers Katz. That order IS the argument.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/25: James I – the marks of mystical states, graded two-plus-two

- ===== DEFINING – these two settle it =====
- (1) INEFFABILITY "defies expression"; must be DIRECTLY experienced; more like a feeling than a proposition; James calls it the "handiest" mark
 - (2) NOETIC QUALITY "states of insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect"; carries a curious sense of AUTHORITY
= experienced insight, NOT independently demonstrated knowledge
- USUAL – present in most cases -----
- (3) TRANSIENCY cannot be sustained long; may RECUR and DEVELOP on recurrence
 - (4) PASSIVITY voluntary preliminaries may facilitate onset; once it sets in the mystic feels GRASPED AND HELD by a superior power

SCOPE: marks of MYSTICAL STATES, not of every religious experience.

AUTHORITY CLAUSE: authoritative for the one who has them; NO authority over outsiders.

==> this is the hinge of the veridicality question; James is not a proof of God.

WHY THE GRADING PAYS: transiency is only usual, so a STABLE, ESTABLISHED liberating knowledge (jnana) still counts as mystical. A flat four-mark list defines the Indian case out.

TRAP: the flat list of four equals is the single commonest error in this clause.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/25: James II – method, medical materialism, fruits, the "MORE"

METHOD: empirical (first-person documents) + pragmatic (consequences) + anti-reductive.

Religion is PERSONAL BEFORE INSTITUTIONAL; theology and church are secondary growths.

x REFUSED TEST – "MEDICAL MATERIALISM" (James's own term, Varieties, Lecture I)

discrediting a state by its physiological or pathological origin

REPLY: causal origin does not by itself settle truth or worth; the same argument would discredit every insight that arrived to a tired or unusual brain.

v ACCEPTED TEST – FRUITS: "by their fruits ye shall know them"

Matthew 7:16/20. James ADOPTS the maxim; he does NOT coin it. <== attribution matters enduring moral integration, courage, charity, transformed conduct

THE OBJECT JAMES ALLOWS HIMSELF: the "MORE" – a wider reality with which the self feels connected THROUGH THE SUBCONSCIOUS. Deliberately under-described, so the psychology does not smuggle in a theology.

OBJECTION: a false belief that makes people kind would be vindicated by the fruits test.
 REPLY: fruits are a criterion of AUTHENTICITY and VALUE, not a deductive proof of the object
 – which is exactly why James cannot function as an argument for God's existence.
 VERDICT SHAPE: strongest as phenomenology and pragmatic assessment; silent on the object.

HEALTHY-MINDEDNESS	religion of the once-born; evil minimised, harmony affirmed
THE SICK SOUL	acute consciousness of evil, guilt and finitude
THE DIVIDED SELF	inner conflict seeking unification
-> CONVERSION	the reorganisation of the divided self: orientation and conduct
SAINTLINESS	the durable moral and affective FRUITS
MYSTICISM	the experiential pole – the four marks of Panel 3

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/25: Otto – the anatomy of the numinous
THE HOLY (das Heilige) splits into

LATIN, WRITTEN IN FULL ONCE: *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* (Otto's own Latin, 1917).
IT IS NOT: fear of a danger (a danger is a comparable thing), nor an intensified moral awe.
PRESUPPOSITION, STATED HONESTLY: that the phenomenological distinctiveness of awe supports a
distinctive OBJECT rather than merely an unusual emotion. That is what the critic denies.

```
>>> NON-RATIONAL is NOT IRRATIONAL <<<
  non-rational = not reducible to conceptual and moral judgement    (Otto CLAIMS this)
  irrational   = contradicting reason                                (Otto DENIES this)
moral and rational predicates are retained as LATER SCHEMATISATIONS of a prior datum
SCHLEIERMACHER, for contrast (The Christian Faith)
  essence of religion = the FEELING OF ABSOLUTE DEPENDENCE
  Otto's implicit correction: dependence is a feeling ABOUT MYSELF; the numinous is
  constituted by DIRECTEDNESS TO A WHOLLY OTHER – it has an object-pole built in.
OBJECTION: psychology can explain awe – evolutionarily, socially, neurologically – without any
  numinous object; Otto has reified a culturally trained emotion.
REPLY: he describes the INTENTIONAL STRUCTURE of the state, and intentionality is a form, not
  an extra feeling. Fear-of-a-tiger is not tiger-flavoured anxiety; it is directed.
BOUNDED: describing a state as object-directed does not show the object exists. Say both halves.
CROSS-CULTURAL LIMIT: Indian traditions often organise the sacred through PURITY and
  AUSPICIOUSNESS (pavitra, suddha, mangala), not through dread. A real limit on Otto's claim.
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EXTROVERTIVE the unifying vision is achieved THROUGH the physical senses; the mystic still sees the multiplicity of objects but perceives the ONE SHINING THROUGH them, with an apprehension of an inner subjectivity or life in all things

INTROVERTIVE ALL sensory and conceptual content is EXCLUDED, leaving a unitary, CONTENTLESS pure consciousness – non-spatial, non-temporal.

Stace regards this as the HIGHER and more complete type.

THE DECISIVE METHODOLOGICAL MOVE

REPLY: The five marks are reported inside the descriptions; the claim then narrows from "identical core" to "recurrent reported marks" – weaker, and more defensible.

a sense of oneness with nature; Zaehner controversially groups certain DRUG-INDUCED states here, IN EXPLICIT OPPOSITION to Aldous Huxley's claims for mescaline

(2) MONISTIC MYSTICISM

isolation or identity of the soul with an IMPERSONAL absolute
– Samkhya-Yoga's aloneness (kaivalya); Advaita's non-dual realisation

(3) THEISTIC MYSTICISM

loving union with a PERSONAL God in which the creature/creator distinction is PRESERVED
– Ramanuja, Sufism, Christian mysticism

!! ZAEHNER RANKS THEM, theistic highest. Widely criticised as CONFESSIONALLY MOTIVATED (he was a Catholic convert). State the criticism – and state what survives it.

WHAT SURVIVES: monistic and theistic reports differ in LOGICAL FORM.

IDENTITY abolishes one term; RELATION requires two. A common-core theory must EXPLAIN that away, not assume it.

EXAM MOVE: KEEP the classification, DROP the ranking.

STACE vs ZAEHNER ARE RIVALS, NOT COMPLEMENTS: 2 types + a core, against 3 types + no core.

ANCHOR: R. C. Zaehner, *Mysticism Sacred and Profane*, 1957.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/25: Mediation – Katz, Forman, attribution and plural mediation

POSITION	CLAIM	PRESSURE ON IT
PERENNIAL CORE (Stace)	traditions interpret a substantially shared core	subtracting "interpretation" may manufacture an abstract sameness
CONSTRUCTIVISM (Katz 1978)	concepts, expectations and practices shape the EXPERIENCE itself	contentless or minimally conceptual states pressure the universal claim
ATTRIBUTION (Proudfoot-style)	an experience is religious partly because the subject explains it religiously	explaining CLASSIFICATION may not exhaust phenomenology or object
PLURAL MEDIATION (Hick)	diverse traditions are culturally conditioned responses to ONE Real	an unknowable Real may be too indeterminate to support specific claims

KATZ'S THESIS, EXACTLY: "there are no unmediated experiences". A Jewish mystic does not have a Buddhist experience differently described; they have DIFFERENT EXPERIENCES.

FORMAN'S REPLY: the PURE CONSCIOUSNESS EVENT – a contentless state has nothing for concepts to shape, so the thesis fails at the introvertive limit Stace called the higher type.

HONEST VERDICT: constructivism is STRONG for extrovertive and theistic reports, WEAKEST for the contentless case – which is exactly where its opponents concentrate.

WHAT IT DEFEATS: the CONVERGENCE INFERENCE, not the occurrence. Mediated perception is still perception; separate OCCURRENCE, INTERPRETATION and VERIDICALITY and argue each on its own.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/25: Advaita – six features, each against its rival

FEATURE	CONTRASTED WITH
1 NON-DUAL (nirvikalpa): subject-object duality collapses	theistic mysticism: an encounter between two terms that both remain
2 IDENTITY, not relation: "I am Brahman" (aham brahmasmi, Brhadaranyaka Up.1.4.10)	Otto's "wholly other"; Ramanuja's loving union which PRESERVES the creature-creator distinction
3 SELF-ESTABLISHED (svatah-siddha): self-luminous consciousness is not established by a further cognition	James's noetic mark, which is FELT authority; Alston's prima facie, defeasible warrant
4 BEYOND OBJECTIFYING SPEECH (avacya): "from which words turn back" (yato vaco nivartante)	ineffability as a mere reporting difficulty; here it is a claim about the STRUCTURE of what is realised
5 BLISS (ananda), beyond the categories of ordinary cognition	emotional ecstasy; ananda is ontological, not a mood
6 STABLE KNOWLEDGE (jnana), not an episode	James's TRANSIENCY – which is why his grading of the marks matters for the comparison

ARGUMENT: subject-object cognition presupposes a WITNESSING consciousness that is never itself an object; scripture (sruti) removes false identification; inquiry ends in recognition.

OBJECTION: a contentless experience cannot identify Brahman.

REPLY: Brahman is SELF, not inferred object; instruction PREPARES a non-objective recognition.

PRICE (name it): the state leaves the space of ordinary evidence, so it cannot be re-entered as public evidence for Brahman. That is what the diversity objection exploits.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/25: Advaita – the route, the image, and the terminological firewall
THE ROUTE

hearing (sravana) -> reflection (manana) -> contemplation (nididhyasana) -> realisation
instruction PREPARES and REMOVES; it does not manufacture an object.

THE IMAGE – THE TENTH MAN

nine men count the party and each forgets to count himself; they grieve for a man who was never lost. Instruction removes IGNORANCE OF AN ALREADY PRESENT FACT.

This is the exact model of how sruti is supposed to work: removal, not production.

STABILITY OVER ECSTASY

it is not a temporary altered state alone; stable knowledge (jnana) matters more than episodic ecstasy. Assessment is SOTERIOLOGICAL: does it remove ignorance and bondage?
 >>> TERMINOLOGICAL FIREWALL <<<
 do NOT call this experience anirvacaniya.
 In Advaita's technical vocabulary anirvacaniya = "indescribable as either real or unreal" (sad-asad-vilaksana) and is the status of MAYA and the WORLD-APPEARANCE – never of Brahman or of Brahman-realisation. A 2025 Religious Language question prints anirvacaniyata in its own proper sense; importing it here is a scripted error.
 OTHER TRAPS: do not write "a subject perceiving Brahman as object"; do not translate ananda as "happiness" or "ecstasy".

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/25: Radhakrishnan – the inversion, three claims, three pressures
 ORDINARY PICTURE RADHAKRISHNAN'S INVERSION (The Hindu View of Life, 1927)
 creed -> practice -> experience EXPERIENCE (anubhava): INTEGRAL INTUITION uniting
 as confirmation cognition, feeling and will; higher than sense and reason because it does not divide subject from object
 |
 v INTERPRETATION by a tradition (concepts, symbols)
 v CREED . RITUAL . INSTITUTION = "secondary"
 v TOLERANCE follows as a CONSEQUENCE: rival creeds are rival readings of a depth none of them owns
 THREE CLAIMS TO NAME THREE PRESSURES TO STATE
 (1) experience is PRIMARY (1) prior to all creeds = correctable by none
 (2) it is SELF-CERTIFYING (2) self-certification is what an outsider cannot check
 (3) it is UNIVERSAL across traditions (3) "one depth, many readings" is itself a substantive metaphysics -> the ADVAITIC ASSIMILATION charge
 DISTINCTION THAT PROTECTS HIM: his "intuition" is NOT a hunch – it is claimed as disciplined, integral and transformative awareness, the product of a practice.
 PRESUPPOSITION: that intuition DISCLOSES REALITY rather than reporting subjective intensity.
 REPLY TO THE CHARGE: universality concerns experiential DEPTH, not identical doctrinal description – and the adequacy of that reply REMAINS CONTESTED. Report the contest.
 2025 STEM DISCIPLINE: name the WORK'S OWN THESES first; evaluate second.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/25: Vedantic plurality – the 2021 stem says "tradition", not "Advaita"
 SANKARA (Advaita) highest realisation = NON-OBJECTIVE RECOGNITION OF IDENTITY;
 subject-object duality belongs to ignorance; Brahman is self-luminous consciousness presupposed by every act of knowing
 RAMANUJA (Visistadvaita) rejects the erasure of difference: Brahman is PERSONAL; selves and world are REAL MODES dependent on God; fulfilment is loving knowledge and communion in which the worshipper is NOT dissolved
 MADHVA (Dvaita) hardens the distinction: God and soul remain ETERNALLY DIFFERENT;
 saving experience is a GRACE-ENABLED RELATION
 ==> Vedanta contains BOTH identity-recognition AND intentional encounter. A script that reduces "the Vedantic tradition" to Advaita has misread the printed word.
 EPISTEMIC STATUS VARIES WITH THE SCHOOL
 Advaita: self-certifying, because self-luminous consciousness needs no second cognition
 Devotional schools: greater weight on scripture, grace and the transformed relation
 COMMON TEST ACROSS ALL SCHOOLS: SOTERIOLOGICAL – does it remove ignorance, egoism, bondage?
 That is what distinguishes Vedantic anubhava from an unregulated private impression.
 OBJECTION: incompatible structures suggest doctrine imposed on ambiguous states.
 REPLY: concede MEDIATION, deny FABRICATION. Each school supplies practice, grammar and tests of transformation – but those criteria are INTERNAL, and internal criteria do not prove the metaphysical object to an outsider.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/25: The Indian experience-types bridge – four structures

TRADITION	EXPERIENCE-STRUCTURE	TERMINUS	CONTROL
ADVAITA	non-dual recognition through hearing, reflection, contemplation	the self AS Brahman	NOT an encounter between two independently existing terms
YOGA	disciplined concentration culminating in seedless absorption and discriminative freedom	isolated consciousness (purusa)	Yoga's special Lord is NOT the creator-object of every experience
DEVOTIONAL (bhakti)	love, surrender, remembrance, prayer and worship	a personal Lord	relation and grace remain REAL – do not redescribe as Advaitic identity
BUDDHISM	meditative insight into impermanence, no-permanent-self and conditioned arising	Dharma / cessation (nirvana) NOT a creator God	noetic and transformative claims remain tradition-mediated; "object" may mislead

FOUR LOGICAL FORMS: identity | isolation | relation | insight.
 THE MARKS ARE IN THE CONTROLS: each blocks a specific misreading – dualising Advaita, theologising Yoga, Advaitising devotion, theologising Buddhism.

PRESSURE ON THE TYPOLOGIES: Zaehner's monistic/theistic pair has no comfortable slot for Buddhist insight; Stace's introvertive type must treat each tradition's own account of its terminus as mere interpretation – which is exactly Katz's objection.

BRIDGE ONLY: meditation stages and liberation doctrine remain with the Paper I owners.

ASCCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 16/25: The object – sacred, holy, God (2018 Q7(a), 20 marks)

EXACT STEM: "The terms 'Sacred' and 'Holy' have come to serve as generic names for the object of religion. Do you agree that one can have God as the object of religion? Discuss."

==> it GRANTS the generic category and asks about the SPECIFIC one. Answer in DEGREES.

WHY 'SACRED/HOLY' BECAME GENERIC

- (1) OTTO the HOLY names a quality of the object disclosed in numinous awe, PRIOR to and independent of moral and rational predicates -> more basic than "God"
- (2) DURKHEIM (1912) the SACRED defined RELATIONALLY, by separation from the profane and by the prohibitions that protect it -> needs no deity; covers totemic religion
- (3) ELIADE (1957) HIEROPHANY: the sacred manifests and structures sacred space and time
- (4) DECISIVE non-theistic religions have a sacred but NO God: nirvana and the Dharma; the Tirthankara and the siddha; the authorless (apauruseya) Veda; the Tao

THE GRADED ANSWER

YES for theistic traditions – classical theism, Visistadvaita, Saiva Siddhanta, Islam, Judaism – where God is not one sacred item but the SOURCE AND MEASURE of holiness

NO as a generic definition – that would stipulate Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa out of religion. ==> 'SACRED' IS THE GENUS; GOD IS THEISM'S SPECIES OF IT.

DISCRIMINATOR THAT EARNS MARKS: Otto's HOLY is NOT Durkheim's SACRED. Phenomenological quality of an object vs social classification. Treating them as one word misses the strongest objection to each.

INDIAN PARITY: pavitra/suddha, mangala, punya, tirtha, ksetra, devalaya; parvan days, muhurta, the ritual calendar; the Veda's sanctity as apauruseya – SANCTITY WITHOUT A SANCTIFIER.

OBJ 1 over-breadth (flags, nations) -> REPLY add the SOTERIOLOGICAL requirement

OBJ 2 God subordinated to a genus -> REPLY the subordination is CONCEPTUAL, not ontological

ASCCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/25: Veridicality – the warrant ledger and the burden clause FOR VERIDICALITY

CREDULITY (Swinburne): if it SEEMS to S that X is present, probably X is – absent defeaters

TESTIMONY: others' reports are probably as reported – extends warrant to the HEARER

NOETIC QUALITY: the state presents itself as disclosure, not as imagination

CONVERGENCE: mystics across traditions report recurrent marks

AGAINST – DEFEATERS

(a) NATURALISTIC EXPLANATION: Freud's projection and wish-fulfilment; social and psychological formation; neural mediation

>>> BURDEN: the critic must show the mechanism is UNRELIABLE, or that it FULLY explains the seeming WITHOUT the proposed object. A correlation alone is not a defeat. <<<

(b) UNRELIABLE CONDITIONS: drugs, pathology, suggestion, deprivation

(c) DIVERSITY <= THE SERIOUS ONE: personal God / non-dual Brahman / emptiness reported with equal conviction. Which object is real?

FOUR CRITICISMS AND THEIR REPLIES

naturalism -> origin does not by itself falsify content; defeaters must show unreliability

conflicting -> interpretation may vary while contact is common

objects REJOINDER: this reply can become UNFALSIFIABLE

ineffability -> limits exhaustiveness, not every statement; analogical report survives

moral fruits -> a criterion of AUTHENTICITY, not a deductive proof of the object

RANKING (this is what earns the top band): naturalism is the LOUDEST and WEAKEST defeater; diversity is the QUIETEST and STRONGEST, because it needs only incompatibility.

BALANCE TO WRITE: prima facie warrant for the SUBJECT + testimonial weight for the HEARER - public demonstration of the OBJECT. "Causal explanation and epistemic defeat differ."

ASCCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 18/25: Alston – six steps, the exact conclusion, and the concession

(1) THEORY OF APPEARING: perception = something PRESENTING ITSELF; sensory content is not essential to that structure, so a non-sensory presentation can still be perception

(2) MYSTICAL PERCEPTION SHARES THE STRUCTURE: apparent object + mode of presentation + resulting belief ==> M-BELIEFS (from mystical perception)

(3) BELIEFS ARE FORMED WITHIN DOXASTIC PRACTICES: socially established, internally organised, with their own inputs, outputs and OVERRIDE procedures

(4) NO DOXASTIC PRACTICE CAN BE SHOWN RELIABLE WITHOUT CIRCULARITY: sense perception cannot be validated except by using sense perception; likewise memory and induction

(5) WE ARE NONETHELESS PRACTICALLY RATIONAL in engaging in sense perception

(6) THEREFORE engagement in an established religious practice (Christian Mystical Practice, CMP) is PRACTICALLY RATIONAL, absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable

CLAIMED: prima facie justification for M-beliefs; PRACTICAL RATIONALITY of engagement

NOT CLAIMED: proof that the practice is reliable; ultima facie justification

>>> "Alston proved religious experience reliable" is the standard overstatement. <<<

ILLUSTRATION: a novice cannot show sense perception reliable without already relying on it; the demand for non-circular validation, uniformly applied, destroys ALL our practices.

DIVERSITY OBJECTION – WHICH ALSTON HIMSELF CALLS THE MOST SERIOUS: CMP, Buddhist, Advaitic and Islamic practices are each established and self-supporting; if that makes engagement rational, it makes engagement in INCOMPATIBLE practices rational.

HIS ANSWER: it is rational to "SIT TIGHT" absent a neutral adjudicating ground – conceding the discomfort and that a better argument might overturn it. An honest answer stops there.
 SECOND OBJECTION: no cross-checking, prediction or intersubjective agreement.
 REPLY: CMP has internal OVERRIDE SYSTEMS – discernment criteria, doctrinal tests, spiritual direction – weaker than science's, but not absent.
 DISTINGUISH FROM SWINBURNE: credulity is about SEEMINGS; Alston's argument is about PRACTICES.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/25: Diversity – the defeater, the three exits, and the price
 THE DATA: personal God (relation) | non-dual Brahman (identity) | emptiness and cessation (no such term) | isolated consciousness (withdrawal) – all reported with equal conviction
 THE DEFEATER: apply the principle of credulity EVENLY and it licenses INCOMPATIBLE conclusions.
 So either the principle is restricted (on what principled ground?) or some seemings are non-veridical (which ones, and by what test?).
 EXIT 1 HICK – PLURAL MEDIATION: one Real an sich, experienced through culturally conditioned lenses. PRICE: a Real beyond all determinate description cannot ground the DETERMINATE claims traditions make; and the reply can become UNFALSIFIABLE.
 EXIT 2 EXCLUSIVISM: one is right, the rest mistaken. Bites the bullet; owes an account of the others' sincerity, discipline and fruits.
 EXIT 3 CONSTRUCTIVISM (Katz): they are DIFFERENT EXPERIENCES, not one differently described.
 THE THREE-WAY SPLIT THAT SCORES
 Did something occur? diversity is SILENT; the reports stand
 How was it interpreted? diversity is DECISIVE; interpretation is tradition-relative
 Was it veridical? diversity is a GENUINE DEFEATER; incompatible objects cannot all be met
 OBJECTION: diversity would equally defeat ordinary perception, where observers also disagree.
 REPLY: the disanalogy is PROCEDURAL. Perceivers can move closer, measure, repeat, ask a third party. Religious practices have INTERNAL override systems but no CROSS-PRACTICE adjudicating procedure. Nothing in the practice is designed to settle disagreement ACROSS practices.
 SAFE RESIDUE: claim FAMILY RESEMBLANCE or ANALOGOUS TRANSFORMATION, not identity of content.
 BOUNDARY: complete pluralist theory belongs to the Religious Pluralism owner.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 20/25: Mystical experience and revelation (2023 Q8(c), 15 marks)

	REVELATION CLAIMED	NO REVELATION CLAIMED
MYSTICAL STATE PRESENT	(1) VEHICLE CASE: the state is received AS disclosure of the Real; Hick's non-propositional model; "experiencing-as"	(2) PURE EXPERIENCE CASE: a unitive or numinous state reported with NO claim to disclose a message or a will
NO MYSTICAL STATE	(3) PROPOSITIONAL CASE: truths delivered through prophet, text or tradition, with no unitive state involved	(4) NEITHER

CELLS (2) AND (3) PROVE NON-IDENTITY. If mystical experience WERE revelation, (2) would be impossible; if revelation WERE mystical experience, (3) would be impossible. Both occur.
 RELATION: VEHICLE to CARGO. The state can CARRY a disclosure without BEING one.
 SIGNIFICANCE IN RELIGIOUS LIFE (the second printed deliverable) – three functions
 ORIGIN founders' disclosures generate traditions and supply their normative content
 RENEWAL later mystics re-authenticate the tradition from within
 RISK an unchecked private disclosure can override community, scripture and moral judgement ==> hence DISCERNMENT (Teresa's criteria; the guru's testing)
 INDIAN PARALLEL, BOUNDED: sruti removes ignorance while realisation is the cognitive event – instruction to insight, not message to messenger.
 OBJECTION: if revelation is what the receiver takes the event to be, disclosure collapses into projection. REPLY: the distinction is preserved by DISCERNMENT, not by phenomenology – and discernment tests AUTHENTICITY, not truth.
 BOUNDARY: faith's RECEPTION of revelation belongs to the Reason, Revelation and Faith owner.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 21/25: Prayer and worship (2020 Q7(b), 15 marks)

AXIS	PRAYER	WORSHIP
Essential act	ADDRESS / communication	AScription OF SUPREME WORTH (homage)
Direction	person-to-person (I-Thou)	creature-before-the-holy
Form	verbal or silent; spontaneous	ritual, embodied, rule-governed
Locus	often private	characteristically corporate
Presupposes	a God who can HEAR and RESPOND	a reality of supreme value; RESPONSE NOT REQUIRED
Non-theistic avail.	strained	available

OVERLAP: ADORATION – address (prayer) AND ascription of worth (worship).
 LIMIT CASE: wordless contemplative prayer – address persists after request disappears.
 KINDS OF PRAYER: A-C-T-S = Adoration, Confession, Thanksgiving, Supplication (+ intercession, contemplative prayer).
 PROBLEM 1 – PETITION: omniscient (already knows) + perfectly good (will already do the best)

+ immutable (cannot be changed) ==> petition is idle or manipulative.
 AQUINAS: we pray to OBTAIN WHAT GOD HAS DETERMINED SHALL BE OBTAINED THROUGH PRAYER – a genuine SECONDARY CAUSE inside the causal order, not an override of the primary one.
 STUMP (1979): asking PROTECTS THE RELATIONSHIP; unrequested benefaction from an overwhelming superior risks spoiling the recipient. RESIDUE: justifies petition's VALUE, not that outcomes causally depend on it.
 PROBLEM 2 – WORSHIP AND AUTONOMY, RACHELS (1971): worship entails unconditional obedience; moral agency forbids abdicating final judgement; so nothing could be WORTHY OF WORSHIP.
 REPLIES: worship recognises WORTH, not blind obedience | a perfectly good being's commands coincide with moral judgement | the autonomy assumed is atomistic.
 THREE INDIAN CASES THAT DECIDE IT
 JAINISM the Tirthankara is free of passion (vitaraga) and CANNOT RESPOND; image-veneration (caitya-vandana) = worship without any possibility of petition being answered
 MIMAMSA efficacy lies in the unseen potency (apurva); the deity is a GRAMMATICAL DATIVE in the injunction, not an agent who grants
 ADVAITA contemplative worship (upasana) of a qualified form is efficacious at the everyday level (vyavaharika) and is TRANSCENDED, not repudiated, at the ultimate level
 BUDDHISM ritual honour (puja) is commemorative and dispositional (Pure Land complicates it)
 PLACEMENT: prayer = RELATIONAL organ; worship = EVALUATIVE and COMMUNAL organ.
 A religion can survive the loss of petition; NONE survives the loss of worship, because nothing would then mark the ultimate as ultimate.
 VERDICT FORMULA: prayer presupposes a RESPONSIVE ultimate; worship presupposes only a SUPREMELY VALUABLE one.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 22/25: Public discourse (2019 Q7(c), 15 marks) – the ladder and the line
 THE EXACT QUESTION: not "is religious experience real?" but "HOW FAR can it be made a topic of public discourse?" ==> a DEGREE is required, never a yes/no.

CASE FOR NO

- (1) INEFFABILITY resists the articulation discourse requires
- (2) PRIVILEGED ACCESS – James concedes authority only for the one who has the state
- (3) NO SHARED CHECKING PROCEDURE, unlike perception
- (4) WITTGENSTEIN's private-language considerations: a wholly private criterion is none
- (5) RAWLSIAN PUBLIC REASON: for coercive decisions, offer reasons others could accept

CASE FOR YES – SIX INTERSUBJECTIVE CRITERIA (ascending publicity)

- (1) PHENOMENOLOGICAL DESCRIPTION – James, Otto, Stace, Zaehner built public typologies out of first-person documents: PUBLIC WORK ON PRIVATE DATA. Even ineffability is reportable.
- (2) COHERENCE – internally consistent, and consistent with what is otherwise known
- (3) DISCERNMENT NORMS – Teresa of Avila's criteria; the guru's verification; the acarya's testing
- (4) MORAL AND PRACTICAL FRUITS – transformation of conduct is OBSERVABLE
- (5) REPLICABILITY THROUGH DISCIPLINED PRACTICE – yoga, dhyana, nididhyasana: repeatable procedures with stated preconditions and predicted outcomes. Vivekananda and Radhakrishnan press this as an "experimental" CLAIM.
 LIMIT: the experiment cannot be run by an uncommitted observer -> closer to the training-dependence of EXPERT PERCEPTION than to a public laboratory test.
- (6) ALSTON'S DOXASTIC PRACTICES – legitimate topic of PUBLIC ARGUMENT ABOUT PRACTICES, if not of public verification of episodes

===== THE LINE =====

All six are publicly assessable and test AUTHENTICITY. None transfers the EVIDENTIAL FORCE the experience has for its subject. CONCEDE THIS EXPLICITLY – the concession earns marks.

=====

BRIDGE – HABERMAS: religious citizens may speak religiously in the INFORMAL public sphere, subject to an institutional TRANSLATION PROVISO before formal state decision-making.

=> the "how far" gets a determinate answer: FULLY in the informal sphere, CONDITIONALLY in the formal one.

VERDICT: publicly DISCUSSABLE and privately PROBATIVE – not publicly demonstrative.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 23/25: The parity bench and the ten-row risk column

AXIS	WESTERN	INDIAN	DISCRIMINATING POINT
STRUCTURE	encounter/union with an Other (Otto, theistic mysticism)	IDENTITY-recognition (Advaita) or ISOLATION (Samkhya-Yoga)	relation vs identity is a LOGICAL, not a stylistic difference
DURATION	transient (usual mark)	jnana is STABLE and ESTABLISHED	why James's GRADING of the marks matters
METHOD	grace, contemplation, sacrament	disciplined, staged, repeatable	India's REPLICABILITY claim in the 2019 question
AUTHORITY	for the SUBJECT only (James)	svatah-siddha, but tested by guru and sruti	both restrict transfer; India adds discernment
OBJECT-TERM	God, the Holy, the numinous	Brahman, purusa, nirvana, the Tirthankara	the generic term must be "SACRED", not "God"
RITUAL	prayer, sacrament, liturgy	upasana, puja, japa, dhyana	Jain and Mimamsa worship WITHOUT a responsive deity

TEN ACCOUNTS AND THEIR CHARACTERISTIC RISK (the risk column IS the assessment)

James	mystical, transformative	the "MORE"	RISK subjectivism
Otto	numinous awe	Holy/wholly other	RISK reification of emotion
Schleiermacher	feeling of dependence	the Infinite	RISK subject-centred account
Stace	extrovertive/introvertive	the One	RISK interpretation does all work
Zaehner	nature/monistic/theistic	three objects	RISK confessional ranking
Alston	perceptual (M-perception)	God, presented	RISK diversity of practices
Advaita	non-dual recognition	Brahman as self	RISK content/criterion problem
Radhakrishnan	integral intuition	the Spirit/Real	RISK Advaitic assimilation
Theistic myst.	union/communion	personal God	RISK conflict with non-dual reports
Buddhism	insight/awakening	nirvana, no creator	RISK "object" category misleads
Durkheim/Eliade	socially structured	the SACRED	RISK over-breadth

RULE: match ONE axis to the stem and run it to its discriminating point. One axis used precisely beats six axes listed.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 24/25: PYQ routing and the directive decoder

THE CLAUSE OWNS EXACTLY ONE PART IN EVERY PAPER, 2018-2025 (8 of 112 parts overall)

2018 Q7(a) 20m 'Sacred' and 'Holy' as generic names; can one have God as the object?

2019 Q7(c) 15m How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse?

2020 Q7(b) 15m Distinguish prayer and worship and determine their place in religion.

2021 Q7(c) 15m Religious experience in the light of the Vedantic tradition.

2022 Q7(c) 15m Nature and variety of religious experiences as presented by William James.

2023 Q8(c) 15m Relation between mystical experience and revelation, and their significance.

2024 Q8(c) 15m Main features of religious experience according to Advaita Vedanta.

2025 Q8(a) 20m Nature and object of Religious Experience per Radhakrishnan, The Hindu View of Life.

DIRECTIVES AND WHAT EACH BUYS

"Do you agree...? Discuss"	-> a graded position on the PRINTED proposition
"How far...? Analyse"	-> a DEGREE, and the exact line you draw
"Distinguish A and B and determine"	-> TWO deliverables; half on each
"in the light of [tradition]"	-> tradition-internal categories, and its INTERNAL plurality
"nature and variety ... [thinker]"	-> the graded MARKS and the TYPOLOGY
"Examine the relation ... expound"	-> relation FIRST, then significance
"main features of X"	-> an enumerated list, each feature with a discriminator
"Evaluate ... in [named work]"	-> the work's own theses first, assessment second

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 25/25: Architectures, verdict ladder and the answer spine

ARCHITECTURES

10m define -> structured marks -> object -> ONE objection -> limited verdict

15m nature/object -> account and presupposition -> canonical example -> Indian/Western contrast -> veridicality objection and reply

20m phenomenology -> claimed object -> warrant (credulity/testimony/fruits) -> naturalistic AND diversity defeaters -> Indian-Western comparison -> graded verdict + THE DEFEATER THAT WOULD CHANGE IT

VERDICT LADDER

Weak ~40% flat four marks; Otto mentioned; no object-analysis, no veridicality question

Avg ~50% marks + numinous + Advaita, correct terms, but marks ungraded

Good ~60% nature/object separated; one epistemic objection raised

Strong ~65-70% graded marks; identity-vs-relation; credulity and defeaters; Indian parity

Top ~70%+ + a discriminating distinction (defining vs usual | Otto's holy != Durkheim's sacred | constructivism vs the Pure Consciousness Event | prima facie vs ultima facie) + a statement of the defeater that would change the verdict

THE ANSWER SPINE

name the LAYER -> define the experience -> state the account with its DECISIVE discrimination

-> identify the CLAIMED OBJECT and say encountered or realised -> apply credulity, testimony and the defeaters -> run ONE Indian-Western axis to its discriminating point -> strongest objection, named -> reply -> GRADED VERDICT + the defeater that would overturn it.

CLOSE: religious experience confers prima facie, defeasible justification on the subject and testimonial weight on the hearer; it does not establish its object publicly. Diversity, not neurology, is the serious defeater – causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things.